Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Genesis

Genesis 1:1

- In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth: This statement summarizes the entire creation story (1:3–2:3). It answers the key question: Who created the world? (see also Proverbs 8:22–31; John 1:1–3). Genesis affirms God's role and purpose in creation.
- The common Hebrew name for God is ʾelohim. This name shows that God has supreme power over all things.

The word ʾelohim is plural in form. However, it usually takes singular verbs. This shows that the Bible teaches there is one all-powerful God.

- created (Hebrew bara'): In the Old Testament, when this verb is used, God is always the one creating. It describes the act of making something new, such as:
- the heavens and the earth (1:1, 21; 2:3),
- humans (1:27),
- the nation of Israel (Isaiah 43:1), and
- the future new creation (Isaiah 65:17).
- the heavens and the earth: This phrase means the whole ordered universe (cosmos).

Genesis 1:1–2.3

- These verses introduce the Pentateuch (the first five books of the Bible). They teach Israel that one true God created, ordered, and populated the world, not the gods of nearby nations.
- God blessed three specific things:
- animal life (1:22–25),
- human life (1:27), and
- the Sabbath day (2:3).

These three blessings emphasize the Creator's plan. God made humans in his image to rule in his place over earth's creatures and to join in God's Sabbath rest.

Genesis 1:2

- This verse provides context for the summary in 1:1 and the detailed description in 1:3–2:3. God's words of creation bring order to the universe's chaos.
- formless and void (Hebrew tohu and bohu): This phrase means something like "wild and waste." It strongly contrasts with the final ordered state of the heavens and earth (1:1).
- surface of the deep (Hebrew pene tehom): Some scholars suggest this refers to the Mesopotamian goddess Tiamat (representing chaos). But Genesis sees tehom as empty chaos, not as a deity or goddess that God fought in a cosmic battle.
- the Spirit of God: God directly guided and oversaw the process of creation.

Genesis 1:3

- And God said: God created everything in chapter 1 by his powerful word (compare Psalm 33:6, 9).
- "Let there be ... and there was": God's command put his will into action to create the world. God is not part of creation or limited by it. He supremely rules over everything (see Nehemiah 9:6).

Genesis 1:3–13

In the first three days, God shaped the formless world into a place where people and animals could live.

Genesis 1:4

Light is the opposite of chaotic darkness (1:2). God considers light to be good, but not darkness (John 1:5). God is the source of this light (Genesis 1:14–19). God separated light, just like he separated water (1:6–8), using his word that creates. Light is associated with life and blessings (Job 38:19–20; Psalms 19:1–6; 97:11; 104:19–20; Isaiah 60:19–20). It limits the darkness that could destroy cosmic order.

Darkness often represents fear, death, and evil (Genesis 15:12; Job 18:6, 18; Psalm 88:12; Ephesians 5:11–12; 1 John 1:5).

Genesis 1:5

- God called (or named): Naming something shows authority over it (see also 2:19–20).
- day: The Hebrew word yom can mean:
- daylight (1:5a),
- a 24-hour period (1:5b), or
- an unspecified time (2:4b, "when," literally in the day; compare Exodus 20:8–11).
- evening ... morning: The Hebrew day started at sundown. This was like the first day that began with darkness and led to morning light.

Genesis 1:6–8

The creation story describes how things appear from a human perspective. The sky looks like a shiny dome separating two groups of water (see Job 37:18; Ezekiel

1:22). In the ancient Near East, people understood the universe to have three levels, with rain coming from the highest level (see Genesis 7:11–12 and study note).

Genesis 1:9–10

Let the waters ... be gathered into one place: Other ancient cultures considered the sea to be a hostile force. Genesis shows God further controlling chaos by setting specific boundaries for the sea (see study note on 1:2). The flood was an act of God's judgment (6:7). It removed these boundaries and returned the earth to chaos (7:1–24).

Genesis 1:14

let them ... mark the seasons and days and years: The movement of the heavenly objects ordered Israel's liturgical calendar. This calendar, rooted in creation, provided sacred timing for Israel's festivals and celebrations (see Exodus 23:15; Leviticus 23:4).

Genesis 1:14–31

On days four through six, God filled the domains that had been formed during days one through three (1:3–13).

Genesis 1:16

- In the surrounding pagan cultures, people worshiped the sun and moon as gods. But in Genesis, they serve God and humanity (see Psalm 136:7–9; Jeremiah 31:35).

Here, this verse does not name the sun and moon. They are simply called the greater light and the lesser light. Not naming them may have reminded Israel that they were not gods.

- rule: Compare 1:26, 28; Psalm 136:9.
- the stars: The stars bear witness to God's power to create, and they declare his glory (Psalms 19:1; 148:3). They do not predict the future, as Israel's neighbors believed (see Jeremiah 10:2).

Genesis 1:21

Unlike pagan beliefs that the great sea creatures existed from the beginning along with God, the Bible teaches that God created them. God has complete power and authority over them. The Hebrew word tanninim ("sea creatures") can also refer to:

- crocodiles (Ezekiel 29:3),
- powerful monsters (Jeremiah 51:34), or
- the sea creature Leviathan (Isaiah 27:1; compare Job 41:1–34).

Genesis 1:22

- God blessed them: This blessing orders and enables them to do what God has said (see "Blessing" Theme Note).
- fill the waters of the seas ... let the birds multiply on the earth: These instructions explain the blessing. The fish and birds can reproduce because of God's command. It is not through pagan ceremonies, as some of Israel's neighbors believed.

Genesis 1:26

- Let Us make: This statement is more personal than the earlier command, "Let there be" (for example, 1:3, 6).
- Us: The use of the plural pronoun here has several possible explanations:

1. It may refer to the Trinity (one God who exists forever in three persons).
2. It may be a plural form used to show God's greatness.
3. It may describe God speaking to himself (a kind of inner council).
4. It may describe God speaking with his heavenly court (angels).

The idea of the Trinity was revealed later in the Bible. Because of this, it is unlikely that the human author meant that here.

Many Hebrew scholars do not accept the idea that this is a plural used to show God's greatness. The grammar does not clearly support that view.

The idea that God is speaking to himself also lacks clear evidence. The only similar examples refer to Israel as a group (for example, 2 Samuel 24:14).

However, the Old Testament often shows God speaking to his heavenly court (angels). This idea has strong support (see Genesis 3:22; 11:7; 1 Kings 22:19–22; Job 1:6–12; 2:1–6; 38:7; Psalm 89:5–6; Isaiah 6:1–8; Daniel 10:12–13).

- in Our image, after Our likeness: These phrases mean almost the same thing in Hebrew. Humans have a special relationship with God.
- to rule: Humans represent the Creator as his ambassadors and his delegated rulers on earth.

Genesis 1:27

- The first poetry of Genesis celebrates God's ultimate achievement in creating humans.
- man: This term (Hebrew ha-'adam) often refers to all of humanity (see 6:1, 5–7; 9:5–6). Although tradi-

tionally translated as "man," it includes both male and female.

Genesis 1:28

- God blessed them: See study note on 1:22; also see 17:16; 48:16; Deuteronomy 7:13.
- said: God speaks directly and intimately to humans. We are caretakers of his shared authority.
- subdue it; rule: As representatives of God's rule, humans are responsible for taking care of the world God created and managing it (see also Genesis 9:2; Psalm 8:5–8).

Genesis 1:29–30

These verses emphasize how God provides for humans, animals, and birds all over the earth. He gives every seed-bearing plant and every tree whose fruit contains seed.

Genesis 1:31

The creator calls his work good seven times in chapter 1. After creating humans, God says it is all very good.

Genesis 2:1–3

Humans are the most important of God's creation (1:26–31), and day 7 is the most important of the creation week. When God rested, he approved all creation. There was nothing more needed! This seven-day framework structured Israel's week.

The seventh day was the model for their weekly Sabbath. God intended for the Sabbath to celebrate his completed work. God set apart the seventh day as holy. The people dedicated it to the Creator, who also rested on this day (see Exodus 20:8–11; 31:12–17; compare Matthew 12:1–8; Romans 14:5–6; Colossians 2:16–17; Hebrews 4:1–11).

Genesis 2:3

- During the first six days of creation, God separated light from darkness, day from night, and water from dry land. The final act of creation separated the ordinary from the holy. This was the basis for Israel's worship. It also anticipated a future time of rest (Hebrews 4:1–11; 12:2; 13:14).
- The lack of the usual "evening ... morning" phrase shows the creator's desire for endless fellowship with humans.

Genesis 2:4

- This is the account (literally These are the generations; Hebrew toledoth): This phrase appears often in Genesis. It helps outline the book. It usually introduces the family line or story of an important person (5:1; 6:9; 10:1; 11:10, 27; 25:12, 19; 36:1; 37:2).

Some people think the first part of 2:4 belongs with 1:1–2:3, but it probably introduces the next story.

- LORD God (Hebrew Yahweh Elohim): This is the second name for God in Genesis. Elohim (1:1–2:3) refers to the all-powerful creator God. Yahweh Elohim refers to the eternal God who made a lasting covenant with Israel (Exodus 3:6, 13–15). So, Genesis 2:4–25 focuses on God as a provider more than as a creator.

The three themes of sexuality, dominion, and food in chapter 1 are now in reverse order (food, 2:8–17; dominion, 2:18–20; sexuality, 2:21–25).

Genesis 2:4–25

This story (see study note on 2:4) of the heavens and the earth is not a second creation story. Instead, it expands on 1:1–2:3 with more theological and historical details. The focus shifts to what the universe (kosmos) produced rather than on its creation.

Special attention is given to the first man and woman. As the story continues, it is shaped by contrasts such as good and evil, knowledge and ignorance, life and death, and harmony and conflict.

Genesis 2:5

Work does not result from sin. It was part of creation's original design. It has a close link to human identity and purpose (1:28; 2:15).

Genesis 2:6

springs: The word refers to underground water that rises up to the surface of the ground.

Genesis 2:7

- In 1:1–2:3, creation happens by God's command ("Let there be ... And it was so"). This story describes a more personal process of creation (see also 2:8–9, 21–22).
- from the dust of the ground: In Hebrew, 'adamah means "ground." This forms a wordplay on 'adam, which means "man." The earth is a key reference point for humans, who become dust again at death (3:17–19; 4:11; Job 4:19; 10:8–9; Isaiah 29:16).
- breathed the breath of life into his nostrils: God gives his breath only to humans, not to other animals. God made humans in his image (Genesis 1:27) and only they can communicate with their Creator

(2:16–17; 3:8–13). They are the only ones with spiritual awareness and a moral conscience (see Job 32:8).

Genesis 2:8

- Eden was the general location in which the garden was placed, not the garden itself. The term could mean "plain," "delight," or "fertility." The description that follows suggests the idea of fertility.
- in the east: The exact location of Eden is unknown. But it was east of Canaan, which later became Israel's home.
- God placed the man in the garden to have a relationship with him and to receive his physical blessings (see also 2:15 and study note there).

Genesis 2:8–14

Similar to the holy time set on the seventh day of creation (2:2–3), the garden in Eden was a holy place separate from the rest of the world. It was like a garden-temple or sanctuary because the Lord showed his presence there in a special way.

Genesis 2:9

- Beauty and abundance characterized humanity's original environment (see 13:10).
- the tree of life: This represented God's presence and care. Eating from it would give everlasting life (3:22), making it a powerful image for later Israelite and Christian thought (Proverbs 3:18; 11:30; 13:12; Revelation 2:7; 22:2, 14, 19).

The candlestick in Israel's tabernacle may have been a stylized representation of the tree of life (Exodus 25:31–35).

- Eating the fruit from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil gave humans the ability to be wise (Genesis 3:6) and have moral understanding (3:5, 22; compare Deuteronomy 1:39, "not know good from evil").

Eating from it showed a human desire to be independent and have wisdom that belonged to God alone (see Proverbs 30:1–4). Humans ignored God's instruction for moral understanding, showing independence instead of following God's will (compare Proverbs 1:7). Choosing human wisdom over God's instruction brings death and destruction (see Psalm 19:7–9; Ezekiel 28:6, 15–17).

Genesis 2:10

- The river that watered the garden was a physical blessing, bringing fertile land for farming. It also represented God's presence (compare Psalm 46:4; Ezekiel 47:1–12; Zechariah 14:8; Revelation 22:1–2).
- branched into four headwaters: The common understanding is that one river had its source in Eden, flowed down through the garden, and then split into the four rivers named.

Genesis 2:10–14

This description portrays the eastern region around Eden as a mountain with rivers flowing out to the world. Eden's beauty and fertility enriched the entire earth.

Genesis 2:11

The Pishon and the Gihon (2:13) cannot be identified with certainty. If the land of Havilah was in southeast Arabia or on the African coast, as some biblical data suggest (see 10:7; 25:18; 1 Samuel 15:7), then the Pishon was possibly the Nile River. The Jewish historian Josephus thought that Havilah and the Pishon were in India (Antiquities 1.1.3).

Two other ideas suggest the Pishon and Gihon might be:

1. rivers in the mountains of eastern Turkey, where the Tigris and Euphrates (Genesis 2:14) also flow, and
2. the marshy delta near the Persian Gulf.

Current geographical conditions make it impossible to prove any theory with certainty.

Genesis 2:12

- The garden's beauty and richness spread to nearby areas through its rivers. The four rivers might suggest the garden's bounty reached all parts of the world.
- The Israelites later used gold and onyx to decorate the tabernacle, the temple (Exodus 25:3–9; 1 Chronicles 29:2), and the priests' clothing (Exodus 28:9–14, 20).
- The people used bdellium (a fragrant resin) in sacred incense (Exodus 30:34).

Genesis 2:13

- Gihon: The exact location is unknown, but some think it could be the Nile River or the Jordan River (as in the Greek version of Jeremiah 2:18; Josephus, Antiquities 1.1.3). Or according to Jewish tradition, it could be a river that once flowed through the Kidron Valley (1 Kings 1:33; 2 Chronicles 33:14).
- Although Cush often refers to ancient Ethiopia, the immediate setting here seems to be a region in Mesopotamia connected with Babylon (see 10:8).

Cush may refer to the land of the Kassites, a people who ruled in Babylonia.

Genesis 2:14

Tigris ... Euphrates: These well-known rivers flow from the mountains of eastern Turkey.

Genesis 2:15

to cultivate and keep it: The garden needed care and management. Caring for the garden was humanity's honorable work. The Scriptures later apply these roles in God's garden-sanctuary to his tabernacle (see Leviticus 8:35; Numbers 3:5–10; 4:46–49).

Genesis 2:17

- but you must not eat: This rule is given in the same way as Israel's Ten Commandments (see Exodus 20:1–17; Deuteronomy 5:6–21). The Lord included law and obedience in his covenant with humanity.
- the knowledge of good and evil: See study note on 2:9.
- you will surely die: Disobedience would bring immediate spiritual death (loss of relationship with God) and eventual physical death (see 3:22–23; Ecclesiastes 12:6–7).

Genesis 2:18

- It is not good: This is God's first negative comment about an otherwise good creation (1:31). The Lord God is like a father finding a bride for his son (compare chapter 24).
- The solution for the man's need is a helper who is perfect for him. She is his ideal partner. God made her in the same image of God (1:26–27), gave her the same mission (1:28; 2:15), and gave her the same rule (2:17). The man cannot achieve his purpose alone.

Genesis 2:18–23

Human creation was the most important part of chapter 1, and human intimacy is the highlight of chapter 2. God's focus on mutual support and companionship among humans is unique in ancient Near Eastern writings.

Genesis 2:19–20

to see what he would name each one: Following God's example (1:5, 8, 10), the man named each creature. By doing this, he showed his authority over creation (1:26, 28).

Genesis 2:23

- Adam recognized the woman as his "suitable helper" (2:20). He celebrated their unity through poetry and song, focusing on their connection, not their differences (compare 29:14).
- "she shall be called 'woman,' for out of man she was taken": Adam understood their connection (see Ephesians 5:28–29). Earlier, Adam looked at the animals but did not find a suitable partner. This evaluation is very different!

Genesis 2:24

- Marriage between a man and a woman is not only a human idea. It comes from the natural order.
- a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife: Marriage involves shifting loyalty from parents to a spouse.
- they will become one flesh: Marriage and its commitments make it the most basic covenant among people. Marriage is a powerful image of Israel's covenant with God (Hosea 2:14–23) and of Christ's relationship to the Church (Ephesians 5:22–32). God designed marriage to be a permanent, exclusive relationship between a man and a woman. The family it creates is the foundation of human society.

Genesis 2:25

both naked: Before the first humans disobeyed God (chapter 3), being naked showed innocence and trust. After this, it came to show vulnerability and shame (see 9:22–23; Leviticus 18:1–23; Isaiah 47:3). Shame is more than embarrassment. It can include being exposed, mistreated, or humiliated (see Deuteronomy 28:48; Isaiah 58:7; James 2:15–16).

Genesis 3:1

- Genesis describes the deceiver as a serpent, one of the animals God created (see also 3:14 and study note). Scripture later identifies him as Satan, the great enemy of God's people (Revelation 12:9; 20:2). He used manipulative language and disguised himself as a serpent. The serpent was the most clever of all creatures. This showed Satan as a master deceiver.

Satan uses different methods to oppose God's people (see 1 Chronicles 21:1; Zechariah 3:1–2). Deception remains one of his main strategies (compare 2 Corinthians 11:3, 14).

The Hebrew word for crafty is 'arum. It can have a positive meaning ("prudent," Proverbs 14:8) or a negative meaning (as here; see Job 5:12). Here it forms a wordplay with "naked" (Hebrew 'arummim) in Genesis

2:25. Adam and Eve were naked and vulnerable. The serpent was crafty and cunning.

- The serpent probably asked the woman because God gave Adam the rule before he created Eve (see 2:16–17). Adam was probably aware of the serpent's craftiness, since he had named all the animals before God created Eve (2:19–20, 23).
- Did God really say: The deceiver started by twisting God's words to make the people doubt God's goodness. God's original rule applied to only one tree (2:16–17), not to all of them.

Genesis 3:1–24

When the man and woman rebelled against God, it disrupted their harmony with the earth, animals, each other, and God.

Genesis 3:2–3

The woman tried to clarify things. But in several ways, she made the privileges God gave her and her husband seem less important:

1. She changed God's words from "freely eat" (2:16) to may eat.
2. She minimized the importance of having fruit from every tree except one (2:17).
3. She added not touching to God's rule against eating (2:17).
4. She made the threat of death seem less certain (2:17).

Genesis 3:4–5

You will not surely die: This directly contradicts God's clear and emphatic words: "you will surely die" (2:17). The serpent takes advantage of the woman's doubt. He denies there will be any penalty and quickly shifts her focus to the supposed reward. He says she will become like God, knowing good and evil.

The deceiver falsely implies that this would be totally beneficial for them. The term used for God is Elohim. It can also mean "divine beings," such as God and the angels (for example, Psalms 29:1; 89:7).

Genesis 3:6

- She saw ... that it was desirable: The woman made two serious mistakes:

1. She assumed she could decide what was good or bad. But God is the only one who has the right to decide what is good or bad.
2. She coveted God's wisdom, meaning she strongly desired something that did not belong to her (see Deuteronomy 5:21).

- her husband who was with her: Scripture highlights the woman's role in humanity's first sin (compare 1 Timothy 2:14). But, the man was also present and responsible. He becomes the focus in the following verses and in biblical teaching. His sin brought serious consequences for all people. The good news is that through Jesus Christ, the "second Adam," God offers salvation to everyone (Romans 5:12–21).

Genesis 3:7

- Shame is the opposite of the naked innocence Adam and Eve enjoyed before they disobeyed God (2:25). This damaged their relationship with each other and God.
- sewed together fig leaves: These covered their bodies but not their shame. They could not fix their broken relationships (see also 3:21 and study note).

Genesis 3:8

- in the garden in the breeze of the day: Traditionally, the Hebrew text refers to the cool part of the day, probably the evening. Some believe it describes a powerful appearance of God's presence (a theophany; see Exodus 19:16–25; 1 Samuel 7:10) as a storm. If this is true, the man and woman hid from the sound of the Lord appearing in judgment (see 2 Samuel 5:24; Psalm 29).
- God placed the trees of the garden for humans to enjoy fellowship with him. Now, the man and woman used them to hide from God.

Genesis 3:9–10

- Where are you?: The man's answer shows the real purpose of this question (3:10). The real meaning of the question was, "Why are you hiding?" (compare 4:9–10).
- I was afraid because I was naked: Modesty was not the problem. The shame from their rebellion made Adam and his wife hide. They might have also feared punishment (see study note on 3:8).

Genesis 3:12

The woman whom You gave me: The man avoided admitting his sin. He blamed the woman for giving him the fruit and blamed God for giving him the woman.

Genesis 3:13

- What is this you have done?: This question is not asked to get information. It is an expression of shock and horror (see 4:10).
- The serpent deceived me: The man blamed the woman (3:12), and the woman blamed the serpent.

The serpent did play a role and would be punished (3:14). But this did not free the woman or the man from their guilt.

Genesis 3:14

- to the serpent: Though later revelation identifies the deceiver as Satan, it is the created animal who was cursed, like the ground (3:17).
- On your belly will you go, and dust you will eat: Groveling in the dust shows humiliation and defeat (Psalm 72:9; Micah 7:17).

Genesis 3:14–19

God judged the serpent, woman, and man because of their sin. Each received a punishment specific to their actions. Their important relationships changed. God is fair in judgment, not unpredictable. Each punishment matches the sin.

Genesis 3:15

- enmity: The prophet Isaiah looks ahead to a future when the Messiah's kingdom will restore all creation to peace, like the garden of Eden before humans disobeyed God (see Isaiah 11:8).
- her seed (or offspring): This term can refer to a single descendant or many. In ancient Near Eastern culture, "you and your offspring" (see Genesis 28:14) describes a shared identity. Here, it describes ongoing hostility between humans and snakes.

The pattern is set using singular terms (He ... you). Christian interpreters have traditionally understood this verse to be a prophecy about Christ. He is the seed of Abraham and fulfills the promise of the woman's seed (see Galatians 3:16; 4:4).

- strike: This refers to the suffering of God's servant (see Isaiah 53). Crushing the serpent's head is a more decisive action. The death, resurrection, and final victory of Jesus over Satan fulfill this promise (see 1 Corinthians 15:55–57; Revelation 12:7–9; 20:7–10).

Genesis 3:16

- The judgment affects the woman's special role in childbearing and her relationship with her husband.
- Your desire will be for your husband, and he will rule over you: The marriage relationship now includes conflict instead of only security and happiness. New life in Jesus can restore a man and woman's marriage relationship (Ephesians 5:18–32; compare Matthew 20:25–28).

Genesis 3:17–19

- God emphasized his first command not to eat the fruit by mentioning eating several times in 3:17–19. The judgment made it harder for humans to get food. This matched their sin of eating what God had forbidden.
- cursed is the ground: The man's relationship with the ground (see study note on 2:7) became hostile as judgment affected his main role (2:5, 15). He must work hard to cultivate the ground, but with less success than before. Human sin impacts all of creation (see 4:12; 6:7; Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 11:13–17, 28; Romans 8:22).

Genesis 3:20

The name Eve (Hebrew khawah) sounds like the word khayah, which means "to give life." After God announced Adam's future death (3:19), Adam showed hope by naming Eve with a name related to life. Adam named Eve soon after 3:16. Some understand this to show that Adam's act of naming the woman reflects his role and responsibility in the relationship after they sinned (see study note on 2:19–20).

Genesis 3:20–24

Soon after they were judged for their sin, Adam and Eve were banished from the garden.

Genesis 3:21

God showed mercy and gave Adam and Eve better clothing (compare 3:7) before sending them into the harsh world outside the garden.

Genesis 3:22

- like one of Us: The plural likely shows God speaking with his heavenly court of angels (see study note on 1:26).
- the tree of life ... live forever: God showed mercy by preventing the humans from eating from the tree of life and living forever in a sinful condition. But through Jesus Christ, eternal life is available again (see Revelation 2:7; 22:2, 14, 19).

Genesis 3:23

Therefore the LORD God banished him from the Garden of Eden: Before humans disobeyed God, the garden was a sanctuary where humans could be in God's holy presence. Now their sin meant God had to expel them from that place. This same idea also influenced Israel's laws. The laws limited the access Israelites had to God in the tabernacle or temple (for example, Leviticus 16:1–2; Numbers 5:3).

Genesis 3:24

- Cherubim are a type of angel that guard access to God's presence (Exodus 26:31; Ezekiel 28:14).
- east ... of Eden: In Genesis, moving east often means leaving God's presence or blessing. This can happen because of:
- judgment (Genesis 4:16),
- human pride or independence (Genesis 11:2; Genesis 13:11), or
- separation from the family (Genesis 25:6).

Genesis 4:1

- had relations (literally knew): In some contexts, the Hebrew word meaning "to know" is a way to describe having sexual relations with someone (4:17; 19:33, 35). It is never used for animals, which mate by instinct.
- With the help of the LORD: Eve fulfilled her God-given role of having children despite the negative effects of sin (see 3:16, 20).
- I have brought forth a man: Cain (Hebrew qayin) sounds like a Hebrew word (qanah) that can mean "produce" or "acquire."

Genesis 4:2

Cain's brother Abel: The name "Abel" may come from the Hebrew word habel, meaning "breath," "vapor," or "meaningless." This might hint at Abel's tragically short life (compare Ecclesiastes 1:2). Alternatively, it may come from the Akkadian word ablu, meaning "son."

Genesis 4:3

There was nothing wrong with offering grain to the Lord (Leviticus 2:14; Deuteronomy 26:2–4). But Cain only gave a small portion of his crops. God requires the first and best (Exodus 23:16, 19; 34:22, 26). Cain's attitude made his offering less valuable than Abel's (Hebrews 11:4). So, God did not accept Cain's offering.

Genesis 4:4–5

the best portions of the firstborn of his flock (or the firstborn of his flock and their fat portions): Abel gave God the best animals and their richest parts. Unlike Cain, Abel offered the best he had. True worship is a costly privilege.

Genesis 4:7

sin is crouching at your door ... you must master it: Sin is like a wild animal ready to attack Cain (see study note on 3:16). Either sin will control Cain, or Cain will fight against the urge to sin. There is no middle ground in this struggle.

Genesis 4:8

- The impact of the sin on human relationships is tragically shown in the first murder.
- The word brother appears seven times in 4:2–11, emphasizing Cain's act of killing his brother despite responsibility to one's family.

Genesis 4:9

Where is your brother?: The questions God asked Cain (4:6, 9, 10) remind us of those God asked Cain's parents (3:9–13). In both situations, humans answered by avoiding the truth (compare 3:12–13). It is surprising how defiant Cain's answer is. This suggests that his attitude was the real problem with his offering.

Genesis 4:10

- What have you done?: This is more an expression of horror and blame than a question seeking answers (see 3:13).
- Abel's blood acts as a legal witness that accuses Cain of a crime.
- from the ground: See study note on 4:11–12.

Genesis 4:11–12

- Like his father (see 3:9–12, 17–19), God asked Cain questions before he judged him (4:9–10). Adam's sin had already caused the ground to be cursed. Now Cain was cursed and driven away from the land he had farmed because he had polluted it with innocent blood.
- a fugitive and a wanderer: God sentenced Cain to endless wandering in a land that offered neither food nor safety. The consequences of sin were becoming worse.

Genesis 4:13–14

For Cain, being driven from the land (the place where he worked as a farmer; see 4:2; compare 3:23) meant being separated from God's presence. God warned the Israelites to remain faithful to the Sinai covenant. If not, he would force them to leave the promised land. This would also mean separation from God's presence in the temple (see, for example, Leviticus 26:27–32).

Genesis 4:15

- Sevenfold punishment was the full weight of justice. Cain complained that his punishment was too harsh. But the severe sentence for anyone who killed Cain

shows how gracious the Lord was to him. Cain deserved death (see 9:5–6).
- The mark graciously provided protection to Cain after God's judgment (compare 3:21).

Genesis 4:16

- The name Nod (which means "wandering") describes Cain's fate (see 4:12, 14) more than a specific place. It suggests a life of wandering, and its exact location is unknown. Cain's sin denied him rest and a sense of belonging.
- Cain's exile east of Eden is another point of connection with Adam's story (compare 3:24). Cain did not learn from his father's sin, so he also experienced separation from the ground and was driven east into exile (see study note on 3:24).

Genesis 4:17

- Cain's wife was probably one of his sisters (5:4). Cain's marriage to his sister would not have caused genetic problems so early in the development of the human gene pool.
- God condemned Cain to be a wanderer. He might have built a city to rebel against this punishment, using walls for protection. Naming the city after his son shows how people who rebel against God often make humanity and its achievements into idols.

Genesis 4:17–5.32

These records of family lines do more than just list names. They contrast how human culture developed. Some people rebelled against God (Cain, 4:17–24), while others obeyed God (Seth, 4:25–5:32). Genesis usually explains the history of the rejected line before continuing with the promised line that became Israel.

Two key contrasts are worth noting:

1. Lamech is the main focus of the first family history. He is the seventh man from Adam through Cain's line. Like Cain, Lamech killed a human and lived in fear of death as a result (4:23–24). In contrast, Enoch lived in a way that pleased God and did not experience death (5:24). Enoch was the seventh man from Adam through Seth's line (4:25–5:32).
2. Human culture and technology advanced through Cain's line. They made the first city, raised livestock, built shelters, developed metal work, and created music. But sin still strongly shaped human life. Seth's line does not have any technological advances mentioned. Instead, people began "to call upon the name of the LORD" (4:26) and "found favor in the eyes of the Lord" (6:8).

Genesis 4:18

father of: This can also mean "ancestor of," and this meaning applies throughout the verse. Hebrew family lists do not always include every generation.

Genesis 4:19

Marrying two women was against God's ideal pattern for marriage (2:24). It might also show the pride and rebellion of Cain's descendants.

Genesis 4:20–22

New tools and skills can hide a growing desire for people to rely on themselves instead of God. They can also show that people are moving farther away from God (see study note on 4:17–5:32).

Genesis 4:23–24

- Lamech's disturbing boast shows how sin's impact on humanity has increased. Cain's descendants reached an extreme of violence with Lamech's contempt for human life. In his arrogance, he turned his actions into a poem.
- avenged ... seventy-sevenfold: God warned that anyone who tried to kill Cain would experience total justice (4:15). Lamech claimed that anyone who harmed him would face an even more severe penalty. This shows he felt accountable to no one, not even God.

Genesis 4:25

another seed in place of Abel: Cain (4:8–16) and Lamech (4:19–24) show the consequences of sin. The birth of Seth brought new hope. See also study note on 5:1–2.

Genesis 4:25–5.32

The story returns to Adam and follows the line of Seth. This family line later leads to Abraham and the nation of Israel.

Genesis 4:26

Enosh means "humankind." In the Old Testament, this term often appears in poems emphasizing human mortality and weakness (for example, Psalm 144:3, "what is man").

Enosh was born when people started to worship the Lord by name (literally call upon the name of the LORD). In Genesis, this meant worshiping the Lord through sacrifice and prayer (similar Hebrew terms are found in Genesis 12:8; 13:4; 21:33; 26:25).

Genesis 5:1

- the book of the generations: The earlier section (2:4–4:26) focused on Adam, Eve, and their first children. But it was more about "the account of the heavens and the earth." Genesis 5:1–32 is a more typical family line.
- in His own likeness: See 1:26 and study note.

Genesis 5:1–2

This section introduces the second account in Genesis (5:1–6:8; see study note on 2:4). It connects God's purpose in creation with the line of Seth rather than the line of Cain (4:17–24).

Genesis 5:1–32

The family lines in Genesis do more than record history. They use select details and structure to communicate spiritual truths. These genealogies show God's blessings. They confirm the family heritage of key people. They connect the Genesis story by showing family continuity.

Adam's family line through Seth records ten generations to Noah (see 1 Chronicles 1:1–4; Luke 3:36–38). The great flood occurred before another 10 generations from Noah to Abram. The number 10 symbolizes completeness. Examples include the 10 plagues (Exodus 7:8–11:10) and the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:2–17). Noah ended the pre-flood history, and Abram began a new era.

Genesis 5:2

- Male and female ... "man" (Hebrew 'adam): See 1:27 and study note.
- blessed them: See 1:28 and study note.

Genesis 5:3

in his own likeness, after his own image: The image and likeness of God continue to exist in all human beings even after sin entered the world (see note on 1:26). When Adam had children, they carried both the image of God and the effects of Adam's sin (Romans 5:12–14).

Genesis 5:5

he died: Adam died (see 2:17; 3:18–19) and so did his descendants (see Romans 5:12–14).

The Bible does not mention Cain's violent actions here (see Genesis 4:8, 15, 23–24). Important figures in Seth's family line live in hope (see 5:29).

Genesis 5:6

the father of: This can also mean "ancestor of." Hebrew family lists do not always list every generation.

Genesis 5:22

Enoch walked with God (also in 5:24): Enoch, the seventh man from Adam in the family line, contrasts with Lamech, the seventh man from Adam in Cain's family line (see study note on 4:17–5:32).

Genesis 5:24

Unlike other sons of Adam, Enoch did not die. Instead, he disappeared because God took him away (compare 2 Kings 2:9–12 and Hebrews 11:5).

Genesis 5:27

969 years: This statement and the numbers given in 5:25, 28, and 7:6 mean that Methuselah died the same year as the great flood.

Genesis 5:28–29

Like Enoch (5:21–24), the typical family line pattern is interrupted to share key theological details about Noah.

The name Noah sounds like the Hebrew words nakham, which means "relief" or "comfort," and nuakh, which means "rest." Noah was the first person born after Adam died (see study note on 5:5). His father, Lamech, hoped Noah would undo the curse caused by Adam's sin (3:17). See 8:21; 2 Corinthians 1:3–7; 2 Thessalonians 2:16–17.

Genesis 6:1–2

The sons of God have generally been understood as fallen angels (or demons). The main interpretation of the phrase seems to refer to demons. The same Hebrew phrase is in Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7; Psalms 29:1; 89:7. This idea appears often in ancient Jewish and Christian writings (for example, 1 Enoch 6:1–7:6; Justin Martyr, Apology 2.5). The New Testament also seems to support this view in some passages (see 1 Peter 3:18–20; 2 Peter 2:4; Jude 1:6–7).

Some interpreters argue that God would not allow angels to have children with humans. They doubt that the New Testament texts should be understood in this way.

Another possibility is that the phrase the sons of God refers to the righteous descendants of Seth. The beautiful women would be from Cain's evil line. This matches Genesis 4:17–5:32 but is weakened by the

language of 6:1–2. That passage seems to refer to all human daughters, not just Cain's.

Others believe the phrase the sons of God refers to cruel human kings. These kings were possibly influenced by demons. They followed Lamech's practice of having multiple wives and made it even worse (4:19) by seizing the daughters of righteous people. The language is similar to 3:6 ("saw ... took"). It shows the rebellious nature of their actions.

Genesis 6:1–8

Human wickedness became very great, so God sent the flood to destroy all living things. But there is a sign of hope, because God showed favor to Noah (6:8).

Genesis 6:3

- will not contend with: Many think that this is an announcement of God's decision to withdraw the restraining influence of his Spirit from human society and allow human wickedness to fully develop. Others think it means God would take away his life-giving breath from humans at an earlier age. The Hebrew word ruakh can mean both "spirit" and "breath"(see 6:17; 7:22; see also Psalm 104:29–30).
- his days shall be 120 years: This might be a new limit on how long people could live. But after the great flood, people lived longer than 120 years (see, for example, Genesis 11:10–26).

Or, this might refer to a 120-year period of grace before the great flood (see Jonah 3:4; Matthew 24:37–38; 1 Peter 3:20; 2 Peter 2:5).

Genesis 6:4

The Nephilim: This term might mean "fallen ones." The context suggests they were the children of the sons of God and God would destroy them in the great flood. Numbers 13:31–33 uses the same term for other giants who opposed God's people and would also be destroyed. Deuteronomy 2:11 connects the Anakite nephilim with another group called the Rephaim (Hebrew repa'im).

Genesis 6:5

- every inclination of the thoughts of his heart: In the Old Testament, the heart is the center of choice, thought, and morality (see Proverbs 4:23). Wicked actions come from a corrupt inner life.
- altogether evil all the time: Strong language shows how widespread, deep, and persistent human evil is. Humanity remained corrupt even after the great flood (see Genesis 8:21).

Genesis 6:6

- The LORD regretted: Because humans had become so evil, the Lord regretted creating them (see also 6:7; compare 1 Samuel 15:11, 35).
- He was grieved in his heart: The evil in people's hearts caused God great sadness (Genesis 6:5). Sending the flood brought deep grief to God.

Genesis 6:7

- blot out ... from the ... earth: Just as God expelled Adam and Eve from the garden-sanctuary (3:23), God would remove all humans from his good creation.
- every man and beast and crawling creature and bird of the air: Human sin had so damaged the earth that animals and birds, over which humans had control, faced judgment (see 1:28 and study note). Humans have a special role in creation (1:28–30), so human moral decisions influence creation (see 8:1; Job 38:41; Hosea 4:3; Romans 8:19–22).

Genesis 6:8

Noah lived a godly life, which was very different from the sinful lives of the rest of humanity.

Genesis 6:9

- the account: See study note on 2:4
- a righteous man, blameless in his generation: The text does not say Noah was without sin (see Romans 5:12–14). Noah was righteous and blameless because he had a close relationship with God. See also Genesis 7:1; 17:1; Hebrews 11:7.

Genesis 6:11–13

- See Genesis 6:5–7.
- violence: The Hebrew word here is khamas. Murder had greatly corrupted Cain's descendants (4:8, 23–24).

Genesis 6:14

- ark: This was a long rectangular boat built for survival, not navigation. The Hebrew word tebah is the same for the basket that carried baby Moses on the Nile River (Exodus 2:3, 5).
- gopher wood: It is not clear what kind of wood this was. It may have come from a conifer (a tree like cypress).

Genesis 6:15

The ark was so large that when it floated, it likely pushed aside about 43,300 tons of water. This is similar to how much water a modern large cargo ship moves aside when it floats.

Genesis 6:16

- A gap of about 46 centimeters (18 inches) below the roof went around the boat. This allowed light and air to enter the boat.
- God told Noah to build a door, and God would close it (Genesis 7:16). God was the captain of this unique boat, which had no sail or rudder. God also brought the animals to Noah (Genesis 6:20).

Genesis 6:17

will bring floodwaters upon the earth: Some scholars suggest the great flood might have only covered the ancient Near East, as known to Noah or Moses. But the flood's purpose was to destroy every living thing that breathes (see also 6:7, 11–13; 7:1, 4, 18–23; 8:21). It was also intended to undo creation (see study notes on 1:9–10; 7:11–12). This suggests the great flood covered the entire planet (see also 1 Peter 3:20; 2 Peter 2:5; 3:6).

Genesis 6:18

This is the first clear mention of a covenant (a formal and binding agreement) in the Bible. It refers to a promise that God made on his own with people and with all the earth after the great flood (see 9:9, 11, 14–17).

Genesis 6:19–20

- every kind: God's instructions to Noah repeat the language of creation (compare 1:24, "according to their kinds").
- male and a female: These animals would reproduce and repopulate the earth again after the great flood.

Genesis 7:2

every kind of clean animal: There were animals meant to repopulate the earth. There were also these ceremonially clean animals for food and for Noah's sacrifice after the flood (8:20–21).

This passage does not use the specific terms found in the rules about ceremonially clean and unclean animals given to Israel at Mount Sinai (see Leviticus 11; Deuteronomy 14:3–12). But the basic idea is the same. It could be that God explained it directly to Noah.

Genesis 7:4

The number forty is often connected with times of testing, hardship, or judgment (see Exodus 16:35; Judges 13:1; 1 Kings 19:8; Ezekiel 4:6; Jonah 3:4; Matthew 4:2; Acts 1:3).

Genesis 7:6

came upon the earth: See study note on 6:17 for more information.

Genesis 7:8

See the study note on 7:2.

Genesis 7:11–12

- on the seventeenth day of the second month: This specific detail gives the flood account a sense of seriousness. It shows that the event is presented as something that happened in history.
- fountains of the great deep: See 2:6.
- the floodgates of the heavens were opened: The great flood undid the boundaries established on the second and third days of creation (1:6–13). Other parts of the Bible describe God's judgment as undoing creation (see Jeremiah 4:23–26; Amos 7:4).
- forty days and forty nights: See study note on 7:4.

Genesis 7:16

the LORD shut him in: This showed that God was in control. He protected the people inside the ark and punished those who remained outside (see also 6:16 and study note).

Genesis 7:17

- the waters rose (literally waters multiplied): This is the same word used for the increase of humans and animals during creation (see 1:22, 28). Now, ironically, the story uses this word for the water that would destroy them.
- high above the earth: The Hebrew word translated as "ground" or "earth" appears eight times in eight verses (7:17–24). The great flood was now cleansing the earth, which humans had polluted.

Genesis 7:22

every living thing: See study note on 6:17.

Genesis 8:1

- God remembered: This key part of the great flood story does not mean God ever forgot Noah. It uses covenant language to show God's faithfulness to his promise to keep his covenant partner safe (see 6:18; 9:15–16; Exodus 2:24; Leviticus 26:42, 45).
- wind: The same Hebrew word is translated as "Spirit" in Genesis 1:2. This and other similarities suggest that restoring the earth after the great flood was like a new creation (see Genesis 9:1–2).

Genesis 8:2

The springs of the deep and the floodgates of the heavens: See study note on 7:11–12.

Genesis 8:4

The mountains of Ararat might be in the region of Ararat (Urartu), southeast of the Black Sea near Lake Van. This area borders parts of eastern Turkey, Armenia, and Iran. There is a Mount Ararat (Agri Dag) in Turkey, but this verse only identifies the region, not a specific mountain.

Genesis 8:5

the waters continued to recede: This is another similarity to the creation week (see 1:9). This suggests that restoring the earth was like a new creation (see study note on 8:1).

Genesis 8:7

The raven is the biggest bird in the crow family and in Noah's time the raven was considered ceremonially unclean (Leviticus 11:15; Deuteronomy 14:14). As a scavenger that eats dead animals, it could survive without returning to the boat.

Genesis 8:11

Unlike the raven (8:7), the dove eats plants. Olive trees are short, so Noah knew the water was almost gone.

Genesis 8:13

In Noah's six hundred and first year, on the first day of the first month: This was two months after the mountain peaks first appeared (8:5).

Genesis 8:14

the earth was fully dry: This word for dry land is often used with the sea to show God's rule over both land and sea (see 1:9–10; Exodus 14:22, 29; Psalm 95:5; Jonah 1:9).

Genesis 8:17

be fruitful and multiply: See 9:1.

Genesis 8:20

- This first mention of an altar in the Bible shows how thankful Noah was for surviving the judgment.
- offered burnt offerings: The same wording is used for the whole burnt offering in Leviticus (Leviticus 1:3–9), but it can refer to any offering that is burned. Noah gave this offering to thank and worship God, who saved him and his family from the great flood.

Genesis 8:21

- smelled the pleasing aroma: The narrator uses anthropomorphic language (he describes God's activity in human terms) to show God's acceptance of Noah's offering (see also Exodus 29:18; Leviticus 1:9; Numbers 15:3). In the ancient Near East, people often believed that their gods ate the sacrifices offered to them. This idea is not found in the Bible.
- in his heart: This is the same phrase as in 6:6. In the same way, here every inclination of his heart echoes "every inclination of the thoughts of his heart" (6:5). God's commitment to a new order replaced his grief over the old.
- Never again will I curse ... destroy: The old curse remained (5:29), but God promised not to add to it. He set new limits for life in a chaotic world (compare Isaiah 54:9). The flood was meant to stop violence, not to change the human heart (the inner thoughts and desires that lead people to do wrong; Genesis 6:5). Human beings have a tendency toward evil, but this would be limited to some degree by a new law that holds people responsible for their actions (9:5–6).

Genesis 8:22

God's promise to sustain the rhythm of the seasons reaffirmed the created order (1:14; see also Jeremiah 33:20; Zechariah 14:7).

Genesis 9:1

Be fruitful and multiply: This blessing and command, first given to Adam (1:28), God now gives again to Noah. He is the "Adam" of the newly cleansed world in need of repopulation.

Genesis 9:1–7

God's first speech after the great flood starts and ends with a blessing (9:1, 7). In this speech, God explains again how humans and animals relate to each other, with some changes from the original creation. God gives special attention to the value of life (the importance of protecting human life).

Genesis 9:2–3

There are two changes to the original order of creation:

1. Before the flood, humans ruled over the animals (1:28). After the flood, animals would fear humans. This uses language often connected with military victory (see Exodus 23:27–31, Deuteronomy 11:25; 31:8).

2. This fear is connected to a change in human diet. Humans were now allowed to eat animal meat, in addition to grains, fruits, and vegetables (Genesis 1:29).

Genesis 9:4

God gives an important restriction. Blood represents life (it stands for life), so it had to be drained from an animal before its meat could be eaten (see Leviticus 3:17; 7:26–27; 17:10–14; Deuteronomy 12:16, 23).

The Law of Moses also forbade eating animals that died naturally, because their blood had not been drained (Deuteronomy 14:21). God provided animal blood to atone for human sin (Leviticus 17:11; Hebrews 9:22).

Genesis 9:5–6

Violence, including murder, was a major factor in bringing about God's judgment of the flood (4:8; 6:11, 13). At this new beginning for human beings, God affirmed the value of human life (that human life is sacred) and established justice for those who take a human life (see also Psalm 9:12; "Retribution" Theme Note).

The function of law is to restrain human wickedness and preserve moral order. This law was further developed in the law of Moses (Exodus 21:12–14; Leviticus 24:17–22; Numbers 35:16–34; Deuteronomy 17:6–7; 19:15).

Genesis 9:6

for in His own image God has made mankind: God made human beings in his own image. That is why this passage gives a theological reason for the death penalty in the Old Testament. Human beings have a unique place in creation because they bear God's image (1:26–28). If someone murders another person, that person destroys a life that reflects God in a special way. Because of that, the murderer must receive the highest penalty. See also Exodus 21:23–25.

This does not mean people should take revenge for themselves (Romans 12:17–19). Instead, God has given governing authorities the duty to carry out justice (Romans 13:1–7).

Genesis 9:7

be fruitful and multiply; spread out (literally swarm and fill): In contrast to those who would destroy human life (9:5–6), God wants human life to grow and flourish.

Genesis 9:8–17

In God's second speech after the great flood, he promises to protect and preserve creation.

Genesis 9:9–10

God had promised this covenant before great flood (6:18). It includes not only people, but also the earth and all animals.

Genesis 9:11

This promise does not prohibit worldwide judgment, but it restricts the means by which God will do it (see 2 Peter 3:4–13).

Genesis 9:12

In the Bible, covenants are frequently confirmed by some sort of sign (for example, 17:11; Exodus 31:13, 17; Luke 22:20).

Genesis 9:13–16

- God brought great judgment through the rainstorm (a very large and destructive storm). Now he gives the rainbow as a sign of peace for the whole earth (see 9:17). The rainbow appears after the rainstorm and is connected to it, but it now shows that God will not destroy the earth in this way again.
- The same Hebrew word can mean both "rainbow" and "bow" (a weapon used in war). In some places, God is described as a warrior who shoots arrows to bring judgment (see Deuteronomy 32:42; Psalms 7:12; 18:13–14; Habakkuk 3:9–11). Because of this, some interpreters think the picture in Genesis 9:13–17 shows God hanging up his bow. This means he is putting aside his weapon of judgment and choosing peace instead.

Genesis 9:18

Ham was the father of Canaan: See also 9:20–27; 10:6–20. The text repeats this idea to show a connection between Canaan and Ham. It explains that the people of Canaan came from Ham's family line.

This connection also points back to Ham's shameful act (a serious dishonor) in 9:20–27. Because of this, the identity of the Canaanites is closely tied to that event.

The people of Egypt (where Israel lived as slaves) and the people of Canaan (the land Israel later entered) both came from Ham's descendants (10:6; see Leviticus 18:3, 24–26; Psalms 105:23, 27; 106:22).

Later stories in Genesis describe moral failure (wrong behavior) in both places. Egypt is shown this way

(Genesis 12:10–20) and Canaan (34:1–31; 38:1–30; see 9:20–27 and 10:6–20).

Genesis 9:20–27

The story of Noah begins with him walking in righteousness and obeying the Lord (6:9). It ends with him drunk and naked in his tent, cursing Canaan. Even after the great flood, people still showed sinful behaviors that led to the flood.

The text emphasizes the cursed origin of the Canaanites, a corrupt and idol-worshiping group. Israel would later remove them from the promised land (see also 15:16 and study note; Leviticus 18:3; 20:23).

Genesis 9:21

wine ... became drunk: Wine is a gift from God (Deuteronomy 14:26; Psalm 104:15; Isaiah 55:1; see Luke 22:14–20; John 2:1–11). Scripture clearly teaches that drinking too much alcohol is a dangerous sin (Proverbs 23:20–21, 29–35; 1 Corinthians 6:10).

Genesis 9:22

- the father of Canaan: See study note on 9:18.
- Ham's behavior was shameful. He looked at his father's nakedness and did not cover him. Instead, he told his brothers and took away his father's honor (see Exodus 21:15, 17; Lamentations 4:21; Habakkuk 2:15).

An ancient Near Eastern story says that a son is expected to come to his father's aid when he is drunk (Tale of Aqhat; compare Isaiah 51:17–18). Ham did not do his duty to his family. Because of this, Noah blessed Shem and Japheth but cursed Ham (Genesis 9:24–27).

Genesis 9:25

Cursed be Canaan!: Noah understood that Ham's actions showed the character of his descendants through Canaan.

Genesis 9:26

Noah refers to God as the LORD, who made a covenant with Israel. Shem became the ancestor of the people of Israel (see 10:21–32).

Genesis 9:27

may he dwell in the tents of Shem: Japheth's descendants would live among Shem's descendants and share Shem's prosperity (compare Romans 11:17–18).

Genesis 10:1

who also had sons after the flood: This fulfilled the renewed command of creation to populate the earth (9:1, 9; compare 1:28).

Genesis 10:1–11.9

The fifth account (10:1) in Genesis (see study note on 2:4) unites the Table of Nations (10:2–32) and the Babel story (11:1–9) around the theme of scattering the nations (10:5, 18; 11:4, 8–9). The Table of Nations appears before the Babel story, but the Babel event explains how the nations and languages in that list came to exist.

By placing these events in this order, Genesis connects the filling of the earth with the blessing God gave to Noah and his sons (see 9:1 and study note). It shows that the growth of the nations comes from God's blessing.

This order also prepares for Abram's call (12:1–3). Abram's call shows God's answer to the problem seen at Babel (11:1–9), where humans were separated from God. Through Abram, God begins to restore that relationship.

Genesis 10:2

- The seven sons of Japheth settled in the region of Anatolia (the western plateau lands of Turkey) and spoke Indo-European languages.
- Gomer was the ancestor of the Cimmerians, who lived north of the Black Sea.
- Magog probably was the ancestor of those who settled in Lydia (see Ezekiel 38:2).
- The descendants of Madai became the Medes of northwest Iran (see 2 Kings 17:6; Jeremiah 51:11; Daniel 5:28).
- The descendants of Javan were the Ionian Greeks.
- The descendants of Tubal and Meshech were sometimes allies in battle (Ezekiel 38:2). They probably came from Anatolia's coastal regions (see Ezekiel 27:13).
- The descendants of Tiras possibly became the Thracians living near the Aegean Sea.

Genesis 10:2–32

- This section explains where the ancient Near Eastern nations came from. Ham was at the center (10:6–20)while the descendants of Japheth and Shem spread out to the surrounding regions of Greece, Crete, Asia Minor, Mesopotamia, Madai, the Arabian peninsula, and northeast Africa.

The list is selective in focusing on nations important to Israel. The 70 names (seven times ten) indicate completeness (see 46:27; Deuteronomy 32:8). These names represent the whole world, which Abraham's descendants would later bless (Genesis 18:18).

- Although Shem is mentioned first in 10:1, he is addressed last in the Table because of his connection to Abram (10:21–31; 11:10–32; 12:1). Although God established the boundaries of all nations (see Deuteronomy 32:8; Amos 9:7; Acts 17:26), Israel was his special creation (a small group of 70 people; Genesis 46:27). God called them to be a blessing to a world of 70 nations (see 12:3).

Genesis 10:3

- The descendants of Gomer came from the area near the upper Euphrates, north of the Black Sea (see Ezekiel 38:1–9).
- The descendants of Ashkenaz were the Scythians, who lived between the Black and Caspian Seas.
- Riphath is near Carchemish.
- The descendants of Togarmah are associated with Til-garimmu. This is the capital of Kammanu in what is now Armenia (see Ezekiel 38:6).

Genesis 10:4

- Elishah is probably Cyprus.
- Tarshish might be southwest Spain (see study note on Jonah 1:3).
- The Kittites lived in southern Cyprus.
- The Rodanites lived on the island of Rhodes, which later became part of Greece.

Genesis 10:5

- maritime peoples ... into their territories: These were seafaring people who settled around the Mediterranean Sea and on different islands.
- languages: This happened after the tower of Babel story (11:1–9; see study note on 10:1–11:9).

Genesis 10:6

- The peoples descended from Ham's four sons (Egyptians, Babylonians, Assyrians, Canaanites) were Israel's most hostile neighbors.
- Cush might have been in Ethiopia or ancient Nubia (northern Sudan).
- Mizraim was the old name for Egypt (50:11).
- Put was in Libya.
- Canaan included southern Syria, Phoenicia, and Palestine west of the Jordan River. In the time of Moses, Egypt and Canaan were part of the same empire. Ham's descendants did not receive the blessing given to Shem's family line (9:20–28).

Genesis 10:7

- The sons of Cush and Raamah add up to seven in total.
- Seba was in northern Africa (see Isaiah 43:3; 45:14).
- Havilah was in southwest Arabia.
- Sabtah was in southern Arabia, in ancient Hadramaut, near the Persian Gulf.
- Raamah was in southwest Arabia near Najran.
- Sabteca was in ancient Samudake near the Persian Gulf.
- Sheba was a kingdom in southwest Arabia with trading colonies (see 1 Kings 10:1–29).
- Dedan was in northern Arabia.

Genesis 10:8–12

The text gives special attention to the early history of Babylonia and Assyria. These Mesopotamian empires (kingdoms from the land between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers) later conquered and exiled (forced to leave their land) Israel and Judah.

Genesis 10:9

- Nimrod became famous through conquest and fear. His empire reached from Babylonia in the south to Assyria in the north (10:10–12).
- a mighty hunter before the LORD: Assyrian kings often praised their own power, showing themselves as brave hunter-conquerors.

Genesis 10:10–12

- His kingdom: This is the region around the Tigris and Euphrates rivers in southern Mesopotamia. This kingdom eventually expanded into northern Mesopotamia (Assyria).
- Babylon is the most important city because it played a key role in the story of the tower of Babel (see 11:4 and study note).
- Erech, known as ancient Uruk, is now Warka in southern Iraq (see Ezra 4:9–10).
- Accad, once called Agade, is north of Babylon and was home to the famous ruler Sargon (2370–2295 BC).
- The location of Calneh is uncertain. But it is probably one of Nimrod's cities north of Aram-naharaim in southern Mesopotamia (compare Amos 6:2).
- built ... Nineveh: Like Cain, Nimrod built cities (see Genesis 4:17 and comments). Nineveh was an ancient Assyrian city on the east bank of the Tigris River in northern Iraq.
- Rehoboth-Ir was either a nearby city or a daughter-city of Nineveh.
- Calah is modern Tell Nimrud, south of Nineveh.

- Resen is possibly modern Selamiyeh, northwest of Tell Nimrud.

Genesis 10:13–14

- the Ludites were Lydian tribes located west of the Nile delta.
- The identity of the Anamites is unclear. They might have been Egyptians near Cyrene, west of Egypt.
- the Lehabites were probably a Libyan tribe.
- the Naphtuhites lived in northern Egypt.
- the Pathrusites lived in southern Egypt.
- the Casluhites might have lived in an Egyptian area also known as "Cyrenaica."
- the Caphtorites were Cretans (see Jeremiah 47:4; Amos 9:7).
- the Philistines from Crete were warriors and traders who traveled by ship from Crete to settle in southwest Canaan. They lived there during the time when the Israelites left Egypt and in later periods (Exodus 13:17; Amos 9:7). During the early years of Israel's kings, the Philistines were one of Israel's strongest enemies (see 1–2 Samuel).

Genesis 10:15–18

- Sidon settled in Phoenicia, north of Canaan.
- the Hittites: In Genesis, these were a group of cities in Canaan (see 26:34–35; 27:46; Ezekiel 16:3). They were probably different from the Hittites of Anatolia (Asia Minor). Their empire was a major power in the time of the biblical patriarchs.
- The Jebusites were ancient people living in Jerusalem (Joshua 15:63; Judges 19:10–11; 2 Samuel 5:6–9).
- The Amorites lived in the mountains of Palestine in Canaan (see Genesis 15:16; 48:22; Numbers 13:29; Deuteronomy 3:8; Joshua 10:5; Judges 1:35; 10:8; Ezekiel 16:3).
- Little is known about the Girgashites, a Canaanite tribe (Genesis 15:21; Deuteronomy 7:1; Joshua 3:10).
- The Hivites were a Canaanite people group who did not practice circumcision (Genesis 34:2, 13–24; Joshua 9:1, 7; 11:3; Judges 3:3; 2 Samuel 24:7).
- The Arkites lived in Tell 'Arqa in Lebanon.
- The Sinites formed a city-state in Phoenicia.
- The Arvadites lived in Ruad in northern Phoenicia, near the El Kebir River. They were known for shipping (compare Ezekiel 27:8).
- The Zemarites lived in Sumur (modern Sumra), north of Arka on the Phoenician coast.
- The Hamathites founded what is now Hama on the Orontes River, the northern border of Canaan (see Numbers 34:8; Joshua 13:5; 2 Samuel 8:9–10; 1 Kings 8:65; 2 Kings 14:25–28).

Genesis 10:19

- God set apart the borders of Canaan to be taken from its people and given to Israel (see 15:18; Numbers 34:2–12; Ezekiel 47:15–20; 48:1–28).
- An ancient highway along the seacoast, the Via Maris, ran from Sidon toward Gerar, connecting Egypt to Mesopotamia.
- Modern Gaza is 18 kilometers (11 miles) northwest of Gerar.
- Sodom and Gomorrah were cities on the southeastern border of the Dead Sea.
- Admah, and Zeboiim: The Bible mentions these cities 15 times in connection with Sodom and Gomorrah (14:2, 8; Deuteronomy 29:23; see Hosea 11:8). God destroyed all four cities to cleanse the land (see Genesis 19).
- Lasha was possibly in the northern area of the Dead Sea.

Genesis 10:21

- Shem, the older brother of Japheth, was the ancestor of the Semitic peoples (people groups connected by language and culture in the ancient Near East) . The people listed here lived mainly to the east of Israel, in areas like modern Iraq, Iran, and Syria.

The narrator focuses on places in Mesopotamia (the land between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers). This is important because Abram, the ancestor of Israel, came from this region (see 11:27–32).

- Eber receives special attention because he is an ancestor of Abram and is closely connected to the Hebrews (see study note on 10:24).

Genesis 10:22

- The descendants of Elam lived in what is now southwestern Iran (see 14:1, 9; Ezra 4:9; Isaiah 11:11).
- The descendants of Asshur became the Assyrians, who lived under Nimrod's rule (see Genesis 10:11). Sumerians, who descended from Ham, were expelled by Mesopotamian Semites.
- Arphaxad may have settled northeast of Nineveh. There is more information about his descendants in 11:12–26.
- Lud was near the Tigris River. The people of Lud were related to the Lydians (see 10:13).
- Aram was a kingdom of tribes living in the Mesopotamian plains.

Genesis 10:23

- The patriarchs later interacted with the descendants of Aram (see 25:20; 31:20; Deuteronomy 26:5).

- Uz was the main Aramean tribe, possibly northeast of the Jordan River. It was Job's home (see Job 1:1; see also Lamentations 4:21).
- Hul is unknown. He might have founded Armenia.
- Gether is unknown. He might have founded the Syrians.
- Mash might have a connection to Mount Masus in northern Mesopotamia or to a part of the Lebanon Mountains.

Genesis 10:24

- Shelah is not well-known, but it might be short for Methushelah (compare 38:5, 11).
- Eber was an ancestor of Abram the Hebrew (11:10–26). His name is the source of the word Hebrew (see 14:13; 39:14; 40:15; 41:12; Exodus 2:11; 3:18).

Genesis 10:25

- Peleg means "division," which refers to the dividing of people into different language groups after the tower of Babel event (11:1–9). Peleg's descendants included Abram (see 11:16–26).
- Joktan was the ancestor of the southern Arabian tribes. The Ishmaelite tribes lived in northern Arabia (see 25:13–16).

Genesis 10:26–29

- Almodad was an ancestor, region, or tribe in what is now Yemen.
- Sheleph was a tribe in Yemen.
- Hazarmaveth had a link to Hadramaut in southern Arabia.
- Jerah is unknown but might have a connection to Mount Barach.
- Hadoram was an Arabian tribe.
- Uzal was Sana'a, an ancient capital of Yemen before Islam.
- Diklah was a southern Arabian oasis in Mina.
- Obal was between Hodeida and Sana'a in southwest Arabia.
- Abimael was a Sabaean. These were an ancient people of southern Arabia.
- Sheba was in southern Arabia (see 10:7).
- Ophir was a region in southern Arabia between Sheba and Havilah. It was famous for gold (Isaiah 13:12).
- Havilah: See 10:7.
- Jobab might have been Jobebitai in southern Arabia.

Genesis 10:26–32

Shem had 14 sons through Eber and Joktan. The tower of Babel story connects Joktan to God's judgment there (11:1–9) and connects Peleg to Abram (11:27–12:1).

Genesis 10:30

- Mesha was a region in northern Arabia, located south of Hadramaut.
- Sephar is the same as Isfar, which is south of Hadramaut in Yemen.

Genesis 11:1

Now: The events in 11:1–9 caused the nations to scatter, as shown in the family histories of 10:2–30. Although these events happened in a different order than they are written, the author arranged them this way to help explain things about God's actions and plans more clearly (see study note on 10:1–11:9).

Genesis 11:1–9

The story of the unfinished tower continues themes from the Table of Nations (chapter 10). These themes include language and human unity. The builders wanted independence from God, which recalls the rebellion in the garden of Eden (chapter 3). This also helps show why Abram's faithful response to God is needed (chapter 12) during a time of disorder among the nations.

The scattering of the nations also points forward to later warnings given to Israel. God warned that idolatry would lead to their being scattered, and that their cities would be ruined (see Leviticus 26:33; Numbers 10:35; Deuteronomy 4:27; 28:64; 30:3).

In the timeline of Genesis, this goes back to an earlier time. It explains how the nations spread out during the time of Peleg (see Genesis 10:25).

Genesis 11:2

- journeyed eastward: See study note on 3:24.
- Shinar (Babylonia) was in southern Mesopotamia, where Nimrod later built his empire and cities (see 10:10; Isaiah 11:11; Daniel 1:2; Zechariah 5:11).

Genesis 11:3

- Stone was plentiful in Canaan. In Mesopotamia, stone was rare, so they developed brick-making technology.
- They made tar from bitumen, a natural, waterproof asphalt similar to cement (see 6:14; Exodus 2:3).

Genesis 11:4

- Far from the original garden (2:15), the first cities of Genesis represent arrogance (4:17), tyranny (10:8–12), and evil (18:20–21). The city on the Babylonian plain attracted human pride and idol worship.

- a tower that reaches to the heavens: This was probably a temple-tower (a ziggurat). In ancient Babylonian cities, people considered ziggurats to be sacred mountains where gods came down to earth. Jacob's dream in 28:12 might indicate this idea.
- that we may make a name for ourselves: The tower builders wanted fame through their idol-worshiping ambition. God promised to make Abram famous because of his humble obedience (12:2).

Genesis 11:5

came down: The tower was a human attempt to reach up to God's realm (God's dwelling place; see Deuteronomy 26:15; Psalms 2:4; 103:19; 115:16). This effort was foolish. God had to "come down" to see what they were building, which shows how small and weak their work really was.

Genesis 11:6

If no one stopped them, the tower builders would become united and ambitious. This would allow human evil to grow in ways that cannot be imagined.

Genesis 11:7

- Come, let Us go down: God speaks to his angelic court (see 1:26; 3:22; and study notes).
- will not understand one another's speech: When people could no longer understand one another, their shared plan to do wrong would stop. Later, at Pentecost, God allowed people to understand many languages. This showed a partial reversal (undoing) of what happened at Babe (Acts 2:5–13; see Zephaniah 3:9).

Genesis 11:8

the LORD scattered them: In a similar way, God punished Adam and Eve for trying to become independent of his rule. God punished Cain for murder. Their punishments involved exile and scattering (3:23; 4:12, 14; 9:19; 10:5, 25, 32).

Genesis 11:9

- Babel: The Babylonians saw their city as the home or gateway of the gods. The double meaning at the end of this story shows Babylon's spiritual confusion.

Babylon became important under Nimrod (10:10) and later in biblical history (see 2 Kings 25:1–30). Its role as a center of pride and idol worship makes it a symbol for the forces opposed to God in the end times (for example, Revelation 14:8; 16:19; 18:2).

- The tower builders gathered together in one place to reach up into God's realm (God's dwelling place; Genesis 11:3–4). God came down and scattered them across the earth. In this way, he stopped their idolatrous ambition (their desire to act against him and seek their own glory).

Genesis 11:10

- This account of Shem continues from 10:21–32, focusing on the family line leading to Abram. Only Abram and Israel inherit Shem's God (see 9:26–27; Deuteronomy 32:8–9). The Babel story strongly rejects the culture that God called Abram to abandon (Genesis 12:1; 24:6–7). Together with the account of Terah's descendants (11:27–32), this account of Shem's line forms a bridge from the universal history of chapters 1–11 to Israel's national history that begins in chapter 12.

Abram was part of the small group that remained faithful after the confusion at Babel.
God chose Abram as an act of grace. Through Abram, God began a new plan. God's purpose was to bless the whole world, even though the nations had been divided and scattered at Babel (12:3).

- the father of (or the ancestor of): Hebrew family records (genealogies, or lists of ancestors) do not always include every generation.

Genesis 11:18

Peleg: See the study note on 10:25.

Genesis 11:27

- Nahor was Laban's grandfather. Laban's daughters later married Jacob (chapters 29–31).
- Lot: See the "Lot" Profile.

Genesis 11:27–32

This brief section provides a complete summary of Terah's life and accounts for his other sons and their marriages. It also introduces Lot, Abram's nephew, who later played an important role. The ancestors, including Terah and his family, were idolatrous, worshiping other gods in Mesopotamia (Joshua 24:2).

Genesis 11:27–25.11

This is the account: The Hebrew word is toledoth (a term that introduces a new section or family history; see study note on 2:4). This section tells about Terah's family.

The details in 11:28–25:11 are about the family line that comes from Terah. The focus is on Abraham and God's covenant with him.

The passage also highlights Isaac, the promised child. Isaac continued the family line and carried God's blessing to the next generation.

Genesis 11:28

- Abram received his calling from God in Ur of the Chaldeans (15:7; Acts 7:2–4). This was the main city of Sumer in Mesopotamia near the Persian Gulf. The family had moved there perhaps generations before this calling. Their original home ("country," Genesis 12:1) was probably near Haran, in the region of Shem's descendants (11:10–26). They settled in Haran after leaving Ur (11:31). Later, they were described as Arameans (Deuteronomy 26:5).
- native land: The same Hebrew phrase appears in 12:1 ("country"), indicating that Ur, not Haran, was where Abram received his calling (see 15:7; Nehemiah 9:7; Acts 7:2).

Genesis 11:29

- Sarai means "princess" in Hebrew. The text does not mention Sarai's parents. This might have been to create suspense in the story of Abimelech. This story reveals her as Abram's half-sister (20:9–12). Later, the law forbade such marriages (Leviticus 18:9; 20:17; Deuteronomy 27:22).
- Nahor's wife was Milcah, who was the daughter of Haran and Nahor's niece (see Genesis 11:29). Her son Bethuel was Rebekah's father. Rebekah became the wife of Abram's son Isaac (24:10, 15, 24). The name Milcah is related to the Hebrew word for "queen."

In Akkadian, it is a title for the goddess Ishtar, the daughter of the moon god. Terah's name is related to the Hebrew word for "moon." His family probably worshiped Sin, the moon god (see Joshua 24:14).

Genesis 11:30

Sarai, Rebekah, and Rachel could not have children at first (25:21; 29:31). Sarai's case especially shows the tension between what people could see and what God had promised. God had promised to make Abram into a great nation (12:2).

Israel began through women who could not bear children. This shows that Israel existed because of God's power and choice. God gave children to women who were barren (unable to have children), as these passages also show (see also 1 Samuel 1:2; 2:5; Psalm 113:9; Isaiah 54:1).

Genesis 11:31

- Terah took: Abram left Ur because God called him (see study note on 11:28). Yet, the story relates from Terah's viewpoint, reflecting the ancient Near Eastern culture where the oldest male led the family. This respect for elders is probably why Abram did not go to Canaan alone at that time (see Acts 7:2–4).
- Haran was 885 kilometers (550 miles) northwest of Ur, near the Syrian-Turkish border. Despite the similar name, there is no connection to Terah's son Haran, who died in Ur (11:28).
- Haran means "caravan." It was a major trade center where ancient trade routes met.
- Haran was also famous for moon worship, which Terah's family probably practiced (see study note on 11:29).

Genesis 12:1

Abram knew that he should leave, but he did not know where he was going. Obedience required faith.

Genesis 12:1–3

These verses are structured around two commands to Abram: Leave and be a blessing (see study note on 12:2). Each command is followed by three promises conditioned upon obedience.

Genesis 12:1–9

- Through Abram's faith and family, God started to restore the blessing. God called Abram from a pagan world to start a new nation. His promises to Abram later became a covenant (chapter 15).
- God's calling of Abram later helped convince the Israelites to leave Egypt and go to the land God promised to Abram. It also reminded the Babylonian exiles of their need to return to their own land (for example, Isaiah 51).

Genesis 12:2

- make your name great: Abram gained the fame that the builders of the tower of Babel wanted for themselves (see 11:4 and study note).
- so that you will be a blessing: This statement is a command and a promise in Hebrew. It depends on Abram obeying God's command (12:1–3): "Go ... so that you will be a blessing. I will bless those who bless you and curse those who curse you."

Genesis 12:3

- Because Abram obeyed the command to be a blessing (12:2), God gave him three more promises.
- those who curse you: People who ignored Abram and his covenant were rejecting God's choice and plan.
- all the families on earth will be blessed: By faith, they could join the covenant God was making

with Abram. The blessing spread worldwide through Abraham, Israel, the covenants, the prophets, Scripture, and the Messiah (Galatians 3:8, 16; compare Romans 9:4–5).

Genesis 12:4

Abram was middle-aged, settled, wealthy, and of high social status. He worshiped many gods (see study note on 11:27–32). When the Lord spoke to him (12:1–3), he obediently left his old ways in Ur to follow God's plan. Because Abram responded in faith, God could confirm his promises (12:2–3) in a binding covenant (15:8–21).

Genesis 12:4–9

Abram obeyed God's calling and followed his commands (see study note on 12:1–3). He traveled to Canaan (12:4–6) and became a blessing (12:5–9).

Genesis 12:5

The people (Hebrew hannepesh, meaning "the lives") he brought into his household were probably converts. Abram first became a blessing by influencing his household to follow the Lord.

Genesis 12:6–7

- the Oak of Moreh: This was probably a Canaanite shrine. Fertile groves were sacred to the Canaanites (compare Isaiah 1:29), and Moreh means "teacher."

Abram proclaimed the Lord's name beside a pagan place of worship and instruction (Genesis 12:8).

- Abram continued to be a blessing by building an altar to worship God at Shechem and east of Bethel (12:8).

Genesis 12:7

- the LORD appeared to Abram at Shechem (12:6) to confirm that this was the promised land. Israel was meant to live in this land, but they needed faith to share in God's promises (compare Numbers 14; Joshua 1:6–9).
- to your offspring: Abram did not own the land yet. He lived there as a temporary settler.

Genesis 12:8

he called on the name of the LORD: Calling on the name (identity and character) of the Lord is central to worship and witness (compare 4:26; see Exodus 34:5–7). Abram needed to distinguish his sacrificial worship from that of the pagan Canaanites.

Genesis 12:8–9

Abram had to keep moving camp because the Canaanites had the fertile land.

Genesis 12:10

The Nile River supplied plenty of water for crops, so Egypt was usually the last area to experience famine.

Genesis 12:10–13

- Abram's scheme came from fear, putting his family and God's promises at risk. He lacked faith when he went to Egypt. He stopped building altars, and deception became the main pattern of his behavior. Deception would trouble his family throughout Genesis (26:1–11; 27:1–29; 29:15–30; 30:34–36; 31:6–11; 37:18–35; 39:7–20).
- Abram's plan probably followed a custom where a brother arranged his sister's marriage (compare 24:29–61). Abram may have thought that any possible suitor would have to deal with him, giving him time to leave with Sarai. He did not expect Pharaoh to act without negotiation (12:14–16).

Genesis 12:10–20

- This story shows that God would allow Abram to put his promises at risk in this episode. Soon after Abram obeyed God's call, a famine tested his weak faith. God rescued Abram and his family, even though Abram acted foolishly. In Egypt, he used deception instead of trusting God to protect him.
- This story intentionally mirrors Israel's later slavery in Egypt:
- Because of a famine (compare Genesis 12:10 with Genesis 47:13), Abram and Israel went to Egypt (compare Genesis 12:10 with Genesis 47:27).
- There was an attempt to kill the males and save the females (compare Genesis 12:12 with Exodus 1:22).
- God sent plagues to Egypt (compare Genesis 12:17 with Exodus 7:14–11:10).
- Abram and Israel took riches from Egypt (compare Genesis 12:16 with Exodus 12:35–36).
- Pharaoh expelled them (Hebrew shalakh, meaning "send"; compare Genesis 12:19–20 with Exodus 12:31–33) and they went to the Negev (compare Genesis 13:1 with Numbers 13:17, 22).

Israel was to believe that God would deliver them from bondage in Egypt through the plagues because their ancestor had already been rescued from bondage in Egypt.

Genesis 12:13

Please say you are my sister: This request appears three times in Genesis (see also 20:2; 26:7). The text explains that this was Abram's usual strategy (20:13), and his son Isaac did the same thing. The first time this happened was outside the land, and the second time within it (chapter 20). This shows that God protected his promise in both regions.

Genesis 12:14–15

Sarai was 65, but she would live to 127. If the biblical lifespans here are understood literally, she had lived only about half her life. By those standards, she may still have been at an age of full strength and maturity.

Sarai and Abram came from a noble family (see study note on 11:29), so she likely had a regal appearance and wore fine clothing. Pharaoh was drawn to both her beauty and the political advantage of an alliance with her family.

Genesis 12:14–16

- Abram was bound by the king's gift to an unwanted agreement about Sarai that he did not want and could not stop. His plan had put him in a dangerous situation. It put Abram, Sarai, and the promise at risk.
- Abram seemed to gain wealth from his deception, but these new possessions also led to new problems. Abram and Lot had to separate (chapter 13). Hagar, an Egyptian servant, later became the mother of Ishmael's descendants (chapter 16). In the Bible, these descendants are often shown as being in conflict with Israel.

Genesis 12:15

Pharaoh was a title for a ruler, not a personal name (37:36; Exodus 1:15).

Genesis 12:17–19

God intervened to rescue Sarai and to preserve her marriage to Abram so that the covenant promise could be fulfilled. When Sarai was returned to Abram, Pharaoh rebuked him because of what had happened (12:18–19).

Genesis 12:20

Abram did not need to answer Pharaoh's questions (12:18–19) because Pharaoh's rebuke was followed by expulsion. Pharaoh's command echoed God's command to Abram (12:1), but Pharaoh's words brought Abram shame and disgrace. Even so, God remained faithful and preserved his promise.

Genesis 13:1–7

This story takes place during a time of conflict and God's blessings. At the beginning, Abram returns to a place where he had built an altar. The story emphasizes earlier events as Abram returns to the land (13:3–4). Abram renews his worship and again calls on the Lord's name (see 12:8).

Genesis 13:2

Abram already had powerful resources (12:5). His time in Egypt increased his wealth and power (12:16).

Genesis 13:5–7

- Lot was also wealthy, owning many animals. Tents play an important role in Lot's story (13:12).
- The Canaanites and the Perizzites (see 34:30; Deuteronomy 7:1; Judges 1:4; 3:5) controlled the fertile land. The argument between Abram's and Lot's herdsmen made Abram easier to attack.

Genesis 13:8

Abram wanted to avoid conflict (Hebrew meribah) because they were close relatives (literally brothers). Later, Moses rebuked Israel for the incident in the wilderness at Meribah (Exodus 17:1–7; Numbers 20:1–13). He taught them to have faith in such situations. So, Meribah became a word of warning for testing and arguing with the Lord in unbelief (see Psalm 95).

Genesis 13:8–13

God promised the land to Abram. Abram might have told Lot to find his own place. Abram's generosity showed his faith. He believed that even if he gave all the land away, God would still provide it to him and his descendants. Abram did not need to hold to things, while Lot's choices were selfish.

Genesis 13:10

- What attracted Lot would not last. In the garden of the Lord, Adam and Eve gave in to their desire for what they saw. Later, Israel became enslaved in Egypt. Sodom and Gomorrah warn us about putting strong desires ahead of obedience to God (Genesis 3:5–6; see 1 John 2:16).
- Zoar was a small town in the plain where Lot and his daughters later fled (Genesis 19:18–22). Earlier, it was called Bela (14:2).

Genesis 13:11

- Lot's choice was completely selfish, showing no concern for Abram or faith in the Lord.
- the whole plain of the Jordan (literally the circle of the Jordan): This was probably near the southern end of the Dead Sea, based on descriptions in ancient records that locate cities of the plain. This area is now very desolate.

Genesis 13:11–18

The narrator makes many contrasts between Lot and Abram.

Genesis 13:13

This suggests that Lot would not oppose Sodom's influence because he was focusing on his own interests.

Genesis 13:14–17

Abram could give Lot the choice land because he believed in God's promise. Abram waited for God to give him the land. Lot just took what he wanted.

Genesis 13:18

- Hebron was an Anakite city (Numbers 13:22) originally called Kiriath-arba (meaning "city of Arba"). It was located in the forested highlands just north of the Negev (Genesis 12:9; Joshua 17:15). Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob all settled there (Genesis 18:1; 35:27; 37:14). Sarah, Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, and Leah were buried in Hebron (23:19; 35:27–29; 49:29–32; 50:13).
- Mamre was an Amorite (14:13; 15:16).

Genesis 14:1

Tidal apparently ruled several city-states. The text calls his people Goiim, which means "nations" in Hebrew.

Genesis 14:1–2

Archaeology has not identified these kings. But ancient texts include similar names, which supports the report's reliability. The Mesopotamian kings were allies under one leading ruler, likely Amraphel, who is named first.

Genesis 14:1–16

In this typical ancient political conflict, powerful kings allied to control smaller dependent states.

Genesis 14:4

King Chedorlaomer seems to have defeated the kings of the Siddim Valley earlier and made them pay tribute in asphalt, olive oil, and copper. In the thirteenth year, they stopped paying. In the fourteenth year (14:5), the invading kings returned to bring them under their rule again.

Genesis 14:4–5

This was Chedorlaomer's war. Under the feudal system of tribal affiliations, those in covenant with him had to fight. It was also Abram's battle to rescue Lot, and those under treaty with him had to accompany him.

Genesis 14:5–8

The invaders came down the King's Highway on the east side of the Jordan Valley to the Gulf of Aqaba, then circled back to the valley of the Dead Sea.

Genesis 14:8–12

The five cities of the Plain were close together near the south end of the Dead Sea. The Mesopotamian kings crushed the weak revolt, plundered Sodom and Gomorrah, and carried Lot away with the other captives.

Genesis 14:13

- The word Hebrew appears here for the first time in the Bible. It is different from the later term Habiru found in Egyptian texts. The Habiru were hired soldiers who roamed the land during the time of the judges.
- Mamre: See study note on 13:18.
- a brother: Or ally.

Genesis 14:14

- Abram ... mobilized the 318 trained men born in his household: This shows that Abram was a strong leader and that God's promise to make him great was already being fulfilled (Genesis 12:2–3).
- Dan was a city about 241 kilometers (150 miles) north of Abram's home in Hebron. At that time, the city was called Laish or Leshem (see Joshua 19:47 and study note; Judges 18:29). Dan, the son whose descendants later settled there during the time of the judges, had not yet been born (Genesis 30:6; Judges 18:1–29). It seems that an editor later updated the place name so that later audiences would know which city the text meant.

Genesis 14:14–16

God could give his people victory over any forces invading the promised land. Faithfulness to God was necessary for victory. God promises to bless his people and give them victory over the world. He uses those who respond to his call and can skillfully use weapons of war.

Genesis 14:15

Damascus was 64 kilometers (40 miles) north of Dan. Hobah was 97 kilometers (about 60 miles) north of Damascus.

Genesis 14:17

The Valley of Shaveh, or King's Valley, was probably the Kidron Valley (see 2 Samuel 18:18).

Genesis 14:18

- The name Melchizedek means "king of righteousness." This suggests the king of Salem was a righteous servant of God. He was probably a Jebusite priest and king. Later writers regarded him as a type of Christ, that is, a person who points forward to Christ (Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 7:1–19).
- Salem is the ancient name for Jerusalem (compare Psalm 76:2).

Genesis 14:19–20

By giving a tenth of everything to Melchizedek, Abram acknowledged Melchizedek as spiritual authority (see Hebrews 7:4). He affirmed that God had given him victory.

Genesis 14:21–24

Abram understood that accepting the king of Sodom's offer (see study note on 14:1–2) might make him an ally or subject, as Lot had been. This could put God's promises at risk. Faith looks beyond the world's riches to the greater blessings that God will give.

Genesis 14:22

In this oath, Abram may have been making it clear that his God, the LORD (Yahweh), is the same as God Most High, whom Melchizedek spoke about. It is possible that Melchizedek did not know the name Yahweh.

Genesis 15:1

- Do not be afraid: Abram did not have a son to inherit his property. The Lord addressed Abram's anxiety about the future with comforting words.
- I am your shield: The Hebrew word for shield (magen) comes from the same root word as Melchizedek's word delivered (14:20). The Lord, who had delivered Abram's enemies into his power, would continue to protect him.
- your very great reward: The promise of children was still unfulfilled (12:2–3; see also Psalm 127:3).

Genesis 15:1–21

God made a covenant (a special agreement) with Abram. In this covenant, God confirmed the promises he had made earlier when he summoned Abram to leave his country (12:1–3). Abram's descendants would experience a long period of slavery before God made these promises come true.

Genesis 15:2–3

Abram used wordplay to show his concern that Eliezer of Damascus (Hebrew dammeseq), a man in Abram's household, would become his heir (Hebrew ben-mesheq, which means "son of possession"). This was the usual practice when a man had no son.

Genesis 15:4–6

God confirmed that the promise to Abram was for his own children. Then God showed Abram the stars as a sign of the many descendants he would have (22:17; 26:4). The apostle Paul quotes this promise in Romans 4:18 to emphasize Abram's strong faith.

Genesis 15:6

- Abram believed: God made a covenant with someone who trusted in him. The text does not say when Abram first believed. The Hebrew text does not link Abram's belief to the promise about the stars. It simply says that Abram believed the LORD. Abram already had faith. Leaving Ur was his first major act that showed it (see Hebrews 11:8–10).
- it was credited to him as righteousness: The New Testament quotes this key statement about Abram's faith three times (Romans 4:3; Galatians 3:6; James 2:23). The New Testament writers use this verse to support the teaching that God makes a person right with himself through trust in him (see also Romans 4:22–23).

Genesis 15:7–21

In a special ceremony, God made a covenant with Abram and promised to do what he had said.

Genesis 15:10

Obeying God's instructions, Abram collected three herd animals for the ceremony and cut them in half. Cutting the animals symbolized the oath. It showed that the person making the covenant risked his own life if he did not keep his promise (Jeremiah 34:18).

Genesis 15:11

birds of prey: These are ceremonially unclean birds that symbolize those who unjustly attack Abraham's heirs (15:13–14).

Genesis 15:13

- mistreated: The same word appears in Exodus 1:11–12. Egypt, like "birds of prey" (Genesis 15:11), tried to destroy Israel and stop the fulfillment of the covenant.
- four hundred years: This is probably an approximate number (also Acts 7:6; compare Exodus 12:40; Galatians 3:17). According to the Hebrew text's timeline, the family moved to Egypt around 1876 BC. The exodus happened around 1446 BC, but many scholars believe the Israelites left Egypt later, around 1270 BC (see Exodus Book Introduction, "The Date of the Exodus").

Genesis 15:13–16

Not even 400 years of slavery could interfere with God's plan to fulfill the covenant.

Genesis 15:16

- The reasons for Israel's bondage included God's justice. God would tolerate the sins of the Amorites until they fully deserved judgment.
- is not yet complete: To give the promised land to Israel, God would justly remove those living in the land. Fulfilling promises to Israel also meant judgment for the people in the land. But if they trusted in him, God would save individual people (see Joshua 2:1–15; 6:23–25; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25). Until then, God would send Jacob's family to Egypt so Israel could become a great nation. Seeing this future frightened Abram (Genesis 15:12). But it was comforting to know nothing could stop God's plan.

Genesis 15:17–18

smoking firepot and a flaming torch: Fire represented the Lord's cleansing and consuming zeal. It also represented how no one could come near him because of his holiness (compare Isaiah 6:3–7). The holy God made (literally cut) a one-sided covenant with Abram. The promises were absolutely certain. This was because they did not rely on what Abram or his descendants' might do.

Genesis 15:18–19

God clearly defined the borders of the promised land (the land he promised to give). He told Abram that even though there would be death and suffering, including slavery, he and his descendants would still receive these promises. God confirmed this with an oath (see Hebrews 6:13–14). Nothing can separate God's people from his love or stop the fulfillment (the bringing about) of his plans (see Romans 8:18–39; 2 Peter 1:3–4).

Genesis 16:1–3

Abram and Sarai dealt with the stress of Sarai not being able to have children and being too old to give birth.

According to the custom in that culture, a woman unable to have children could give her servant as a secondary wife to her husband. The child from this union became the primary wife's child. They adopted the child as the heir.

Sarai's suggestion was acceptable according to the culture's custom. But it was a human plan that showed a lack of faith in God. God's promises would be fulfilled by faith.

Genesis 16:1–16

While they waited for their promised son to be born, Abram and Sarai tried another plan. This plan did not show trust in God.

Genesis 16:4–6

Hagar might have thought Abram would favor her instead of Sarai (compare Proverbs 30:21–23).

Genesis 16:7

the angel of the LORD: The angel of the Lord was the Lord himself in some passages (16:13; 21:17; 22:11–12; 31:11–13; 48:16; Exodus 3:2; 32:34; Judges 6:11, 16, 22; 13:22–23; Zechariah 3:1–2). But in other passages he is distinct from the Lord (Genesis 24:7; 2 Samuel 24:16; Zechariah 1:12).

This figure is often understood as a theophany (a visible appearance of God) or a Christophany (an appearance of the Messiah before he became human (see Genesis 18:1–2; 19:1; Numbers 22:22; Judges 2:1–4; 5:23; Zechariah 12:8). In these cases, he speaks with the authority of the Lord himself.

Genesis 16:8–12

The angel asked Hagar questions that helped her speak openly to God. When she did, God told her to return and submit to Sarai (16:9). He also promised that her son would have many descendants, so many that they could not be counted.

The angel of the Lord did not call Hagar Abram's wife. Instead, he called her Sarai's servant. Hagar would bear Abram's child, but Ishmael was not part of God's covenant with Abram.

Genesis 16:10–12

Hagar's son would become the father of a large nation. This nation would be strong but often hostile, living in the Arabian Desert and frequently in conflict with Israel (compare 25:18).

God blessed Ishmael as Abram's descendant. But God did not choose Ishmael to continue the covenant. God kept that blessing for Abram's heir based on God's promise.

Genesis 16:11

Names in Genesis often emphasize the message of a passage. They help the people of God remember the events and their importance in the history of faith. The name Ishmael means "God hears." It marks the moment when the LORD ... heard Hagar's cry of distress (see also study note on 16:14–15). This name would have greatly comforted Hagar. God listened to her prayers and acknowledged her complaint.

Genesis 16:13

- Hagar showed faith in God through her words and obedience.
- the God who sees me: God understood Hagar's situation and protected her.

Genesis 16:14–15

The name Beer-lahai-roi means "well of the Living One who sees me." This name and Ishmael were a message and a rebuke for Abram and Sarai (see 16:11). God notices suffering and listens to those crying out in need.

Sarai and Abram should have prayed instead of trying to fulfill the promise themselves by following a social custom (compare 25:21). Giving children to a woman who cannot have them is God's work (Psalm 113:9; compare 1 Samuel 1:1–28; Luke 1:1–25). Humans cannot solve impossible problems. The Lord hears those who suffer, sees their needs, and will provide for them in miraculous ways.

Genesis 17:1

- God Almighty (Hebrew El-Shaddai): This name for God emphasizes his power (see also 28:3; 35:11; 43:14; 48:3; 49:25).
- Walk before Me and be blameless: To bless the nations, Abram needed to obey. Almighty God would guide his actions.

Genesis 17:1–27

God gave Abram's family signs that his promises would come true. He changed Abram's name to Abraham (17:1–8). He established circumcision as the sign of the covenant (17:9–14, 23–27). He changed Sarai's name to Sarah (17:15–22).

Genesis 17:4–5

God guaranteed his promise by changing Abram's name. Abram means "exalted father." This referred to his father Terah and his noble lineage (11:27). His new name, Abraham (Hebrew 'ab hamon), means "father of a multitude." This was a wordplay on the promise of his countless descendants (see also John 8:31–59; Romans 4:16–17; Galatians 3:7, 15–19, 29). Whenever the new name was used, he and his household would remember that a multitude of nations would come from him.

Genesis 17:6

kings will descend from you: This is the first sign that Israel would become a nation ruled by kings (see also 35:11; 36:31; Numbers 24:7; Deuteronomy 17:14–18; 28:36).

Genesis 17:7–8

The land of Canaan was to be an everlasting possession for the descendants of Abraham. The Lord would always be their God (see Jeremiah 31:31–40; Zechariah 8:8; Luke 1:68–79; Revelation 21:1–4).

Genesis 17:9–14

God gave circumcision as a confirming sign that reminded all households of loyalty to the covenant.

Genesis 17:14

will be cut off: This punishment seems to have several applications. A person could be exiled from society or put to death by the community; most often it warned that a person might die prematurely (see Exodus 31:14; Leviticus 7:20–27; 17:3–4; 20:17–18; 23:28–29; Numbers 15:30–31; see also Psalm 31:22; Ezekiel 21:4; Romans 9:3; 11:22).

Failure to be circumcised was a serious violation of the covenant (see Exodus 4:24–26; compare Galatians 5:2–4).

Genesis 17:15–16

Sarah's new name marked an important step in her calling (God's purpose for her life). It fit her role as the future mother of kings and pointed to God's promise.

Genesis 17:17–18

he laughed (Hebrew yitskhaq): This was because the promise seemed unbelievable. He thought his family line would continue through Ishmael. But Abraham and Sarah would have their own son.

Genesis 17:19

The name Isaac (Hebrew yitskhaq) means "he laughs." This recalls Abraham's disbelief when he heard God's promise. It also reminds us of God's favor and pleasure at Isaac's birth (compare 21:6).

Genesis 17:20–21

God would not abandon Ishmael. His family would prosper (see 25:13–16). But the covenant promises were for Isaac.

Genesis 17:23–27

After God spoke to Abraham about Isaac, Abraham followed God's instructions immediately. He performed circumcision as a sign of faith, showing their participation in the covenant (compare Romans 4:11–12; Galatians 5:2–6, 11; 6:15; Philippians 3:2–3; Colossians 2:11–12; 1 Peter 3:21).

Genesis 18:1–15

The Lord's visit to Abraham set the time for Isaac's birth. The three visitors were probably the Lord and two angels (see study note on 16:7). Abraham welcomed the visitors peacefully and generously, which contrasted with the chaos and corruption in Sodom (chapter 19).

Sharing a meal was important for making or confirming covenants. When God was ready to fulfill the covenant promise, he personally shared a meal with Abraham. Fellowship with God has always included a communal meal (see Exodus 24:9–11; Matthew 26:17–30 // Luke 22:7–38; Acts 2:42; 1 Corinthians 11:20–34).

Genesis 18:2–8

Abraham received his visitors as very important guests, perhaps realizing that they were messengers from God.

Genesis 18:3

My lord: The Hebrew text uses 'adonay, which always refers to God. In Hebrew tradition, people said this word when they saw the letters of God's holy name ("Yahweh") in the text. The text here might use 'adonay instead of the more common 'adoni to show this was the angel of the Lord, meaning the Lord himself (see study note on 16:7). We do not know if Abraham knew who his visitors were at first. But by the end of the story, he knew he had been talking with God.

Genesis 18:9

The visitors asked about Sarah by name, even though no one had told them who she was.

Genesis 18:10

I will surely return: The Hebrew phrase is emphatic. The statement announced a certain promise and dramatic change.

Genesis 18:13–15

Sarah thought no one noticed her disbelieving laughter. But God knows what people do in secret and what they feel (see Psalm 69:5; Proverbs 20:27; Mark 4:22; Luke 8:43–48; Hebrews 4:13). He knows if they doubt promises or trust in him (see Hebrews 11:11–12).

Genesis 18:14

Is anything too difficult for the LORD?: This question does not expect an answer. It teaches that nothing is too difficult for God.

God can do great and surprising things. For those who live in covenant (a binding promise relationship) with him, nothing is impossible, because nothing is too hard for the Lord.

Genesis 18:16–33

God trusted Abraham as his prophet (18:16–21; see 20:7). In return, Abraham pleaded that God would save Sodom (18:23–32; see Hebrews 7:23–26). God can do anything he wants. This passage confirms it will be fair and right.

Genesis 18:17–19

Abraham was responsible for teaching his descendants to be righteous and act justly so they might enjoy God's blessings. It was important for Abraham to know how God's righteousness was at work in judgment.

Genesis 18:20

The outcry: See Ezekiel 16:49–50.

Genesis 18:20–21

God, who knows everything, was cautious in his judgment. He knew the sins of Sodom and Gomorrah. This careful examination showed God's justice in a way humans could understand. He would not destroy the people unless he was certain they were wicked.

Genesis 18:22–33

Abraham probably thought there were more righteous people in Sodom and Gomorrah than there were (see study note on 19:14). Concerned for them, he made a legal appeal to the Lord based on God's justice. His prayer might seem bold, as if he were negotiating with God. But he approached God with true humility and respect. He did not try to convince God to act against his will. Instead, he prayed for the well-being of others (compare with Lot's prayer, 19:18–23).

God is a fair judge. "Righteousness exalts a nation" (Proverbs 14:34). Righteous people help preserve society (compare Matthew 5:13).

Genesis 19:1

- The two angels also first appeared to Abraham as men (18:2).
- Lot was no longer living in tents near Sodom (13:12). He had become a citizen and leader in Sodom, sitting at the city entrance. Community leaders (elders) usually gathered at the gates. This is where they publicly finalized legal and business matters (compare 23:18; Job 29:7, 12–17).

As a righteous man, Lot tried to guide the people of Sodom to live better lives (2 Peter 2:7–8; compare Genesis 19:9). While he opposed their evil behavior, Lot still chose Sodom's wealthy lifestyle over the simpler life in the hills (compare 13:10–11). Life in the hills offered fewer temptations and less corruption but lacked the comforts of Sodom.

As long as the Lord left Lot and his family alone in Sodom, he lived comfortably and kept his belief in God. But, he could not continue living this way. Sodom would have destroyed Lot if the Lord had not destroyed Sodom.

- This story showed Israel that God is the righteous judge of the whole earth (18:25). He punishes evil fairly. In evil societies, wrongdoing leads to unfair treatment and suffering for others.

Genesis 19:1–14

The two angels who were with the Lord at Mamre (compare 18:2, 22) went on to Sodom. They knew the people there were very wicked. Even though Lot welcomed them, they first chose to stay in the public square instead of going into his house.

Genesis 19:1–38

The Canaanites were evil people who tried to corrupt others. God judged their immoral civilization and warned others not to be like them. It was difficult to get Lot and his family out of Sodom. But it was even more difficult to remove Sodom's influence from them.

This chapter helped later Israelites understand the moral and spiritual dangers of the people living in and around the promised land. This included the Canaanites and Lot's descendants, the Moabites and the Ammonites (see Numbers 22–25; Deuteronomy 23:3–6; Joshua 24:9; Judges 10:7–9; 11:4–5; 1 Samuel 10:27; 1 Kings 11:1–3; 2 Kings 24:2).

Genesis 19:4–5

The evil actions of the men of the city were matched by the hypocrisy of Lot (19:6–9). The men acted in a wicked and violent way toward Lot's visitors. Lot tried to protect his guests. However, he offered his daughters to the crowd instead. This action showed serious moral failure.

Genesis 19:6–9

Lot strongly opposed the men's plan to harm his guests. He spoke against their wicked actions. However, he wrongly offered his daughters to protect the visitors, which showed a serious moral failure.

At first, Lot had only set up his tent near Sodom. Over time, he became closely tied to the city, and its influence shaped his life.

Genesis 19:9

The men of the city became enraged because Lot tried to stop their evil behavior. It was amazing to them that Lot would judge them, since he apparently had not done so before.

Genesis 19:14

Lot's warning words were not taken seriously because of his hypocrisy. It seemed that there would not be even ten righteous people in the city.

Genesis 19:15–23

- Lot escaped God's judgment because of God's grace, but Lot was still hesitant to leave Sodom. Israel would forever remember Lot as someone who hesitated and needed angels to pull him to safety. The Lord was merciful and spared Lot because of Abraham (18:23; 19:29).
- Today, people who follow God often feel pressure to copy the wrong ways that many people live. God asks his followers to live differently from people who do not follow him. This means Christians should choose actions and behaviors that show they belong to God (1 John 2:15–17). God will judge the corrupt systems of the world. This judgment will be even more severe than the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah (Matthew 11:23–24).

Genesis 19:18–22

Lot asked the angels for permission to live in the small town of Zoar (which means "little place") even after they saved him.

Genesis 19:23–25

Compare Luke 17:29. The eruption of Mount Vesuvius, the volcano that destroyed Pompeii in AD 79, along with more recent natural disasters, shows how quickly a complete disaster like this can happen.

Genesis 19:26

looked back: The verb form indicates intense gazing at the world she loved, not just a curious look (15:5; Exodus 33:8; Numbers 21:9; 1 Samuel 2:32; compare Exodus 3:6). Lot's wife had become too attached to Sodom to follow God's calling. So God judged her as she lingered on the valley slopes.

Christ's return to judge the world will be as sudden and devastating as Sodom's destruction (Luke 17:32–37). Those who desire the life of this wicked world will lose both this world and the next.

Genesis 19:29

God listened to Abraham's plea (compare 18:23–32). But Lot lost everything during the destruction of Sodom. His choice to live in the fertile land of Sodom eventually led him into a dangerous situation (13:10–13). After this, he could no longer remain in the land he had chosen.

Genesis 19:30–35

Sodom's culture apparently influenced Lot's daughters more than their father's values. They had no issues having children with their drunk father because they saw no other way to continue their family line (see 9:21–22).

Genesis 19:30–38

The poverty of the cave contrasts with the wealth Lot shared with Abram and the good life he lived in Sodom. Abraham would father a righteous nation (17:1), but Lot and his daughters started a new Sodom.

Genesis 19:36–38

- The daughters' plan worked. They each became pregnant by their father. From these two sons, born from incest, came two of Israel's long-time enemies: the nations of Moab and Ammon. Their extreme wickedness was partly due to their origins.
- Both daughters chose descriptive names for their sons. Moab means "from my father" and Ben-ammi means "son of my people." These names subtly hinted at their actions without making people suspicious who were unaware of the stories.

Genesis 20:1

Gerar was near the coast in Philistine land, about 19 kilometers (12 miles) south of Gaza and 80 kilometers (50 miles) southwest of Hebron.

Genesis 20:1–18

- This second "sister story" in Genesis (compare 12:10–20) happened just before Sarah became pregnant with Isaac (chapter 21). In both instances, God protected Abraham and Sarah's marriage to keep it pure for the covenant promises. To be part of God's plan, his people must separate from worldly corruption.
- This story happened in the promised land. It showed Israel how God intervened in people's lives to fulfill his plan. He protected them from threats from other tribes. He used his chosen people to mediate his relationship with other nations.
- By preventing adultery from destroying Abraham's marriage, God reminded the Israelites not to marry those who would lead them away from the Lord (Ezra 9:1–4; Nehemiah 13:23–27; Malachi 2:10–17). They should not allow any chance for temptation. Adultery would eventually destroy the covenant and the people.

Genesis 20:2

- Abraham lied to Abimelech, just as he had lied to Pharaoh (12:13). Isaac later did the same (26:1–11), probably learning this from his father.
- Abimelech (which means "my father the king") was probably a title like Pharaoh (37:36; Exodus 1:15), not a personal name (see study note on Genesis 26:1).

Genesis 20:3

One night ... God came ... in a dream: God urgently intervened to stop Abimelech from harming Sarah's purity right before fulfilling his promise (18:10; 21:1–3).

Genesis 20:3–7

God gave Abimelech a strong warning against committing adultery. This was a crime that could be punished by death (compare Exodus 20:14). The ancient Near East considered it "tremendous guilt" (Genesis 20:9).

Genesis 20:4–5

- Abimelech was innocent (20:6). He knew of no wrong he had done. But he was close to committing adultery. Not knowing the truth does not remove guilt (Leviticus 4:13–14).
- would You destroy a nation even though it is innocent?: Abimelech's plea to God echoes Abraham's earlier words (compare 18:23–32). It shows Abraham's lack of faith at this time.

Genesis 20:6

Because Abimelech acted with a clear conscience, God kept him from sinning. God will graciously help those who try to do what is right. When people act with reverence toward God, God gives them more revelation and draws them into more specific faith (see Acts 10).

Genesis 20:7

Abraham's prayer saved the king's life and restored his family (20:17–18). Abimelech learned that Abraham's God was sovereign (meaning God has complete power and authority over everything). Abraham, as God's prophet, received God's messages and would pray for others (see Numbers 12:13; Deuteronomy 9:20). This was true even if he did not always act like a prophet.

Genesis 20:8–10

Abraham received rebukes from Abimelech and God (compare 12:17–19). Abimelech was upset because Abraham's lie made him guilty of this serious sin (see study note on 20:3–7). Abimelech understood that taking a married woman into his harem (a group of wives and concubines) was wrong.

Genesis 20:11–13

Abraham's deceit was not just a brief loss of faith. Even after being scolded in Egypt, he used this strategy everywhere he traveled (compare 12:12–13). Living by faith requires perseverance.

Genesis 20:14–16

Abimelech showed he was an honorable person by making things right (see study note on 20:4–5). He made things right by letting Abraham live in the area. He also gave him slaves, livestock (compare 21:27), and 1,000 pieces of silver to make up for any wrong done to Sarah.

Genesis 20:17–18

The inability to have children suggests that some time had passed. God controls births. He decides when women can have children (25:21; 29:31; 30:2, 17, 22–23; 1 Samuel 1:19–20; Psalms 113:9; 127:3; Luke 1:13).

Genesis 21:1–2

See Genesis 18:10.

Genesis 21:3–4

Abraham responded in faith by naming his son Isaac and circumcising him according to the terms of the covenant (see 17:9–14).

Genesis 21:5

Isaac was born 25 years after God first made the promise to Abraham (compare 12:4).

Genesis 21:6

Sarah's made a wordplay with the name Isaac (Hebrew yitskhaq, meaning "he laughs"). It shows how laughing in disbelief turned to laughing in joy when God fulfilled the promise (18:12). Isaac's name might reflect the pleasure of God and his parents at his birth. Sarah knew everyone who heard about this would laugh and celebrate with her.

Genesis 21:6–7

Sarah was filled with joy and praise for this amazing event. Only God could enable her to have a child.

Genesis 21:8–9

The feast for Isaac's weaning probably happened when he was three. Ishmael was around 17 years old at that time (16:16). Sarah saw Ishmael mocking her son, Isaac. The verb metsakheq ("mocking") is related

to the word for "laughter." This theme (21:6) becomes negative because of Ishmael's mocking.

Genesis 21:8–21

God used the incident of Ishmael's mocking Isaac to separate Ishmael and Hagar from the family and the child of promise. They would constantly threaten the promised descendant if they remained with the family.

Genesis 21:10

Earlier, Sarah mistreated Hagar and forced her to flee (16:6). Later, when Hagar's son mistreated Isaac, Sarah insisted that the slave woman and her son leave.

Genesis 21:11–13

Abraham was upset when Sarah asked him to send Hagar and Ishmael away. God told Abraham to agree, promising that Ishmael would also have a future as Abraham's descendant.

Genesis 21:14–21

God rescued Hagar and Ishmael in the wilderness and promised them a future (compare 16:7–14). This passage is like chapter 16, but there are key differences. God saves Hagar and Ishmael, but there is no special naming. God repeats the promise to Hagar, but she is not told to return to Sarah.

These repeated themes show God's plan for Hagar and Ishmael. As Joseph later explained to Pharaoh, a repeated event confirms God's plan (41:32). God did not leave Hagar and Ishmael alone. He met them in their time of despair (compare 16:7). He gave them what they needed and promised again that Ishmael would start a great nation (21:13; see 16:11–12).

Paul uses this story in his letter to the Galatians to show that God's people must let go of anything that could block God's promise from being fulfilled (Galatians 4:21–31).

Genesis 21:16

a bowshot away: This means the distance an arrow can travel when someone shoots a bow. The phrase connects with Ishmael's future work as an archer (21:20).

Genesis 21:22–23

Abimelech wanted a treaty so that Abraham would not deceive him. He knew that God was blessing Abraham, even though Abraham had not always been truthful (20:9–10). This sad contradiction made the treaty necessary.

By contrast, God's people are called to speak truthfully. Paul teaches believers to speak the truth in love (Ephesians 4:15, 25). Jesus also warned against using oaths to distort the truth (Matthew 5:37; James 5:12).

Genesis 21:22–34

At the high point of this passage, it explains the name of Beersheba, where Abraham lived (21:31–34). The name is linked to the covenant (a binding agreement) that Abraham made with the people of the land. This agreement allowed him to live there in peace and safety.

In this way, God's promise was beginning to come true (12:7; 13:14–17; 15:7, 18–21; 17:8).

Genesis 21:25

The theme of the well appears again (see 16:14; 21:19). God provided water, symbolizing blessing, in the dry wilderness. Later, he even brought water from a rock for Israel (Exodus 15:22–27; 17:1–7; Numbers 20:1–13).

Genesis 21:27–31

Abraham gave gifts to Abimelec (compare 20:14). These gifts helped confirm his legal right to live peacefully in the land and to claim the well as his own. Beersheba marked another step toward the fulfillment (completion) of God's promise.

Genesis 21:32

The Philistines mentioned in Genesis are not the same as the Philistines in Judges through Kings. The earlier group had Semitic (ancient Near Eastern) names, such as Abimelech, and they followed Canaanite culture.

The later Philistines were likely from the Aegean region (near Greece). They had different customs and culture. They seem to have come to Canaan by sea around 1200 BC, during the time of the judges.

Because of this, the name Philistines in Genesis is probably used to describe the earlier people of the region in a way that later audiences would understand.

Genesis 21:33–34

- A tamarisk tree requires a lot of water. Planting it showed Abraham felt secure in his land rights and trusted God to provide water in the desert. Although he was a foreigner, living under the tree represented peaceful security (compare Zechariah 3:10).
- there he called upon the name of the LORD: See study note on 12:8.

Genesis 22:1

Some time later: Abraham had sent Ishmael away and settled in the land. Then God tested Abraham's faith by telling him to give up Isaac. This challenged Abraham's logic and understanding of God.

Would he still obey when God seemed to oppose him and the covenant? Would he hold onto the boy or surrender him to God (see Exodus 13:11–13)? Did he believe that God would still keep his promise and bless the world through Abraham's descendants?

Genesis 22:1–2

The biggest test in Abraham's life came after he finally had the promised child, Isaac, after waiting a long time. He had grown to love Isaac and enjoyed his company for many years.

Genesis 22:2

- Abraham's earlier obedience to God's calling (12:1–3) brought him great blessings. Now, he had a chance to show even greater obedience.
- Take your son ... Isaac, whom you love: God described Isaac in detail to remind Abraham that Isaac was his beloved son, reinforcing the cost of the sacrifice.
- The name Moriah is explained by the Chronicler (2 Chronicles 3:1) as the future site of the temple mount in Jerusalem.
- go: God worded the command this way to help Abraham remember his earlier call and obey again (12:1–3).

Genesis 22:3

Abraham's immediate and unquestioning obedience is as remarkable as the test itself.

Genesis 22:5

The boy and I will go over there to worship, and then we will return to you: Abraham's amazing statement makes us wonder what he was thinking. Abraham knew that God had planned the future of the covenant around Isaac and that God wanted him to sacrifice Isaac. He could not reconcile these things in his mind; he could only do what God commanded him to do, and leave the future to God (compare Hebrews 11:17–19).

Genesis 22:7–8

When Isaac asked, Abraham showed his faith in the Lord by saying, "God Himself will provide." But he did not know how. This idea is central to the entire story.

Genesis 22:9–19

God's intervention was dramatic and instructive, confirming that he never intended for Isaac to be sacrificed. God later made it clear that child sacrifice was an abomination to him (see Leviticus 18:21; 20:1–5; Deuteronomy 18:10; 2 Kings 16:2–3; Isaiah 57:5; Jeremiah 32:35). God wanted Abraham to sacrifice his own will and surrender it to God, and when he did, God intervened.

This story sets an example for all who worship through sacrifice. Like Abraham, true worshipers understand that everything belongs to God. They acknowledge that all things come from God and are his. A true worshiper obediently gives God what he asks for. They trust that God will provide all needs. Through this trust, they experience that God always provides.

Genesis 22:11

The angel of the Lord stopped Abraham just as he was ready to plunge the knife into his son.

Genesis 22:12

- Now God knew that Abraham would hold nothing back from him, that he did truly fear God. To fear the Lord means to reverence him as sovereign, trust him implicitly, and obey him without protest. The sacrifice that pleases God is a heart broken of self-will, surrendered to God (Psalms 40:6–8; 51:17).
- you have not withheld: Compare Romans 8:32, which uses the same verb ("spare") as the Greek Old Testament here. If God gave us his most precious possession, he will surely provide everything we need.

Genesis 22:13

God provided a ram caught by its horns in a bush for the sacrifice. God graciously allowed Abraham to substitute an animal sacrifice instead of Isaac. Later, all of Israel would offer animals to the Lord, understanding that God's grace allowed this substitution (Exodus 29:10; Leviticus 4:15; 16:20–22).

In the New Testament, God substituted his only son for all humanity. This perfect sacrifice was made once and for all people (Isaiah 53:6, 10; John 1:29; 10:1–14; Hebrews 7:27; 1 Peter 3:18).

Genesis 22:14

- As in many stories about the patriarchs (early fathers of Israel), the key meaning is preserved through naming. Yahweh-Yireh means "the Lord will provide" (see 22:8). The use of the divine name

Yahweh (the personal name of God) shows that the patriarchs knew this name (compare Exodus 6:2–3), even if they did not yet understand its full meaning (see study note on Exodus 6:2–3).
- to this day: Later Israelites saw this story as a lesson about their worship in Jerusalem. Abraham's sacrifice happened on the mountain of the Lord, which later became the site of the temple in Jerusalem (see study note on 22:2). Three times a year, the people of Israel brought their best offerings to God for sacrifice. They trusted he would continue to provide for them.

Genesis 22:15–19

After the event, God again confirmed his covenant with Abraham (compare 15:5, 18–21; 17:3–8). His descendants would be numerous:

- like the stars in the sky (compare 26:4),
- like the sand on the seashore (compare 32:12), and
- like the dust of the earth (compare 13:16; 28:14).

Genesis 22:16

By Myself: There is no higher name by which God can swear (Hebrews 6:13–17).

Genesis 22:17

Joshua and Old Testament Israel partially fulfilled the promise that Abraham's descendants would conquer the cities (literally take possession of the gates) of God's enemies. The church will completely fulfill this promise (compare Matthew 16:18 and the study note there).

Genesis 22:18–25.11

Abraham proved his faith. Afterward, he needed to pass the covenant blessings to Isaac. He bought a burial plot (chapter 23), found a wife for Isaac (chapter 24), and distributed his property (25:1–11).

Genesis 22:20

Milcah was the wife of Nahor. She was also his niece (see 11:29).

Genesis 22:20–24

A report came from the east that Abraham's brother Nahor (see 11:27–29) was doing well. The people in the next part of the story are introduced here.

Genesis 22:21

Uz may have been an ancestor of Job (Job 1:1).

Genesis 22:22–23

Bethuel was the youngest of Nahor's eight sons with Milcah. He was the father of Rebekah, who would become Isaac's wife (see 24:15, 67). Rebekah would succeed Sarah as the clan's female leader (23:1–2).

Genesis 23:1–2

- Sarah was 127 years old, and Isaac was 37 at this time (compare 17:17).
- Hebron: See the study note on 13:18.

Genesis 23:1–20

She died: Abraham bought a piece of land for Sarah's burial. This was the first sign of a permanent change, as people usually buried their dead in their ancestral homeland (compare 49:29–50:13). By burying Sarah, Abraham separated himself from his ancestral home (where his relatives still lived, 22:20–24). His future would be in Canaan, where his descendants would fulfill the promise.

Genesis 23:3–4

- Abraham negotiated with local Hittite elders to buy land for a burial site. These Hittites had moved south to Canaan from the large Hittite empire in what is now Turkey (compare 10:15).
- Abraham was a foreigner and an outsider among them. But he trusted God's promise that he would eventually own the land.

Genesis 23:5–6

- sir. You are God's chosen one (or prince; Hebrew my lord, you are a lifted up one of God): Either Abraham was well-respected by these people, or they were politely asking for his generosity.
- Bury your dead in the finest: They were ready to fulfill his request, especially if it meant they could legally bind him to themselves (23:11).

Genesis 23:7–16

Abraham wanted to buy Ephron's cave at Machpelah, but Ephron wanted him to buy the entire field.

Genesis 23:9

This cave would serve as the permanent burial site for Abraham's family. It was near Mamre (23:19), where Abraham lived (see 13:18; 14:13; 18:1). They would bury Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, and Jacob and Leah there (23:19; 25:9; 35:27–29; 49:29–31; 50:13). This marked their lasting presence in the promised land.

Genesis 23:11

Ephron did not intend to give the cave to Abraham for free. He expected Abraham to pay the full price. Ephron wanted to sell the cave to avoid taking care of it and to get the highest price possible.

Genesis 23:12–13

Abraham did not want the whole field, but he was willing to take it to get the cave.

Genesis 23:15

four hundred shekels of silver: This was a high price. Ephron's politeness was part of the usual bargaining process.

Genesis 23:16–20

Abraham paid the full amount and completed the deal. He avoided debt by not accepting gifts from the people (compare 14:21–24). The Hittite elders witnessed the deal, ensuring no one could dispute Abraham's ownership of the land. The transaction happened at the city gate, where they conducted public legal and business matters (see 19:1).

The land became Abraham's permanent property, a first step toward God's promise to give him the land. God had not yet fulfilled his promise with this purchase. Abraham knew it, so he planned for the future (12:7). By buying land for his dead, he showed that God's promises continue beyond this life. This is the hope for all who die with faith.

Genesis 24:1–9

Trusting in the Lord's promise, Abraham had his main servant promise to find a wife for Isaac (probably Eliezer, 15:2). Abraham told his servant to return to his relatives in his homeland, 724 kilometers away (about 450 miles). Abraham was faithful to the covenant by planning for Isaac's future.

Genesis 24:1–67

Isaac's marriage to Rebekah made it certain that God's plan would continue for the next generation. God showed his covenant faithfulness by working through his faithful people (24:12, 27, 49).

Genesis 24:2

The servant placed his hand under Abraham's thigh (compare 47:29). This was the custom when making a serious oath. The servant accepted the responsibility of completing this mission.

Genesis 24:3

Isaac knew how wicked and threatening the local Canaanite people were, so he maintained separation from them (compare 26:34–35; 27:46; 28:8–9).

Genesis 24:6–8

The servant was never to take Isaac out of the promised land to find a wife. Abraham protected Isaac and made sure God's promises would remain tied to the land of blessing.

Genesis 24:10

Aram-naharaim means "Aram of the two rivers." It was also known as Paddan-aram, which means "the field of Aram" (compare 25:20).

The journey took two weeks each way. So, the servant took 10 of his master's camels and departed with all kinds of gifts (24:22, 53).

Genesis 24:10–27

The servant obeyed his master's instructions and trusted God to lead him to the right woman.

Genesis 24:10–60

The servant faithfully completed his mission. God showed his faithful covenant love to Abraham's family by bringing all these details together. God was working quietly through these events to carry out his will through people who acted responsibly and in faith.

Genesis 24:14

Abraham's future daughter-in-law showed hospitality and hard work, similar to Abraham (see 18:1–8). Ten thirsty camels could drink 946 liters (250 gallons) of water. A woman willing to do that much work for a stranger was certainly not lazy, but generous and hospitable.

Genesis 24:15–22

The servant received a precise, immediate answer to his prayer for guidance.

Genesis 24:22

The servant thanked the girl by giving her expensive jewelry.

Genesis 24:23–24

God guided the servant to Abraham's relatives.

Genesis 24:25

Rebekah again showed kindness by offering lodging for the servant and food for his camels.

Genesis 24:26

The servant bowed to the ground and worshiped the Lord for his loyal love and faithfulness in guiding him to the exact family he sought.

Genesis 24:27

the LORD, the God of my master Abraham, who has not withheld His kindness and faithfulness from my master: These words express this chapter's message (compare 24:48). Believers can trust the Lord's leading because he is sovereign in all things. He never leaves his people to their own resources in carrying out his covenant work.

Genesis 24:29–31

Laban ... rushed: He did not want to miss the chance to marry off his sister and get more gifts. Laban's reaction to the servant's wealth hints at his greedy nature (see 24:54–56 and study note; 29:21–27; 30:27–36; 31:1–13).

Genesis 24:33–48

The servant stayed focused on his mission. He insisted on sharing his story before eating. He explained his mission and recognized God's providence in leading him to Rebekah. He did this before taking care of his own needs. The servant wanted everyone to understand that this was God's work, not a chance or humanly arranged meeting.

Genesis 24:48

The way that God directed this event from behind the scenes is different than in most of Genesis, but it is true to how the life of faith normally works. Faith, expressed in personal prayer and obedience, looks for evidence of God's working. Believers usually have to make wise choices and remain faithful to the covenant, trusting that God will guide them through the circumstances of life to accomplish his will.

Genesis 24:50–51

Following his testimony about God's guidance, the servant secured the family's blessing and permission to take Rebekah to his master's son Isaac.

Genesis 24:53

The servant gave expensive gifts to Rebekah, her mother, and her brother to conclude the arrangements.

Genesis 24:54–56

It was hard for Rebekah's family to let her go so suddenly, and Laban may have hoped to gain more wealth. However, the servant had sworn an oath and would not rest until it was completed. There was no reason for him to stay.

Genesis 24:57–58

Rebekah chose to leave at once to be with her new husband, which ended the disagreement. She accepted what seemed to be the Lord's clear leading.

In that culture, young women usually wanted to marry (not marrying brought great shame and hardship). Later stories about Laban help explain why Rebekah may have wanted to leave (compare 31:14–15).

Rebekah showed faithful love to the servant, to Abraham's family, and to Isaac by going to become his wife.

Genesis 24:60

When Rebekah left, her family blessed her, hoping she would become the mother of millions. They said, May your offspring possess the gates of their enemies. Rebekah's marriage to Isaac was part of God's plan to bless "all the families of the earth" (12:1–3).

Genesis 24:62

Isaac lived in the Negev, in the southern part of Canaan.

Genesis 24:67

Isaac was 40 years old when he married Rebekah (25:20), so Abraham was 140 (21:5).

Genesis 25:1

The exact time when Abraham married Keturah is unknown. It was probably after Sarah's death, but this is not certain.

Genesis 25:1–11

Even though Abraham had sons with another wife, he protected Isaac's inheritance and blessing.

Genesis 25:2–4

The birth of these nations from Abraham partially fulfilled God's promise to him (12:2; 17:4).

Genesis 25:3

Sheba and Dedan: Compare 10:7. Abraham's descendants probably settled in these regions. They became known by these names, along with people from other family lines.

Genesis 25:5–6

Abraham loved all his sons, so before he died, he gave them gifts and sent them away as he had sent Ishmael (21:8–14). This made certain that Isaac remained his heir.

Genesis 25:7–8

These verses mention Abraham's death before Jacob and Esau are born. But he actually lived until they were 15 years old (25:19–26; compare 21:5; 25:26). This storytelling choice ends Abraham's story before focusing on Isaac's family.

Genesis 25:11

God blessed his son Isaac. Abraham had sent his other sons away. Isaac lived near Beer-lahai-roi, a special place where God answered prayers (16:14) and where Isaac waited for the Lord (24:62).

Genesis 25:12–18

This record lists Ishmael's descendants before giving the details of Isaac's descendants (see 25:19–35:29). This follows the literary structure of Genesis (see Genesis Book Introduction, "Summary").

Genesis 25:16

Ishmael's 12 sons fulfilled God's promise of blessings (Genesis 17:20).

Genesis 25:18

- Havilah was a region in north-central Arabia.
- Shur was an area between Beersheba and Egypt.
- And they lived in hostility toward all their brothers: This wording is similar to 16:12.

Genesis 25:19–20

Isaac ... married Rebekah: Isaac's marriage connected him and his family more closely to Abraham's relatives. If he had married a Canaanite woman, the faith of the covenant could have been endangered by these corrupt people and their mixed worship.

Genesis 25:19–26

Jacob's struggle to be greater than his brother began before the twins were born (see Hosea 12:3).

Genesis 25:19–35.29

This account of the family of Isaac, the chosen son of Abraham, mostly recounts Jacob's struggle for the blessing (25:27–34; chapters 27–33).

Genesis 25:21

- For 20 years, Rebekah could not have children (compare 25:20, 26), similar to Sarah (see 16:1). This condition tested their faith (see study note on 16:1–3). How could they be childless when God promised that nations would come from them?
- Isaac begged the Lord for help, and the Lord answered his prayer. Isaac seemed to learn from his father's mistake and acted with faith.

Genesis 25:22

When Rebekah's pregnancy was difficult, she went to ask the LORD about it. She likely did this by visiting a prophet (a person who speaks God's message), possibly Abraham (20:7; see study note on 25:7–8).

Genesis 25:23

- nations: Jacob and Esau fought in the womb, and their descendants (Israel and Edom) fought continuously throughout their history. In their many conflicts, Israel achieved supremacy over Edom.
- the older will serve younger: God chose the younger son over the elder, which went against the usual order (compare 48:12–14; see Malachi 1:1–3; Romans 9:11–16).

Genesis 25:24–26

When the twins were born, the unusual circumstances inspired each boy's name and hinted at what would happen to them in the future.

Genesis 25:25

- Two wordplays anticipate Esau's future. Esau sounds like the Hebrew word se'ar, meaning "hair." Esau's later homeland was Edom. Another name for it was Seir ("hairy") because it was wooded (as though covered with hair).
- red (Hebrew 'admoni): This Hebrew word sounds like Esau's other name, Edom, which had red soil (25:27–34).
- hair like a fur coat: This suggests his unspiritual character (25:34; Hebrews 12:16; compare Leviticus 26:22; Deuteronomy 7:22; 1 Corinthians 15:32). The

description of the child uses words that emphasize the Edomites' character.

Genesis 25:26

The name Jacob (Hebrew ya'aqob, from Hebrew 'aqeb, "heel, footprint") was originally positive, meaning "protect" (like a rear guard), but it took on the negative meaning of "heel grabber" or "deceiver" in the context of Jacob's deceptive, grasping, usurping character (see 27:36).

Genesis 25:27

- Esau became a skilled hunter, a man of the field: He was a wild man who enjoyed the wild country.
- Jacob was a quiet man who stayed at home (literally a mature/perfect man dwelling in tents): He lived in tents and had good manners.

Genesis 25:27–34

Jacob and Esau developed according to their early traits (25:24–26).

Esau, the reddish, hairy man, cared about physical things rather than spiritual things (see Hebrews 12:16). His desires eventually overcame him and he sold his birthright.

Jacob, the heel grabber, knew the birthright's value. He made a ruthless deal to win it from his brother.

Genesis 25:28

- Each parent had a favorite child.
- Because: Isaac loved Esau because of his hunting ability. Rebekah had a constant and unconditional love for Jacob.

Genesis 25:29

- Jacob was actually more cunning than Esau. The word for cooking (Hebrew wayyazed, meaning "boiling") sounds like the word for hunter (Hebrew tsayid). While Jacob was boiling stew, he was also setting a trap for Esau, who is described as hairy and red. He may have waited a long time for this moment.

The word for cooking can also describe acting without proper limits, like water boiling over a pot. In this way, Jacob went too far when he took the promise for himself. By contrast, Abraham trusted that the promise was already his, so he was willing to give the land to others (see study note on 13:8–13).

- Esau was tired and hungry, but his life was not in danger (25:32; see study note on 25:33–34).

Genesis 25:30

- Esau focused only on his hunger. When a person is controlled by physical desires like this, there is no room for spiritual values. The text shows this clearly by using a Hebrew word (translated "Let me eat") that was often used when feeding animals.
- Edom means "red." See study note on 25:25.

Genesis 25:31–33

On this occasion, Jacob proved to be the better hunter. However, strong ambition like this can be dangerous. God's people should desire what God desires, but they must not try to gain these things by human effort (see Zechariah 4:6; Galatians 5:16–17; Ephesians 6:10–12).

The Lord dealt strictly with Jacob to remove his sinful methods. Later, he received the promise not as Jacob the deceiver, but as Israel (which means "God fights"). God fought on his behalf (Genesis 32:28).

Genesis 25:33–34

Esau quickly accepted what Jacob offered and fell into his trap. He ate and left so quickly that he could not have been close to death (25:32). The final comment in the passage explains that Esau treated his birthright with contempt, as if it had no value (Hebrews 12:16). It is foolish to give up spiritual blessings just to satisfy physical desires (compare Genesis 3:6).

Genesis 26:1

This Abimelech is probably not the same person from chapter 20 because these events could be 90 years apart. Abimelech might have been the name of a dynasty or a title. First Samuel 21:10 mentions a later King Achish, who was also called Abimelech (Psalm 34:title).

Genesis 26:1–35

This section pauses Jacob's story to focus on Isaac. Isaac's success and wealth in chapter 26 show that God's blessing had passed to him (compare 25:11), even though he sometimes failed to trust God.

Genesis 26:2–5

The Lord assured Isaac that the covenant promises (compare 12:2–3; 15:5–8; 17:3–8; 22:15–18; 28:13–14) would pass to him because Abraham faithfully listened to God and obeyed all his requirements, commands, decrees, and instructions. These terms were later used in Deuteronomy to describe God's full legal covenant with Israel.

An Israelite would immediately think of the complete Torah when hearing these words and be prompted to obey God's law as Abraham did, though Abraham had only a few commands from the Lord. Through these words, the text emphasizes that Abraham would have obeyed the later commands if he had had them, because he was an obedient servant of the Lord.

Genesis 26:6–11

While Isaac was living in Gerar, he, like his father Abraham, told people that his wife was his sister. Some think this story repeats the accounts of Abraham's deception (12:10–20; 20:1–18). But there are more differences than similarities. It is not surprising that a son repeated his father's lie.

Genesis 26 shows, through many similar patterns, that God's plan continued through Isaac. Even when Isaac put the covenant at risk, as Abraham had done, God prevented something terrible from happening and protected the marriage. God would bless Abraham's descendants because of Abraham, but they still needed to trust God themselves to experience those blessings.

True faith in God's promises leads to a life without fear as one follows him. Fear, however, can put the blessing at risk and make a person's faith seem empty.

Genesis 26:8

Abimelech ... looked down ... to see Isaac caressing his wife Rebekah: The Hebrew word for "caressing" is the same as the word used for Ishmael "mocking" Isaac (21:9). This Hebrew word is also related to the name Isaac (Hebrew yitskhaq). It is as if Isaac's lack of faith made Abimelech look foolish and brought shame on Rebekah and on the great promise connected to Isaac's name.

Genesis 26:10–11

Isaac, like his father, was rebuked by Abimelech (see study note on 20:1–18). This legal wording would remind Israel of how important it was to preserve marital purity. Abimelech recognized the danger to his own people. Though his decree preserved his own society, it was also a word from God that preserved the sanctity of Isaac's and Israel's marriages. If Isaac's marriage had ended here, there would have been no Israelite society.

Genesis 26:12–13

Isaac lived in the land as a temporary resident. God blessed him, so his crops grew well and he became very rich.

Genesis 26:14–16

The Philistines were jealous of Isaac's success and filled his wells with dirt. The king then told Isaac to leave the area because he was too powerful for them (compare 21:22–23).

Genesis 26:17–22

Isaac left ... in the Valley of Gerar: This was away from the city of Gerar itself, but probably still within 16 kilometers (10 miles).

When he got there, Isaac reopened the wells of his father. Although people opposed him there, Isaac chose not to fight back. He gave up one well after another until God's blessing overcame the opposition. Whenever Isaac reopened a well, even if enemies filled it in, he found water. God blessed Isaac, and nothing could stop it. Finally, the Philistines left Isaac alone.

Genesis 26:23–25

Beersheba ... the Lord appeared him: This was to confirm his covenant (compare 21:31–33). Isaac showed faith like his father by building an altar to the Lord. He declared the Lord's identity and nature (see study note on 12:8; 21:33).

Genesis 26:26–33

This oath is like the one a previous king made with Abraham (see 21:22–31). This king acknowledged that God was blessing Isaac. He understood that an oath with Isaac would be beneficial.

No opposition can stop God's blessing. It will flourish, and other nations will notice it. They will seek peace with God's people to share in the blessing.

Genesis 26:33

Since the earlier treaty was renewed with Isaac, the name of the well was also renewed by the oath.

Genesis 26:34–35

Esau's marriages show how he was not suitable to lead God's covenant people into receiving God's blessings. Isaac's later attempt to bless Esau was foolish (27:1–40). Later, Esau married a third wife, trying to make things right without success (28:6–9).

Genesis 27:1–4

- The first scene introduces the main problem in the chapter. Isaac knew about God's oracle (a message from God; 25:22–23), but he went against it or ignored it when he tried to bless Esau.

- Isaac was old and his eyes were so weak that he could no longer see: This shows that he was losing awareness, both physically and spiritually.

Genesis 27:1–40

Jacob got his father Isaac's blessing through deception. In this story, an entire family tries to carry out their responsibilities by physical means rather than by faith. Faith would have provided Rebekah and Jacob a more honorable solution to the crisis.

Genesis 27:3–4

Like Esau, Isaac let his love of tasty food control his affections (compare 25:28–34).

Genesis 27:5

Esau agreed to Isaac's plan. In doing so, he broke the oath he had sworn to Jacob (25:33).

Genesis 27:5–17

The blessing seemed to be at risk. In the second scene, Rebekah and Jacob tried to gain God's blessing through deception, rather than through faith and love. Rebekah made a plan to trick Isaac, who was old, into thinking he was blessing Esau when he was actually blessing Jacob.

Genesis 27:11–12

Jacob had no problem tricking his father. He only worried it might fail and Isaac would curse him for attempting it.

Genesis 27:18–20

Jacob lied about his identity, and then came close to blasphemy (speaking in a way that dishonors God) by lying about God.

Genesis 27:18–29

In scene three, Jacob tricks his father and receives the blessing.

Genesis 27:20–27

Isaac expressed his doubts three times. But his senses, which were not working well, eventually misled him (see study note on 27:1–4).

Genesis 27:30–40

In scene four, everything is discovered, and the family becomes even more divided.

Genesis 27:33

When Isaac understood what happened, he started shaking uncontrollably. He had tried to change God's plan, but God stopped him.

Genesis 27:34–35

Esau was very bitter and angry enough to kill. After Jacob received their father's blessing, Esau planned to take his brother's life (27:41).

Genesis 27:36

- he has cheated me twice (or tripped me up, or deceived me): Esau started to understand Jacob's true nature. Jacob took the birthright (the right of inheritance, Hebrew bekorah; 25:27–34). He tricked their father to get the blessing (the spoken pronouncement of the inheritance, Hebrew berakah).
- Esau was right in how he judged Jacob, but he did not recognize his own ungodliness in these actions (see study note on 27:5; Hebrews 12:16).

Genesis 27:37

There was no way to undo the blessing. Isaac had declared a message from God, who had made Jacob to be Esau's master (see Romans 9:11–13).

Genesis 27:39–40

All that remained for Esau was a promise of hardship and struggle (compare 3:17–19; 16:11–12).

Genesis 27:41–45

Rebekah and Jacob received the blessing, but Esau hated them for it. They also separated from one another. The Bible does not indicate that Rebekah and Jacob ever saw each other again.

They gained nothing that God would not have given them anyway. Their actions came at the expense of their relationship. Jacob had to flee from home to escape Esau's vengeance.

Genesis 27:42–33.17

Jacob met the Lord on a road that Abraham had traveled 125 years earlier. The story in 27:42–33:17 follows a pattern (called a "chiasm") focusing on Jacob's exile:

- A: Jacob runs away from Esau (27:42–28:9)
- B: Angels of God meet Jacob at Bethel (28:10–22)
- C: Jacob lives in exile in Paddan-aram (29:1–31:55)
- B': Angels of God meet Jacob at Mahanaim (32:1–2)
- A': Jacob reconciles with Esau (32:3–33:17).

Genesis 27:46

Rebekah convinced Isaac to send Jacob away by carefully planning her words and actions. Like Isaac, Jacob married a woman from his relatives who lived in the east.

Genesis 28:1–2

- Isaac stayed in the land, but Jacob had to leave. God would deal with Jacob through his uncle Laban (see study note on 29:1–31:55).
- Believers must remain spiritually pure by marrying other believers (2 Corinthians 6:14–18). The Canaanites had many groups and clans among their people through wars, treaties, and marriages (see Genesis 34:20–23).

Abraham's family was to resist such mixing (compare 24:3; chapter 34). They were supposed to marry within their clan to maintain the purity of the line and of the faith that identified them as the chosen people. The surest way to lose their distinctiveness was to intermarry with people of other tribal backgrounds and beliefs (see Ezra 9–10; Nehemiah 13:23–29).

Genesis 28:3–5

Before Jacob departed, Isaac gave him a pure, legitimate blessing. He did not hold back, because he now knew what God wanted him to do. Isaac clearly passed on the blessing God Almighty (Hebrew El-Shaddai; see 17:1) had given to Abraham and to him regarding prosperity and the land (compare 15:5, 18–20).

Genesis 28:6–9

Esau, the unchosen son still trying to please his father, married a woman from the unchosen line of Ishmael, which he thought would be more acceptable. He did not understand the uniqueness of the covenant family.

Genesis 28:10–22

Even though Jacob used deceptive methods to get the blessing, God promised to protect and provide for him. The God of Abraham and Isaac was also the God of Jacob. This revelation greatly changed Jacob's perspective and brought faith into clearer focus.

Genesis 28:11

Jacob set up camp in a safe spot at the base of a hill. He probably used a large stone more for protection than as a pillow.

Genesis 28:12–13

- ladder: This word occurs nowhere else in Scripture. The image may have reminded people at that time of a stairway or ramp on the front of a ziggurat (a large temple tower in ancient Mesopotamia). Such a structure was thought to connect heaven and earth (see study note on 11:4).

In this passage, God begins direct communication between heaven and earth to guide and protect Jacob, who carries his covenant (28:13–15; see Psalm 91:11–15).

- Jesus later said that he himself is the way between heaven and earth (John 1:51).

Genesis 28:12–15

The vision showed that God and his angels were with Jacob on his journey. God reminded Jacob of the promises made to Abraham and Isaac. He promised Jacob land, descendants as numerous as dust (compare 13:16; 22:17), and blessings for all people through him (compare 12:2–3; 15:5, 18; 17:3–8; 22:15–18; 35:11–12). God also promised to be with Jacob and protect him until he returned.

Genesis 28:14

Jacob inherited Abraham's entire covenant (see 22:17), which confirmed Isaac's blessing (28:3–4) and showed that Jacob would live away from home for a time (28:15; see 15:12–16).

Genesis 28:15

I am with you: The promise of God's presence meant that God would protect and provide for Jacob in a special way. God's promise to be with his people is repeated throughout Scripture (see also 26:24). It encourages those who have faith to respond with worship and confidence (28:16–22).

Genesis 28:16–22

The second part of the passage describes Jacob's response to God's revelation. He felt reverence and awe in God's presence. His acts of devotion became models for Israel's worship.

When God graciously visits his people and promises to be with them and make them a blessing to the world, his people respond in faith with reverence, worship, offerings, and vows. They preserve their faith in memory for future worshipers.

Genesis 28:18

Anointing with oil became a way of setting something apart for divine use in Israel's worship (Exodus 29:1–7; 40:9; Leviticus 2:1; 1 Samuel 10:1).

Genesis 28:19

Bethel later became a holy site for Israel (see Judges 20:18–27; 1 Samuel 7:16; 10:3; 1 Kings 12:26–13:10; 2 Kings 2:2–3).

Genesis 28:20–22

In view of what God would do for him, Jacob vowed to do certain things for God. He believed the Lord's words and responded in gratitude. Jacob's vow influenced Israel's way of making commitments to God in worship.

Genesis 28:22

I will surely You a tenth: By paying a tithe (a tenth) as an act of worship, a person acknowledges that everything is a gift from God and belongs to God (see 14:19–20; Numbers 18:21–32; Deuteronomy 14:22–29; 2 Chronicles 31:5–6; Malachi 3:7–12; Matthew 23:23).

Genesis 29:1

Jacob resumed his journey: The Hebrew text can be literally translated as he "lifted up his feet," suggesting he felt inspired. He continued his journey with renewed enthusiasm. This change in attitude came from the vision he received at Bethel.

It was a wonderful revelation that God would protect and bless him. Now, he expected God's promises to come true, not only to escape from Esau. Jacob's attitude had become positive and magnanimous to the point of being naive and vulnerable.

Genesis 29:1–31.55

- These chapters describe how God fulfilled his promise by greatly blessing Jacob with a family and possessions. God also disciplined Jacob, leaving him to struggle with Laban for many years. Laban was Jacob's match in deception, and thus a means of correction.
- The story of Jacob and Laban is similar to Israel's later stay in Egypt. Jacob struggled while serving his uncle but finally emerged with a large family (the founders of the 12 tribes) and great wealth. In Egypt, the Israelites suffered under their oppressors, but they also flourished, becoming a great nation of 12 large tribes and escaping with great riches.

Genesis 29:2–12

Jacob met Rachel at the well at just the right time. This happened under God's guidance, because God rules over all things (God is sovereign). God was leading Jacob toward the fulfillment of his promises (see 24:12–20). The well was a reminder of God's blessing (compare 16:13–14; 21:19; 26:19–25, 33).

Genesis 29:10

- Unlike the lazy, unhelpful shepherds (29:7–8), this verse shows Jacob to be generous, hardworking, and energetic.
- watered his uncle's sheep: Laban's flocks would thrive under Jacob's care.

Genesis 29:11

Jacob kissed Rachel: Kissing relatives was an appropriate way to greet them (29:13; compare Song 8:1).

Genesis 29:14

You are indeed my own flesh and blood: Laban welcomed Jacob into his house and treated him much like a son.

Genesis 29:14–30

Jacob looked forward with joy to marrying Rachel, but this hope became a time of testing. Laban acted with shrewdness (clever but not honest behavior), and Jacob was disciplined (corrected and trained). Jacob and his mother had deceived his father and brother to gain the blessing. Now Laban, his mother's brother, deceived him.

Jacob experienced the results of his own dishonesty through 20 years of hard work, suffering, and being misled while serving Laban (31:38).

In God's fair judgment, people receive what they do (Galatians 6:7). Laban's actions helped Jacob see his own tendency to deceive others. God often brings people into the lives of believers to discipline them. But Jacob was determined, and God greatly blessed him with a large family and many possessions during this time of service (30:25–43).

Genesis 29:18

Seven years of service was a high bride-price in the ancient world, but Rachel was beautiful (like Sarah and Rebekah), and Jacob was in love with her.

Genesis 29:23–26

- Like Isaac, Jacob was given food and wine (compare 27:25). He could not see in the darkness (compare

27:1). He became confused by clothing (compare 27:15) and misled by touch (compare 27:23).
- The marriage had already been completed (the husband and wife had come together as one; 29:23; compare 2:24). Because of this, Jacob was bound to Leah.
- It is not our custom here to give the younger daughter in marriage before the older: Laban's words are a reminder of what Jacob did when he, the younger son, pretended to be his older brother to gain the blessing (chapter 27). Now Leah, the older sister, pretended to be the younger sister to get a husband. God gave the deceiver a dose of his own deception as a discipline in his life.

Genesis 29:28–30

After the bridal week ended, Jacob also married Rachel (29:27). But he had to work another seven years (see 31:41). Laban seemed to have the advantage.

Genesis 29:30

he loved Rachel more than Leah: This kind of favoritism (showing special love to one person over others) caused ongoing trouble in his family (see 25:28; 37:3). Jacob's favoritism had lasting effects. His family was often divided, and their descendants (the tribes of Israel) were rarely united.

Genesis 29:31–35

- Leah's first four sons were born in rapid succession, but Rachel could not conceive. She was unable to have children, like Sarah and Rebekah (compare 16:1; 25:21; see also 1 Samuel 1:1–28; Luke 1:5–25).
- Each name is a memorable wordplay on Leah's experience and hopes.

Genesis 29:31–30.24

- The rivalry between these sisters explains much of the later conflict among their sons, and then among the tribes. This is similar to how Jacob and Laban's rivalry predicted future conflicts between Israel and the Arameans of Damascus (2 Samuel 8:5–6; 10:8–19; 1 Kings 20:1–34; 2 Kings 5:1–8:29; 13:1–25; Isaiah 7:1–9).
- God fights for the cause of the poor and oppressed. He honored Leah, the despised first wife, by making her the first mother. Judah's royal tribe and Levi's priestly line came from her. This was despite Jacob's favoritism for Rachel and her children.

Despite the tension and jealousy resulting from Laban's deceit and Jacob's favoritism, God still grew Jacob's family and brought about the births of the tribal ancestors.

Genesis 29:32

The LORD has seen my affliction: The name Reuben (from the Hebrew re'uben) sounds like the Hebrew phrase ra'ah be'onyi, which means "he has seen my affliction." Leah felt that God had seen her suffering and had comforted her when her son was born, and she hoped that Jacob would now love her.

Jacob did not notice her suffering, but God did (compare 16:14; 24:62; 25:11). The name was a reminder of God's care and help.

Genesis 29:33

Leah named her second son Simeon. The name suggests that she had cried out to the Lord and was heard (compare 16:11).

Genesis 29:34

Leah named her third son Levi because she hoped her husband would become attached to her after she had borne him three sons. The name Levi sounds like the Hebrew word for "attached" or "joined." But this did not happen.

Genesis 29:35

Leah accepted that Jacob would never love her. She named her fourth son Judah, saying, "I will praise the Lord." In Hebrew, Judah means "praised." She appeared to have stopped hoping for Jacob's love and found comfort in the Lord.

Genesis 30:1–2

In that culture, for a woman not to have children could feel like a kind of death (compare 1 Samuel 1). Only God could enable Rachel to have children.

Genesis 30:1–8

Rachel's naming of sons through Bilhah does not reflect faith as Leah's namings had. Rachel felt wronged over the marriage and her barrenness. The names of Bilhah's sons reflect Rachel's bitter struggle with her sister and her feeling of some victory.

Genesis 30:3–4

Rachel decided to have children through her servant, and Jacob agreed. This is similar to Sarai using Hagar (16:1–4).

Genesis 30:5–6

Dan means "he judged" or "he vindicated." Rachel felt justified (Hebrew dananni) by Dan's birth.

Genesis 30:7–8

The name Naphtali is related to the phrase In my great struggles. In Hebrew, the phrase is naptule 'elohim niptalti, which means "I have struggled the struggles of God."

Genesis 30:9

When Leah saw that she had stopped having children, she gave her servant Zilpah to Jacob as a wife, even though she already had four sons.

Genesis 30:10–13

Gad (meaning "fortune") was the name of a god associated with fortune. Asher (meaning "happy") was the name of a god associated with luck. These names show Leah's pagan background, but there is no indication she believed in these gods.

Genesis 30:14–17

People believed mandrakes could increase sexual desire and help women become pregnant (see Song 7:13). Rachel hoped they would help her become pregnant, so she made a deal with Leah. Rachel would let Leah spend one night with Jacob in exchange for mandrakes. Yet, Leah became pregnant, not Rachel.

Genesis 30:18

The name Issachar reflects this idea of being hired or receiving payment. It reminds readers of the events surrounding his birth. Leah says that Jacob was "hired" for the night (Genesis 30:16). The Hebrew word sekari means "my hire."

Genesis 30:19–20

Zebulun means "honor" or "gift," like a dowry or tribute. Leah believed God gave her Zebulun so her husband would honor her. She always hoped this would happen.

Genesis 30:21

Dinah was the only daughter of Jacob. See chapter 34.

Genesis 30:22–24

- Rachel finally had her own son, Joseph, thanks to God's intervention. His birth was not due to superstitions (30:14–16) or the custom of giving servants as wives.
- The Hebrew word translated as "taken away" ('asap) sounds similar to the name Joseph (yosep), which means "may he add." Rachel was happy about Joseph's birth and prayed for another son.

Genesis 30:25–34

After working for fourteen years, Jacob asked Laban if he could return home. The two nomadic leaders negotiated politely but stayed cautious. Laban wanted more from Jacob, while Jacob wanted to earn his wages through selective breeding.

Genesis 30:27

blessed me: God made Laban successful because Jacob was with him (see 22:18). Laban may have looked for signs (omens) to understand what was happening, or he may simply have noticed the results. Dark-colored sheep were uncommon (30:32). So, people considered having many of this color as a sign of God's blessing.

Genesis 30:30–33

Jacob agreed that God had blessed Laban through him, so he made a plan to gain something for himself. He proposed for his wages the rare black and multicolored goats and the speckled and spotted sheep that were born.

Genesis 30:32

As Abraham had done with Lot (13:9), Jacob gave Laban what he valued most. White sheep were more common and more valuable than dark or multicolored sheep; as a man of faith, Jacob was willing to take the rejects (compare 1 Corinthians 1:26).

Genesis 30:34–36

- Laban said he agreed with Jacob's plan, but he tried to prevent Jacob from gaining wealth by removing animals from the flock that would fulfill the agreement.
- Laban's deception with the goats is similar to Jacob's deception with Esau (compare 27:9; see study note on 29:14–30).

Genesis 30:37

exposing the white inner wood: This clever wordplay explains the entire section. When Jacob exposed the white (Hebrew laban) streaks of wood underneath, he played the "white" game (the Laban game) and won. By outsmarting Laban ("Whitey"), Jacob's flocks increased and he became successful.

Genesis 30:37–43

God blessed Jacob even though Laban was deceitful. Jacob cleverly used selective breeding to grow his flock. He followed the traditional belief that peeled sticks could affect the type of animals born.

The peeled branches seemed to help his animals produce streaked and spotted offspring. Jacob later admitted that God had helped him succeed (31:7–12). Jacob ended up with stronger animals, while Laban got the weaker ones (30:41–42).

Genesis 30:42

Laban now received what he deserved for how he treated Jacob. His attempt to cheat Jacob led to Jacob gaining more, because God was working in Jacob's life.

Genesis 30:43

Jacob became very wealthy, in fulfillment of God's promises to him (27:28; 28:13–15).

Genesis 31:1–2

Laban's sons became more hostile toward Jacob because his flocks were growing faster than theirs. They were jealous because God was blessing Jacob. They were also afraid that he might take over everything they had.

Genesis 31:1–21

Jacob's return journey led to a conflict with Laban. This conflict created a lasting boundary between Israel (Jacob) and Aram (Laban). God kept his promise to Jacob. He made Jacob successful in Paddan-aram and protected him as he traveled back home.

Genesis 31:3

- the land of your fathers was Canaan, to which God had called Abraham (12:1–7; 17:8).
- Go back ... I will be with you: See study notes on 26:2–5; 28:12–15. God protected Jacob (also called "Israel," 32:28) as he led his family back to the land God promised them. Later, God brought Israel back to Canaan after many years of slavery in Egypt.

This return had many similarities to this passage:
- God defeated foreign gods and beliefs.
- He used dreams for rescue and protection.
- He gave victory over threats.
- He set boundaries between nations and tribes (see Deuteronomy 32:8).

Genesis 31:4–13

Jacob explained to his wives how God had blessed him, even though Laban opposed him. He was not sure if they wanted to leave Laban and move to Canaan. He wanted his family to agree willingly, so he needed to persuade them. He shared how God had guided and provided for them over the years. He explained that he needed to keep the vow he made at Bethel (28:20–22).

Genesis 31:14–16

The women quickly agreed to go with Jacob because God had blessed him. They were very willing to leave Laban, who had wasted their wealth (the property meant to support them). They understood that what God gave Jacob would also belong to them.

Genesis 31:17–21

Jacob left Laban secretly because he was afraid of revenge (31:31).

Genesis 31:19–20

- Rachel stole her father's household idols: She might have wanted to recover some of the wealth Laban wasted. She may have also worshiped idols (compare 35:2–4). Having the idols might have meant claiming the family inheritance, as later customs indicate. Laban seemed to feel insecure without them. Whatever her reasons, Rachel's theft nearly caused disaster for the family when Laban overtook them.
- A wordplay shows that Rachel and Jacob were very similar—Rachel stole (Hebrew wattignob) Laban's household gods. Jacob tricked (Hebrew wayyignob, "stole the heart of, deceived") Laban.

Genesis 31:21

The journey took the family from Haran southwest to the land of Gilead, just east of the Jordan River in the north of today's kingdom of Jordan.

Genesis 31:22–23

- The theft of the idols (31:19) probably caused Laban and his men to chase Jacob. It was one thing for Jacob to take his family and flocks (Laban probably still thought they were his). But taking the household gods was different. Laban might have feared Jacob would return to claim all of Laban's property. When he could not find the gods, he asked for a treaty to keep Jacob away (31:43–53).
- It took Laban seven days to overtake Jacob.

Genesis 31:24

Be careful not to say anything to Jacob, either good or bad: God told Laban not to try to bring justice himself. When we try to enact our own sense of good and evil apart from God's command, we always do evil (see study note on 2:9).

Genesis 31:25–30

The dispute between the two men used the language of legal controversies and lawsuits (see also 31:36). Laban first argued that Jacob had wronged him by stealing from him.

Genesis 31:32

Jacob was so sure he did not have the gods that he made an oath that unknowingly put Rachel under a death sentence.

Genesis 31:33–35

Laban searched for the idols but did not find them. He did not think that a woman in her monthly bleeding would make the idols ceremonially unclean by sitting on them (see Leviticus 15:19–24).

Genesis 31:36–42

Jacob answered by accusing Laban of making false charges and humiliating him. Now Laban was the one who had to answer, because his charges were insulting and seemed to have no basis.

Genesis 31:40

Jacob, who preferred life at home (25:27)**,** had spent 20 years enduring the hardships of outdoor life, which Esau had loved.

Genesis 31:42

the Fear of Isaac: This is a name for God used here and in 31:53. It does not mean that Isaac was afraid of God in a negative way. Here, fear means deep respect, honor, and awe for God.

God was with Jacob (31:3). God saw Jacob's hard work and faithfulness, even though Laban treated him badly. God rewarded Jacob. Laban's dream showed Jacob that he was right.

Genesis 31:43–44

Laban wanted a treaty to end the dispute because he felt unsafe and wanted to secure the borders. Jacob did not need a treaty because God had provided for him and protected him.

Genesis 31:45–48

The stone and the pillar marked the border agreement between the two men. It was a witness for future generations. Each man named the monument witness in his own language. It became the lasting border between Israel and the kingdom of Aram (Syria), two nations often at war.

Genesis 31:49

The pile of stones was also called Mizpah (which means "watchtower"). God would watch over Jacob and Laban to keep them apart, because they did not trust each other.

Genesis 31:50–53

Laban added conditions to the treaty to try to justify himself. He used many words to hide his own dishonesty and make Jacob look unethical. He even claimed credit for the monument Jacob had built ("here is the pillar I have set up," 31:51). The women and children would be safer and better cared for with Jacob than they ever were with Laban.

Genesis 32:1

God promised Jacob protection when he needed comfort the most. Jacob's journey was a physical return to his homeland and a spiritual return to God's promised land. God protects his people and fulfills his plan.

Genesis 32:2

- This is the camp of God: Jacob probably saw the angels as a sign of God's protection, similar to the earlier vision when he left the land (28:10–22).
- Mahanaim (meaning "two camps"): Jacob's group and the group of angels were together in one place.

Genesis 32:3–5

Apparently inspired by the vision of angels (32:1, Hebrew mal'akim), Jacob sent messengers (mal'akim) into Edom to meet Esau.

Genesis 32:7–8

Jacob divided his company into two groups or camps (Hebrew makhanoth, related to "Mahanaim" in 32:2). This was because he was afraid. Jacob remembered Esau's character and his threat to kill him (see 25:25; 27:41).

Genesis 32:9–12

Jacob's prayer is a wonderful example of how to address God. He based his appeal on God's will, reminding God of his relationship with him, his command for him to return to the land, and his promise (32:9). He had a correct attitude of genuine humility and total dependence on God (32:10). Finally, he asked that God rescue him from his brother, and he repeated God's promises (see 22:17).

Genesis 32:13–21

Taking a large portion of the wealth God had blessed him with (some 550 animals), Jacob prepared a gift to appease Esau's anger and gain his favor.

Genesis 32:22–24

The Jabbok River flows westward to the Jordan Valley, dividing the region of Bashan on the north from Gilead on the south.

Wordplays on Jacob's name and character preserve the memory of this encounter. Jacob (Hebrew ya'aqob), while at Jabbok (Hebrew yabboq), wrestled (Hebrew wayye'abeq). Through his fight with an adversary to receive the blessing, Jacob's name would be changed, and his deceptive striving would partially give way to faith as his way of life.

Genesis 32:22–32

Jacob went back to the land God promised him. Before this, God met, injured, and blessed him. God also changed his name to Israel. This event was a significant turning point for Jacob.

Genesis 32:24

- a man wrestled: The story develops just as it did for Jacob. We do not know any details about the attacker, who later refused to reveal his identity (32:29).
- until daybreak: The darkness matched Jacob's situation, adding to his fear and uncertainty. In the dark, he could not tell who it was. It might have been one of Esau's or Laban's men.

Genesis 32:25

he struck the socket of Jacob's hip and dislocated it: Jacob, who had struggled and deceived others, could no longer fight. When the man wrestled with him as an equal, Jacob could hold his ground. But now he met someone far stronger than himself.

Genesis 32:26

At daybreak, Jacob began to understand the meaning of the struggle. He realized who his opponent was. Since he could not win by fighting, he held on and asked for God's blessing.

Genesis 32:27

What is your name?: The Lord's question was about Jacob's character, not just his identity (see 3:9; 4:9). By stating his name, Jacob admitted his nature and behavior as a "Heel-grabber, Deceiver, Usurper." Before God would bless him, Jacob needed to recognize who he was. Then God would change his identity.

Genesis 32:28

- Jacob: See study note on 25:26.
- Israel ("God fights"): God first fought with him, but now God would fight for him. Jacob's name promised hope for him and his descendants.
- you have struggled with God and with men: Throughout his life, Jacob tried to get God's blessing using his own skills and by any means necessary. He understood the importance of the blessing but was too self-reliant and proud to accept it freely. He had been fighting God long before this encounter.
- and have prevailed: He had succeeded in his struggles with Esau and with Laban. Now he received God's blessing.

Genesis 32:29

Jacob knew who was with him (32:30). The request was his attempt to regain some control. God would not reveal his name, which cannot be had on demand.

Genesis 32:30

- Peniel (which means "face of God"): The name shows that Jacob recognized the man as a manifestation of God (a theophany).
- yet my life was spared (or and my soul has been rescued): This probably meant Jacob realized that God had answered his prayer to be saved from Esau (32:11). If he could encounter God like this and survive, he had nothing to fear from Esau. The saying may also reflect an ancient belief that no one can see God and live (see Exodus 33:20).

Genesis 32:31

God injured Jacob's hip. This limited Jacob's pride and self-reliance (depending on his own strength). Because God reduced his natural strength, Jacob had to trust the Lord more.

Jacob thought he could return to his land by outsmarting his brother again (32:3–21). But at the border of the land, he met its true owner. He would receive the land, but only if God fought for him.

Self-reliance (trying to gain God's blessing by our own strength or by worldly ways) will not succeed. If we continue in this way, God may need to weaken our self-reliance so that we trust him more.

Genesis 32:32

The story includes a dietary restriction for Israel that became a custom but was not put into law. This custom helped preserve the memory of the story. Observant Jews still refuse to eat the tendons of an animal's hindquarters.

Genesis 33:1–2

God had changed Jacob's identity (32:27–28), but he had not yet learned to live in line with his new name. He still showed favoritism (treating some family members better than others), which can divide families.

He arranged his family and possessions according to their importance to him. He placed the servant wives and their children in front, where they would face danger first. Leah and her children were behind them. Rachel and Joseph were at the back, where it was safest.

Genesis 33:1–17

Jacob had long expected to meet his brother Esau, and the meeting turned out much better than he feared. Esau's changed heart shows how "God fights" for his people (See 32:28). God works powerfully for his people when they trust him.

Earlier, Esau did not value his birthright (the rights and blessing of the firstborn son; 25:32–34). Now he no longer held on to old anger. Jacob understood that God had stepped in and changed the situation.

Genesis 33:3–13

Jacob was scared even though he had no reason to be. He tried to calm his brother by acting like a servant to a king:

- he bowed (33:3),
- used respectful titles (33:8, 13),
- introduced people (33:6–7), and
- gave gifts (33:8).

Genesis 33:4

Esau's friendly greeting was an answer to prayer (32:11). God had rescued Jacob from Esau's revenge.

Genesis 33:5

your servant: When speaking with his brother, Jacob kept calling himself Esau's servant (also 33:14). He referred to Esau as his lord (33:8, 13–15). Esau called Jacob "my brother" (33:9). Jacob acted carefully to avoid any possible attack from Esau. In doing this, he went against the earlier oracle (a message from God about the future; 25:23).

Genesis 33:7

Among Jacob's sons, only Joseph is named. Joseph was Jacob's favorite son and the recipient of the blessing.

Genesis 33:10

Jacob knew that Esau's friendly greeting was God's work, secured at Peniel when he saw God face to face.

Genesis 33:11

my gift (literally my blessing) that was brought to you: Jacob considered Esau as a threat and tried to calm him with a gift (see 2 Kings 17:3–4; 18:7, 14; 2 Chronicles 28:21). He might have felt guilty and wanted to fix past mistakes. Jacob insisted that Esau accept the gift.

Genesis 33:12–15

- Even though Esau seemed generous, Jacob was cautious and cleverly avoided traveling with him.
- until I come to my lord at Seir: Jacob's lie shows his old habit of using deceit instead of living by faith.

Genesis 33:16–17

Jacob promised Esau he would follow him south to Seir, but he deceived him. Instead, Jacob went to Succoth, which is east of the Jordan River and north of the Jabbok.

Genesis 33:18–20

- These verses conclude Jacob's adventures away from home. He returned safely with a large family and many possessions.
- Jacob, like Abraham, built an altar at Shechem (see 12:6–8) and bought land from Hamor's family.

Genesis 33:20

El-Elohe-Israel: The name of the altar means "God, the God of Israel." It commemorated Jacob's relationship with God. Jacob publicly declared that God was his God and had guided him back to the land he would inherit.

Genesis 34:1–2

- Dinah was probably Jacob's only daughter (30:21).
- Shechem ... saw her, he took her and lay with her by force: Shechem took Dinah and raped her, which ruined her chances for a proper marriage.

Genesis 34:1–31

After Jacob and his family settled in the land, the Canaanites became a threat. This story warns the Israelites about the risk of being influenced by the Canaanites. Later, God commanded Israel not to marry or make deals with them because they were corrupt and would corrupt others. This chapter gives an implicit warning against adopting their lifestyle (34:1–2).

It also teaches Israel to maintain integrity and not misuse holy things for deceit or violence (34:13). Israel's reputation was at risk in the land (34:30). Because of their violent actions, Simeon and Levi did not receive the birthright blessing (49:5–7).

Genesis 34:3–4

Shechem had strong feelings for Dinah, and he was willing to go through great trouble because of her (34:11–12, 17–18, 24). However, the way he showed his "love" (not true love, but a selfish desire) was impulsive and self-centered. It also broke accepted moral standards of that time (compare Judges 14:2; see 1 Corinthians 13:4–7; 1 John 4:10).

His character shows why Israel needed to stay separate from the Canaanites (the people living in the land at that time).

Genesis 34:5–7

Jacob's response to this crime is surprising. When he heard that Dinah had been defiled, he said nothing about it until his sons came home. Because Jacob did not act, his sons did, though without the wisdom and integrity necessary for justice.

Dinah's full brothers were shocked and furious that Shechem had done such a disgraceful thing to Jacob's family (literally in Israel; this is the first use of the name Israel to describe the family). This sexual crime was an outrage against the community of God's people and deserved punishment, but the leader of the clan did nothing.

Genesis 34:8–10

Hamor suggested a marriage alliance for mutual economic gain. But God had already promised Jacob everything, including the land (34:10; see 14:21–24). Hamor wanted to control Israel's wealth (34:23). Trusting the Canaanites would not lead to anything good.

For some of these reasons, the law of Moses did not allow Israelites to marry Canaanites (see Exodus 23:27–33; Deuteronomy 7:1–5). The exception would be if they converted (see Joshua 2:1–15; 6:23–25; Matthew 1:5).

Genesis 34:13–17

Dinah's brothers responded to the proposal without waiting for Jacob to respond, and they acted deceitfully. They may not have thought that Shechem and his people would ever agree to the rite of circumcision, but they knew what they would do if the Canaanites accepted (34:25).

Genesis 34:18–24

The Canaanite men agreed to the condition, and every male in the town was circumcised. This was not only to allow Shechem to marry Dinah. They also saw it as a way to gain everything that Jacob owned (34:23).

Genesis 34:25–29

When Simeon and Levi used circumcision (the sign of God's covenant) to deceive and kill the Canaanite men, they showed disrespect for that sacred sign. Their killing of all the males and their looting of the city was not justice. It was harsh and excessive revenge.

They were angry and wanted to correct a wrong. But they should have asked for payment for the harm done (see Exodus 22:16–17; Deuteronomy 22:28–29). Instead, their violent anger led to the loss of their birthright blessing (the special family blessing given to the firstborn; Genesis 49:5–7).

Genesis 34:30

Jacob responded again fearfully because of what might happen to him. But God made the people of the land fear him instead (35:5).

Genesis 35:1–7

Jacob returned to Bethel, about 24 kilometers (15 miles) south of Shechem, to fulfill the vows he made there (28:20–22).

Genesis 35:1–29

- This chapter discusses God's promises, Jacob's vow, and how Jacob's sons continue the covenant. Deborah, Rachel, and Isaac died. This marked the end of an era and the story of Isaac's family (25:19–35:29).
- They removed idols (35:1–4) and established pure worship (35:6–7). During this time, they needed to renew their faith so Jacob's sons could continue the covenant.

Genesis 35:2–4

Jacob vowed to fully devote himself to the Lord (28:20–22). To establish this devotion, his family had to get rid of all pagan idols and stop worshiping other gods.

God allows no rivals. Only the Lord could be their God (compare Joshua 5:1–9).

Genesis 35:3

He has been with me wherever I have gone: God had fulfilled his promises (28:15; 31:3), so Jacob must fulfill his vow.

Genesis 35:5

a terror from God: People had heard about the killing of the men of Shechem (Genesis 34:25–30).

Genesis 35:6–7

Jacob built an altar at Bethel as God had instructed (35:1; compare 12:8).

Genesis 35:9–15

At Bethel, God confirmed the promise he made earlier. He reminded Jacob that his name was now Israel, proving that he had received the blessing.

Genesis 35:11–12

God's reference to himself as God Almighty assured Jacob that his promise could and would be fulfilled. At Bethel, God promised Jacob that he would have descendants in the land (compare 28:13–14). Here, God added that his descendants would include kings (see 17:6).

Genesis 35:14–15

In fulfilling his vow (28:20–22), Jacob's actions were almost identical to his actions in the earlier experience at Bethel (compare 28:16–19).

Genesis 35:16–20

Benjamin's birth completed the family. But it was a sad event because Rachel died during childbirth (see study note on 31:32).

Genesis 35:18

Rachel felt that the name Ben-oni, meaning "son of my sorrow," fit the moment. But Jacob did not want his son to carry such a sad name, so he changed it to Benjamin, meaning "son of my right hand." In this way, Jacob changed a moment of sorrow into one of hope and gave his son a name that pointed to blessing and strength.

Genesis 35:19

Jacob did not carry Rachel's body to the family tomb at Machpelah (23:1–20; 25:9; 49:30; 50:13) but buried her in the territory that would be Benjamin's (see Josh 18:21–28; 1 Sam 10:2).

Genesis 35:20

it marks Rachel's tomb to this day: This seems to be a later editorial comment by someone who was living in the land after the conquest and giving directions to the tomb (see Genesis Book Introduction, "Composition").

Genesis 35:22

- Reuben had sexual relations with Bilhah. This dishonored his father's marriage. As the oldest son, Reuben might have been trying to take over as the clan leader using a pagan method (compare 2 Samuel 16:15–22). But this act caused him to lose his birthright (see Genesis 49:3–4).
- Jacob soon found out what happened, but he delayed his response again (see 49:3–4; compare 34:5).

Genesis 35:23–26

The 12 sons of Jacob became the leaders of the 12 tribes of Israel. Their names are the beginnings of the nation.

Genesis 35:27–29

Esau and Jacob, listed in the order of their birth, reunited to bury Isaac in Hebron. This was probably their first meeting since they reconciled (see 33:16–17; 13:18; 23:1–2, 17–19).

Genesis 36:1–8

The story of Esau emphasizes two main points:

1. The sons of Esau ... were born to him in the land of Canaan (36:5) before he moved to Seir (36:8). In contrast, most of Jacob's children were born outside Canaan but later moved there. God gave the land to Jacob and his descendants, making space for them by settling Esau elsewhere.
2. Esau was also known as Edom. Israel often had conflicts with the Edomites (see 1 Samuel 21:7; 22:9–22; Obadiah 1).

Genesis 36:1–43

Genesis now turns to the story of Isaac's sons. It first finishes the account of Esau's line (chapter 36), who was not chosen. Then it continues with the line of Jacob (chapter 37), whom God chose.

Genesis 36:2

Oholibamah was the great-granddaughter of Seir the Horite. Seir's descendants lived in Edom when Esau went to live there (36:20, 25).

Genesis 36:2–3

Esau had three wives named Adah, Oholibamah, and Basemath. Two of these names differ from earlier mentions (26:34; 28:9). It is possible the other wives died, Esau preferred these three out of six, or these were different names for the same wives. There is not enough information to know for sure.

Genesis 36:7–8

Esau, like Lot, left for the eastern land (compare 13:5–6).

Genesis 36:9–14

This passage names the descendants of Esau's five sons.

Genesis 36:9–43

This passage begins a second account of Esau's descendants (36:1). It introduces a new list of his family line and traces his descendants through later generations. It also records marriages and alliances

Genesis 36:15–19

Thirteen of Esau's descendants held leadership positions over different clans. This begins to show Esau as an overlord (a ruler over other rulers) of tribes (compare 36:40–43).

Genesis 36:20–30

Seir the Horite was among the early people of the land. His descendants lived in that region until Esau and his descendants moved in and drove them out (Deuteronomy 2:12).

Genesis 36:31

before any king reigned over the Israelites: This editorial note was probably inserted into the text after Israel was ruled by kings (see study note on 35:20).

Genesis 36:31–39

It is not clear how these kings of Edom were related to Esau. The clans in Edom followed the same pattern of organization as the later tribes of Israel. They eventually chose a king from one of their tribes and carried on a line of succession from him.

Genesis 36:40–43

These leaders came from Esau, a great and powerful ruler. As the ancestor of the Edomites, he governed clans and regions. Eleven chiefs descended from him.

By separating from Jacob, Esau started to free himself from Jacob's control (27:39–40).

Genesis 37:1

In chapter 36, Esau was increasing in power and wealth. In contrast, Jacob, still waiting for the promise, lived in the land as a foreigner, like his father. He remained a temporary resident with a single family.

Worldly greatness often comes more quickly than spiritual greatness. Waiting for the promised spiritual blessing while others prosper tests patience, faith, and perseverance.

Genesis 37:2

- The account of Jacob and his family now turns to Joseph and his brothers. Jacob is still important, but the story focuses on Joseph, who is introduced as an obedient seventeen-year-old son.
- he brought their father a bad report about them: Bringing a bad report is not popular, but it was the right thing to do. It shows that Joseph was faithful from the beginning. As the story continues, his brothers' wicked behavior becomes clearer. In the end, like Cain, they even tried to kill the brother who pleased God.

Genesis 37:2–50.26

- The story of Joseph and his brothers is a distinct section in Genesis. It has a different tone and focus from the earlier parts. The story follows one connected series of events, with Joseph at the center.
- Repeated themes structure the entire story of Joseph. These themes are similar to those in wisdom books like Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and Daniel.

Similar events that happen more than once shape the whole story. Its themes are like those in wisdom books (books that teach how to live well), such as Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and Daniel. These books teach that God can bring good out of evil and joy out of suffering.
Even if this does not fully happen in this life, it will happen in the life to come. Although the wicked may succeed for a time, the righteous (those who live rightly before God) should remain faithful. A deeper and lasting way of life comes through obedience to God.
Anyone who hopes to be a leader in God's plan can

learn from Joseph's story. Wisdom guided him and led to his success. Jesus Christ perfectly lived out this wisdom because he is the wisdom of God.

- Judah is also an important person in the story. At first, he was careless and unkind, like his brothers. But later, he truly repented (turned away from his sin). He was willing to give his life to save a younger brother for his father. Because of this, he received an important inheritance.

Genesis 37:3

- Israel (or Jacob): See also 37:13.
- Israel loved Joseph more than his other children. Joseph was born when Israel was old. He was the first son of Israel's favorite wife, Rachel.
- Israel gave Joseph a beautiful robe to show he planned to give him the largest share of the inheritance.

Genesis 37:4

Jacob's favoritism (treating one child better than the others) toward Joseph made his other sons hate him even more. In the same way, Isaac's and Rebekah's favoritism had divided their family. Now Jacob's favoritism would lead to separation between him and his son Joseph.

Genesis 37:5–11

God confirmed his choice of this faithful son as the future leader of the family through two symbolic dreams. This is the first of three dream sequences in chapters 37–50 (see 40:1–41:36; compare 15:13; 20:3; 28:12–15; 31:24). Dreams were often seen as a way God spoke to people. People considered a dream to be more important if it was given twice (repeated to show it was certain).

Genesis 37:7

The sheaves of grain suggest how Joseph would gain authority over his family (see 42:1–3).

Genesis 37:8

The brothers reacted angrily to the revelation, unlike Joseph, who was honest and faithful. This shows why they were not chosen as leaders. Leaders in God's plan cannot be full of jealousy and hatred.

In their anger, they missed an important part of the revelation. They also would become rulers ("stars," 37:9) and would successfully gather their sheaves (37:7).

Genesis 37:9

the sun and moon and eleven stars: Signs like the sun, moon, and stars often stand for rulers. The dream showed that Joseph would become a leader over the whole family of Israel.

Genesis 37:10

your mother ... and I: Joseph's birth mother, Rachel, was dead (35:19). Leah was now the matriarch of the clan.

Genesis 37:11

- Joseph's brothers hated him because they were jealous. Instead of recognizing that God was at work, they tried to stop his dreams from coming true (37:18–36). These actions show that they were not ready to lead God's people.

God's choice of a leader (especially someone young or who seems unqualified) often reveals what is in people's hearts. It shows whether they are willing to accept that leader's authority. Joseph's brothers represent many people throughout history who act with envy (jealous anger) and malice (a desire to harm others) because they are not committed to doing the Lord's will.

- Jacob wondered what the dreams meant because he knew God would choose the next leader. He understood that God could choose the younger son to lead the older ones and could reveal all this in dreams.

Genesis 37:12–13

It was foolish for Jacob to send Joseph on such a mission, knowing how the brothers felt about him. Joseph obeyed his father by going to find his brothers despite their hatred for him.

Genesis 37:14–17

The brothers traveled over a wide area. Shechem was about 80 kilometers (about 50 miles) from Hebron. Dothan was another 24 kilometers (15 miles) beyond Shechem.

Genesis 37:18–20

When Joseph's brothers saw him coming, they plotted to kill ... that dreamer and stop his dreams. Earlier, they had unjustly killed the men of Shechem to avenge their sister (chapter 34). Now, in the region of Shechem, they plotted to unjustly kill their own brother out of jealousy.

Genesis 37:21–24

Reuben might have been trying to regain his father's favor (35:22) by acting as the firstborn leader (compare 42:22). Reuben succeeded in saving Joseph's life, but he did not win his father's favor (37:29–30).

Genesis 37:23

The repeated theme of changed clothes points to changes in status, position, and authority (see 37:3, 23; 38:14, 19; 39:15–18; 41:14, 42).

Genesis 37:25–28

The Ishmaelite traders were descendants of the slave child who was cast out for mocking Isaac. Now they would enslave Joseph. When he was sold for 20 pieces of silver and carried to Egypt, he was at least preserved alive.

Genesis 37:26

Judah began to take a leadership role, which he continued to develop as the story goes on (see 43:8–10).

Genesis 37:28

- The Ishmaelites are called Midianite traders (that is, traders from Midian). Ishmaelites were descendants of Abraham through Hagar (16:5). Midianites were descendants of Abraham through Keturah (25:1–2). The term Ishmaelite may have been used more generally for desert tribes (nomadic groups who move from place to place). The Midianites may also have been traveling with a separate group of Ishmaelite traders (37:27).
- Kidnapping (taking a person by force) is mentioned in 40:15. Later, it became a capital offense (a crime punished by death) in Israel's law (see Exodus 21:16).

Genesis 37:29–30

When Reuben returned, he tore his clothes in grief. His attempt to restore his relationship with his father by saving Joseph had gone wrong.

Genesis 37:31–35

The family's long pattern of deception influenced the brothers. Jacob had used a young goat to deceive Isaac (27:5–17). Now Jacob's sons deceived him using a goat (see study note on 30:34–36).

Genesis 37:32

your son's: The brothers were so full of hatred that they did not call Joseph by name or acknowledge him as their brother (see 21:10).

Genesis 37:33

recognized: Compare with 27:23.

Genesis 37:34–35

Jacob tore his clothes, put sackcloth around his waist: This showed his extreme distress and mourning (see 44:13; Job 1:20; 16:15). Jacob was devastated and refused to be comforted. This betrayal affected his entire family.

Genesis 37:36

sold Joseph in Egypt to Potiphar: Joseph worked in a position that matched his potential for leadership, but he still faced more testing.

Genesis 38:1–30

The story of Judah and Tamar is a carefully placed break in the larger story. It shows what was happening in Judah's family. Judah would later become an important leader. The story also shows the early stages of the family mixing with the people of the land. This helps explain why God sent the family to Egypt (chapters 39–47).

The Egyptians kept themselves separate from other peoples (43:32). Because of that, the Israelites were more likely to keep their own identity in Egypt than in Canaan.

Genesis 38:7

That Er was a wicked man is not surprising, since his mother was a Canaanite and his father a rebellious Israelite.

Genesis 38:7–10

This story describes the Lord as the sovereign judge who ended the lives of Judah's wicked sons.

Genesis 38:8

Perform your duty … raise up offspring for your brother: This reflects the custom of levirate marriage (a practice where a man marries his dead brother's wife).

In this custom, if a man died without children, his brother or nearest relative would marry the widow. The goal was to have a child who would carry on the dead man's name and inherit his property. This practice was later included in God's law for Israel (Deuteronomy 25:5–10).

A close relative could refuse this duty, but he would be publicly shamed in the family for not preserving his brother's name.

Genesis 38:9–10

Onan married Tamar, but he was not willing to provide an heir for his brother. He had sexual relations with Tamar, but he did not fulfill his duty to his dead brother (38:8).

Genesis 38:11

Judah is now shown as the example for his sons' behavior. He also failed in his duty under levirate marriage toward Tamar, even though he was the next kinsman (see study note on 38:8). Judah and his sons acted too much like the Canaanites (see study note on 38:27–30; this contrasts with Boaz, who acted rightly in Ruth 3–4).

Genesis 38:12–13

- Without a marriage, the family's future was at risk.
- Judah's wife ... died: This made Judah available to fulfill the responsibility of providing an heir.

Genesis 38:14–19

Tamar understood she needed to act to secure her family's future. Following the levirate custom (see study note on 38:8), she remained loyal to her dead husband. She had a legal right to have a child with Judah's son or Judah himself. So she tricked her father-in-law into having sexual relations with her. Again, Jacob's family experiences deception, this time by a Canaanite daughter-in-law.

Genesis 38:17

It would be normal for Tamar to ask for a pledge if the man did not have the money to pay. A woman in such a position would not trust anyone to send the money.

Genesis 38:18

seal: A small cylinder made of stone or metal was carved with unique designs. People usually wore it on a cord around the neck. When it was rolled over soft clay or wax, it left a clear impression of the design.

Genesis 38:20–23

Judah had gone to Tamar as a regular prostitute (Hebrew zonah, 38:15), whereas Hirah was mistakenly looking for a shrine prostitute (Hebrew qedeshah), of which there were none.

Genesis 38:24–26

Judah acted hypocritically by condemning Tamar to death for adultery. When Tamar showed his seal, cord, and walking stick, it proved Judah was the father. He then withdrew the condemnation.

Genesis 38:26

She is more righteous than I: Judah admitted he had failed to provide an heir. It was wrong for Judah to visit a prostitute, but Tamar had a legal right to have Judah's child and acted on it.

In the book of Ruth, the elders gave a similar blessing at the marriage of Boaz and Ruth. They prayed that God would make Ruth like Tamar (Ruth 4:12; compare Matthew 1:3, 5).

Genesis 38:27–30

Judah's family line continued through Tamar. The twins replaced Judah's two sons who had died (38:7, 10). Their birth was similar to the birth of Jacob and Esau (25:21–26). As with Jacob and Esau, the expected order of birth was reversed. In both cases, the twin connected with the color red (scarlet) did not remain in the first place.

In a similar way, Jacob gained the right to rule over his older brother (27:29). This pattern seems to appear again in Judah's family. The family line continued through Perez, not through the older son Shelah, whom Judah had tried hard to protect (38:11; see 1 Chronicles 4:21), and not through the older twin Zerah (see Ruth 4:13–22; Matthew 1:3).

Genesis 38:29–30

Perez moved ahead of his brother, just like Joseph would soon do with his own brothers (chapters 39–47).

Genesis 39:1–23

Joseph was honest and faithful in his work for Potiphar. This is very different from Judah, who failed morally (chapter 38). God was with Joseph (39:2–3, 21, 23). He helped Joseph succeed and become a blessing to others (see study notes on 12:1–9; 28:16–22), even while Joseph was a slave and later in prison.

Genesis 39:1–47.31

Joseph began as a slave, alienated from his brothers and separated from his father; he ended as Pharaoh's viceroy. Through the trips to Egypt, the covenant family went from the brink of apostasy, divided by jealousy and deception, to being reconciled and united by Judah's intercession and Joseph's forgiveness.

Genesis 39:2

Apart from 38:7–10, this is the first time the story mentions God since Jacob built his altar in Bethel (35:1–15). This is also the first time his covenant name, "the LORD," occurs since Jacob left Laban (31:49).

Genesis 39:5

God began to bless Egypt through Joseph (see 22:18).

Genesis 39:6–10

A major theme in wisdom literature (wise teaching about how to live well; see study note on 37:2–50:26) is a warning to young people: sexual sin and other wrong behavior will lead to harm and ruin (compare Proverbs 5–7). Joseph resisted temptation because he had godly wisdom. He was guided by the fear of the Lord (a deep respect and reverence for God that leads to obedience; Proverbs 1:7; 9:10).

Genesis 39:14

brought to us: Although Potiphar's wife was speaking to slaves, she spoke to them as fellow Egyptians. She did this to make them support her and act as witnesses against the Hebrew man (a person from the people of Israel; see 43:32). This Hebrew man, Joseph, had gained Potiphar's trust.

Genesis 39:19–20

This was the second time Joseph became imprisoned while faithfully doing the right thing. They deceptively used his clothing as false evidence (compare 37:23–24, 31–33).

Genesis 39:21–23

Joseph thrived in prison because God was with him. Each time Joseph prospered, he was put in charge of something.

Genesis 40:1–4

Joseph was so faithful and reliable that the captain of the guard trusted him with the care of two of Pharaoh's officers.

Genesis 40:1–23

Joseph did not lose faith in God's promises, as evidenced by his readiness to interpret the dreams of two prisoners. He was still convinced that God's revelation in his own two dreams (37:5–11) was true, and he had not abandoned hope that they would be fulfilled. When the fellow prisoners' dreams were fulfilled exactly as Joseph said, this confirmed that his previous dreams were from God.

Genesis 40:5–8

- Pharaoh's cup-bearer and baker appeared worried because they sensed their futures were connected to these threatening and troubling dreams they could not understand.
- Joseph still trusted that interpreting dreams was God's work. He knew he could understand them with God's help. He knew he had not misunderstood his own dreams.

Genesis 40:9–19

Joseph listened to the dreams and gave their interpretations. These dreams were not trivial. They were serious warnings from God about what everyone would soon face. These two dreams also prepare for Pharaoh's two dreams, which reveal the coming seasons of life and death that the nation would soon experience.

Genesis 40:14–15

Because he knew that the chief cup-bearer was going back into Pharaoh's personal service, Joseph saw an opportunity to seek his own release from prison.

Genesis 40:20–22

The interpretations Joseph gave the prisoners proved true. The death of the chief baker speaks of the harsh realities of life in ancient Egypt, with a king whose word was his land's highest law.

Genesis 40:23

The chief cupbearer ... did not remember Joseph: But God remembered him. Joseph's faith was about to be rewarded (chapter 41).

Genesis 41:1–4

Pharaoh's first dream was about cows. Cows often stood half-submerged in the Nile River's reeds to escape the heat and flies. They would leave the water to find grass.

The second group of cows worried Pharaoh because they were thin but were able to swallow the fat cows.

Genesis 41:1–46

God had used two dreams to identify Joseph as a leader among his brothers (37:5–11). He used two dreams to test Joseph's faith in prison (40:5–14). Now

God used two more dreams to raise Joseph from prison to a place of high honor and authority.

Joseph had shown that he was faithful in small tasks. Now God would give him responsibility over greater things.

Genesis 41:5–7

Pharaoh's second dream had a similar message. Seven shriveled heads of grain ate seven full heads of grain on one stalk and withered heads that grew afterward.

Genesis 41:8

The magicians and wise men were part of a group of people who claimed special skill in spiritual matters, such as understanding dreams and visions (see Exodus 8:18–19; Daniel 2:10–11).

God used an Israelite slave to show that the wisdom of this world is limited (see Daniel 2). Even the most powerful nation is still under God's rule and control (Daniel 2:20–23).

Genesis 41:9–13

The chief cup-bearer finally remembered Joseph and testified that his interpretations were true.

Genesis 41:14–15

- Pharaoh quickly summoned Joseph from prison to explain his dreams.
- Joseph shaved, following the Egyptian custom.

Genesis 41:16

Joseph knew that only God could explain Pharaoh's dreams (compare 40:8). He was sure God would reveal their meaning, as the dreams had a purpose (41:25, 28).

Genesis 41:17–24

Pharaoh recounted his dreams and testified that no human wisdom could interpret them.

Genesis 41:25–32

Both dreams predicted that seven years of abundant crops would be followed by seven years of severe famine.

Genesis 41:32

The two similar dreams showed that the matter has been decreed by God, and He will carry it out shortly. This was like the dreams of the two prisoners that God quickly fulfilled (40:5–23). Joseph's own two dreams (37:5–11) were also about to come true (41:37–46; 42:6–9).

Genesis 41:33–36

- God's message required a response. It was not given just to satisfy curiosity about the future. Joseph's advice showed that he was wise and able to plan well. This is why Pharaoh chose him to lead (41:37–40).
- Joseph set up a system to store food. He placed one main leader over the work and local leaders in each area. He collected one-fifth (20 percent) of the grain and stored it for future needs. Later, wisdom literature (see study note on 37:2–50:26) teaches the same idea: plan for the future instead of living only for the present (see Proverbs 6:6–8; 27:12).

Genesis 41:37–40

Pharaoh saw that Joseph was the right person for this work. He recognized that Joseph had the Spirit of God and was wise and understanding.

In this way, God showed his rule and authority over Egypt. Israelites who later read this story could trust that God would save them, just as he had promised.

Genesis 41:41–46

Joseph was made the acting ruler or manager of Egypt.

Genesis 41:42

- Pharaoh's signet ring had a seal used for signing documents. The seal was impressed in soft clay, which hardened and left a permanent impression of the ruler's signature, which carried his authority. Numerous seals of this type have been found in archaeological digs.
- The linen clothing and gold chain showed Joseph's new status as a ruler.

Genesis 41:43–44

Pharaoh made Joseph second-in-command; all the people had to submit to him. Compare Psalm 105:16–22.

Genesis 41:45

- As a sign of Joseph's new status, Pharaoh gave him an Egyptian name and a wife from an important family.
- On was a center for sun worship and later came to be known as Heliopolis (meaning "sun city").

Genesis 41:46

- Joseph was thirty years old: It had been about 13 years since his brothers sold Joseph into slavery (37:2).
- traveled throughout the land of Egypt: As a wise manager, his first priority was to understand his responsibilities.

Genesis 41:47–57

Pharaoh's dreams were fulfilled just as Joseph had explained.

Genesis 41:50–52

- Despite his status and power, Joseph stayed true to his heritage. He gave his two sons Hebrew names.
- Manasseh: Joseph's wealth and success helped him forget the pain of being away from his family.
- Ephraim: By giving him this name, Joseph expressed his thanks to God for making him fruitful in Egypt.

Genesis 41:53–57

Joseph's wisdom paid off, for the seven years of plenty were followed by seven years of severe famine, but throughout Egypt there was plenty of food. Joseph had grain to sell to the Egyptians and to people from other countries as well.

Genesis 42:1–44.34

Joseph did several unusual things to his brothers when they came looking for grain. The last time Joseph had been with them, they were filled with jealousy, hatred, and anger; they attempted to destroy their brother, and they deceived their father. Joseph put them through various tests, similar to the trying situations they had put him through, to see if they had changed.

Genesis 42:1–47.31

God used the famine to bring Israel to Egypt under Joseph's rule, thus fulfilling two prophecies (15:13; 37:7–11).

Genesis 42:4

Jacob may have believed that Benjamin would not be safe with his brothers.

Genesis 42:6–7

Joseph's first dream (37:5–11) was partially fulfilled when his brothers bowed down to him without recognizing him (see also 43:26; 44:14). It was totally fulfilled in 50:18. Joseph recognized his brothers immediately, but he could not reveal himself because he did not yet trust them to be the honest men they claimed to be (42:10).

Genesis 42:8

they did not recognize him: This was because Joseph was now a grown man, not a boy. He did not have a beard, wore Egyptian clothes, and was in an unexpected position of power. He spoke to them through an interpreter (42:23).

Genesis 42:9

You are spies!: The brothers thought Joseph was a spy for their father and treated him harshly (37:2, 14, 18–28). Now, Joseph was testing them in a similar way to see their reaction.

Genesis 42:11

Joseph knew that they had not always been the honest men they claimed to be.

Genesis 42:15–17

Joseph put his brothers in prison for three days. He did this to see if they felt guilt for what they had done in the past (42:21–23). The brothers had similarly thrown Joseph into a cistern-prison while they decided what to do with him (37:24).

Genesis 42:18–20

Rather than keep all but one, Joseph would release all but one to take grain home to their starving families.

Genesis 42:21–23

Surely we are being punished: The brothers believed that God was punishing them. They thought this because they now had to bring Benjamin to Egypt, even though their father did not want this. They connected this trouble with their past sin of selling Joseph to traders.

They began to see this as divine punishment (God judging wrong actions). The fear of divine punishment began to cause feelings of guilt that Joseph's cries for mercy and their father's tears had failed to produce (37:34–35).

Genesis 42:22

you would not listen: Reuben had lost his place as leader (see study notes on 42:37; 49:3–4).

Genesis 42:24

Joseph turned away from them and began to weep (compare 43:30; 45:2, 14; 50:1, 17). He might have heard a part of the story he had never known, like Reuben's attempt to save him (37:21–22, 29). Or, his brothers' remorse might have moved him to forgive them.

Genesis 42:25

return each man's silver to his sack: Joseph was testing his brothers. He wanted to appeal to their conscience (their inner sense of right and wrong) and make them face their past guilt. Once again, they were going home with silver instead of a brother (37:28–35).

Genesis 42:25–28

Joseph cared for his brothers' needs. He forgave them and provided for them (see study note on 42:24). God used Joseph's care to make the brothers more aware of their sin.

Genesis 42:28

What is this that God has done to us?: They realized God was responsible for everything happening, so they faced a day of reckoning for their sins.

Genesis 42:29–34

The brothers' report focused on the charge that they were spies and on the need to bring Benjamin back to Egypt with them. They did not mention that they were beginning to see God's judgment (his just response to wrongdoing) for what they had done to Joseph.

Genesis 42:36

- Jacob was already grieving the loss of two sons and feared losing Benjamin if he went to Egypt.
- You have deprived me of my sons: He did not know how true his words were. But these words probably troubled his sons' guilty consciences.

Genesis 42:37

Reuben tried to take charge. He might have thought he could regain his father's favor (see 35:22). First, he hoped to rescue Joseph from death (37:21–22, 29–30), and now by keeping Benjamin safe.

Genesis 42:38

Jacob continued to show special favor to Rachel's only remaining son. He refused to let Benjamin go to Egypt, even if it meant that Simeon, Leah's son, would not return.

Jacob's deep grief later weighed heavily on the brothers' conscience (44:18–34).

Genesis 43:1–7

As the famine continued, Jacob's family needed more grain. But, they could not go back to Egypt without Benjamin (42:16, 20). Jacob understood he was in a difficult situation. He needed more food but he would not risk losing Benjamin.

Genesis 43:8–10

Judah solved the problem by taking responsibility for Benjamin's safety. In this way, he succeeded where Reuben had failed. This change was important because Judah had earlier suggested selling Joseph to the Ishmaelites (37:26–27) instead of killing him. Now he would secure Benjamin's safety with his own life (see 44:18–34).

Genesis 43:11–13

Jacob provided everything he could to ensure a favorable reception from the Egyptian governor ("the man"; compare 32:13–21).

Genesis 43:13–14

Jacob finally trusted God Almighty with his family's future. This divine title emphasizes God's power (see also 17:1; 28:3; 35:11; 48:3; 1 Kings 19:10, 14; Revelation 21:22).

Genesis 43:16

When Joseph saw Benjamin with his brothers: Joseph knew Benjamin was well (see study note on 42:1–44:34). The feast was both a celebration and a test.

Genesis 43:18

the brothers were frightened: Compare 32:6–12. Their guilt stopped them from seeing that something good might happen.

Genesis 43:19–22

The brothers, completely vulnerable and feeling the weight of God's judgment on their consciences, approached the manager in desperation.

Genesis 43:24

Joseph stopped being harsh to his brothers and treated them kindly instead.

Genesis 43:26

For the second time, the brothers bowed to the ground before him.This fulfilled his first dream (37:7; see 42:6–7; compare 33:3).

Genesis 43:29

May God be gracious to you, my son: Joseph's blessing to his full brother fulfilled Jacob's prayer (43:14).

Genesis 43:30

- he was moved to tears for his brother: Compare 42:24. Joseph cried because of painful memories and lost years with his brother. He also felt joy and gratitude for seeing Benjamin again.
- he went to a private room: This was because he was not ready to reveal his identity.

Genesis 43:33

in astonishment: This ruler knew more about the brothers than seemed possible (compare 44:15).

Genesis 43:34

The brothers experienced generous and gracious treatment from God through Joseph.

Joseph tested them. He showed special favor to Benjamin, who was also Rachel's son. In the past, their father's favoritism toward Joseph had caused jealousy and hatred.

By treating Benjamin with favor, Joseph tested whether they would respond with the same anger as before. This situation revealed whether their attitudes and behavior had changed.

Genesis 44:1–34

The brothers seemed different. They felt sorry for what they did to Joseph. They showed honor by returning the money and by bringing Benjamin. Given a chance to get rid of Rachel's other son, Benjamin, would they do it?

Genesis 44:2

Joseph was giving his brothers the chance to abandon Benjamin if they wanted to. Joseph was testing them to see if they were loyal to the family and faithful to their father.

Genesis 44:5

- This description would help the brothers see that the ruler knew things that other people could not know.
- Hydromancy (trying to learn hidden things by pouring water into oil) and oenomancy (trying to learn hidden things by pouring wine into other liquids) were forms of divination (seeking knowledge through supernatural means) used in the ancient Near East. A special cup was often used for these practices.

Joseph was still pretending (see 42:7; compare 30:27; see also Leviticus 19:26; Numbers 23:23; Deuteronomy 18:10–11). He knew that only God reveals the future (see Genesis 37:5–9; 40:8; 41:16).

Genesis 44:9–10

The brothers suggested a punishment that was too harsh. In ancient times, people often risked their lives based on their words. The palace manager agreed but imposed a punishment that matched Joseph's intentions (44:17).

Genesis 44:11–12

The palace manager knew where the cup was, but he created more anxiety by beginning with the oldest.

Genesis 44:13

they all tore their clothes: They knew what it would do to Jacob to lose Benjamin (42:38).

Genesis 44:14

This time, the brothers did not bow politely (see 42:6–7; 43:26). They fell to the ground in desperation, fulfilling Joseph's first dream for the third time (see 37:10).

Genesis 44:16

- Judah again spoke for the group.
- God has exposed the iniquity of your servants: God was completing the work of repentance in their hearts. Judah again proposed that they all be punished. Benjamin was seemingly guilty of this theft, but all of the others were guilty of sin against Joseph. They preferred not returning to Jacob at all versus seeing his grief at the loss of Benjamin (44:34).

Genesis 44:18–34

- Judah kept his promise to make sure Benjamin was safe (43:8–10). His lengthy plea to take Benjamin's place in prison is one of the most sincere examples of intercession in the Bible (44:33). It showed Judah's care for their father and his willingness to sacrifice everything for his brother. With this integrity, Judah proved himself a true leader, worthy of the

firstborn's blessing (see John 15:13). Through him, Israel's kings would emerge (see Genesis 49:10).
- The brothers had fully repented, as shown by Judah's intercession. Because of their change, Joseph could reveal himself to them (45:1–15). He arranged for the family to join him in Egypt, where there was food (45:16; 47:12).

Genesis 44:32–34

Judah was willing to give up his family, his future, and his freedom for others.

Genesis 45:1–15

In one of the book's most dramatic scenes, Joseph told his brothers who he was. This brought the process of reconciling with them to a climax (see also 50:14–21).

Genesis 45:2

This is the third time Joseph cried over his brothers in the story (see also 42:24; 43:30; 45:14; 50:17; compare 50:1).

Genesis 45:3

The news shocked the brothers. They were unable to speak because of amazement and fear (45:5; compare 50:15).

Genesis 45:5–8

it was not you who sent me here, but God: This is the main message of Jacob's family story (37:2). As the Lord had told Abraham, he was bringing the Israelites into Egypt (15:13). God sent Joseph ahead to prepare a way to save his family during the famine.

This is a clear statement about God's sovereignty (his complete rule and control over all things). Joseph explained that God was at work through all events and human actions to carry out his plan.

Because God is in control, people can forgive and be restored to those who have hurt them. If people do not believe that God rules over all, they may blame others and try to get even. But those who trust God believe that he is at work, even through human evil (see also Romans 8:28–30).

Genesis 45:9–13

Joseph told his brothers to inform Jacob. The entire family needed to move to Egypt and live in Goshen, a fertile area in the Nile delta (see 47:1–12). If they did not come to Egypt, they would not survive the upcoming five years of famine.

Genesis 45:10

The region of Goshen was in the northeast corner of Egypt, a few days' walk from Canaan. Jacob's family stayed there because it had food and water for them and their animals. Later, the Egyptians forced them into slave labor there.

Genesis 45:14–15

Joseph was reunited with his brothers, first with Benjamin and then with the rest. Their previous hatred and jealousy of Joseph (37:4–11) had come to an end. The brothers experienced forgiveness from God and from Joseph. Instead of commanding his brothers to bow down to him (see 42:6–7), Joseph welcomed them. Joseph held no grudge because he accepted what had happened as God's work and saw the good that had resulted (see 50:14–21).

This is how wisdom rules: The wise leader will forgive and restore (see study note on 37:2–50:26).

Genesis 45:16–25

Joseph instructed his brothers to bring Jacob and the whole family to Egypt. Grateful for Joseph saving Egypt (45:18; see 47:20), Pharaoh promised them the best land in Egypt. Joseph also gave them Egypt's finest products.

Genesis 45:16–47.12

This section marks a transition as the family moved from Canaan to Goshen, where they would live for the next 400years.

Genesis 45:24

Do not quarrel on the way!: When they were away from Joseph, they might begin to accuse one another about the past or argue about how to explain what had happened to Jacob. It was now time to put the past behind them and enjoy the reunion.

Genesis 45:26–28

As expected, Jacob was shocked when he heard that his son Joseph was still alive and ruling all Egypt. But as he heard their full report and saw everything Joseph had sent, he became convinced it was true. At once, he prepared to go to Egypt and see Joseph again after 22 years.

Genesis 45:27

Jacob was revived: This royal invitation was a turning point for Jacob and his sons. Jacob was old and had

little hope left. The 10 brothers were weighed down with guilt and fear.

This moment also fulfilled what God had said earlier (15:13–16): his people would live in a foreign land for a time and there become a great nation, while remaining a distinct people.

The joyful news about Joseph changed the lives of this whole family for the better.

Genesis 46:1

- set out: A little over 200 years earlier, Abraham also went to Egypt during a famine in Canaan (12:10), and God protected him there.
- Jacob first stopped at Beersheba, where Abraham had sacrificed and worshiped the Lord. This was after resolving land and water rights with the Philistines (21:31–33). Isaac had lived there, and Jacob had lived there before fleeing from Esau's anger (28:10).
- all that he had: See 46:5–7.

Genesis 46:1–4

God reassured Jacob about his move to Egypt.

Genesis 46:2–4

In a night vision, the Lord promised Jacob that he would be with him and make his family a great nation in Egypt. The same God who led them into Egypt promised to bring them back to live in Canaan.

Genesis 46:4

will close your eyes: He would have a peaceful death, surrounded by his family and many blessings from God (49:33).

Genesis 46:8–27

This family history of Jacob's sons shows that all the tribes of Israel went to Egypt together. They would also leave together (see the book of Exodus).

Genesis 46:20

On: See study note on 41:45.

Genesis 46:26

numbered sixty-six persons: This includes those who traveled with Jacob to Egypt. But it does not include his sons' wives, the servants, or others in the household. It also does not include Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Jacob.

Genesis 46:27

seventy: This includes Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Jacob. Seventy is a symbolic number for perfection or completion (see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note). From these seventy (meaning all of Israel), the nation of Israel would grow and bless the seventy nations (meaning all the nations) of the world (see study note on Genesis 10:2–32; compare 12:3).

Genesis 46:28–34

Jacob was full of joy when he finally saw his son Joseph again.

Genesis 46:29

embraced him, and wept profusely: Joseph was 17 when he last saw his father (37:2). Now, he was 39.

Genesis 46:30

Jacob was happy to see his beloved son alive. This son was the firstborn of his chosen wife Rachel and the designated family leader (see study note on 48:5–7; see also 1 Chronicles 5:1–2). This was more than a family reunion. It confirmed that God's plan was still in place.

Genesis 46:34

The Canaanites would have mixed with the Israelites if they stayed in Canaan. But, Egyptians disliked Semitic shepherds due to ethnic pride and kept them separate (see 43:32). When Jacob's family settled in Egypt, this separation helped them increase into a large nation while keeping their identity.

Genesis 47:1

Ancient Egyptian texts do not mention Goshen (see study note on 45:10). Later Egyptian writings called it "the district of Rameses" (47:11; see Exodus 1:11). It was fertile and near Joseph's court. This suggests it was on the eastern side of the Nile delta.

Genesis 47:1–6

Pharaoh responded as Joseph hoped by giving Jacob's family the best part of the land; he even gave some of the brothers oversight of his own livestock (47:6).

Genesis 47:7–10

When Jacob entered and left Pharaoh's court, he blessed Pharaoh. This showed Jacob's role as God's representative (see Hebrews 7:7). God promised to bless those who blessed Abraham's family (Genesis 12:2–3), so Jacob blessed Pharaoh and Egypt.

Genesis 47:13–26

The Lord blessed Pharaoh because Pharaoh was blessing Abraham's descendants (12:3). Through Joseph's smart management in Egypt, the Lord saved the people from hunger and helped Pharaoh prosper. During the famine, Joseph sold food to the Egyptians, accepting money, livestock, and eventually land as payment. Then Pharaoh owned almost all of Egypt. Meanwhile, God gave Israel some of the best land in Egypt where they could live, work, and multiply.

Genesis 47:21

reduced the people to servitude: In Hebrew script, the words for slaves (Hebrew 'abadim) and towns (Hebrew 'arim) look very similar. Moving the people into the towns does not fit the context well, so most translations choose slaves as the reading that makes the most sense (compare 47:20).

Genesis 47:27

God blessed his people, just as he had promised Abraham. He said that Abraham's descendants would be too many to count (15:5; 22:17). But they still had to wait for the second part of the promise, that they would own the land of Canaan (17:8).

Genesis 47:29–31

- bury me with them: Compare 49:29–33. Jacob wanted to be buried with Abraham and Isaac in the cave of Machpelah (see study note on 49:29–33; see 23:1–20; 25:7–10; 35:27–29).
- put your hand under my thigh: This custom was a serious oath to continue the covenant (compare with 24:1–9 and study note on 24:2). The covenant's main promise was descendants in the promised land that would be too many to count.

Genesis 47:31

After taking the oath, Jacob bowed in worship and thanked the Lord for making sure he would be buried with his ancestors in the promised land (compare 1 Kings 1:47).

Genesis 48:1–22

When Jacob blessed Ephraim and Manasseh, he showed faith in God's promise to continue. He understood that God's ways differ from human ways. From Jacob's long life, the writer of Hebrews chose the blessing of Joseph's sons as his greatest act of faith (Hebrews 11:21). Jacob followed God's will by giving the main blessing to the younger son instead of the older one, without any trickery or negative outcomes.

Genesis 48:3–4

Jacob remembered how God Almighty appeared to him and promised him Abraham's blessing: countless descendants living in the land ... as an everlasting possession (compare 28:10–22).

Genesis 48:5–7

Jacob remembered Rachel (see 35:16–20) and blessed Joseph by making his two sons equal heirs with his other sons. The tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh would share equally with Jacob's other tribes (see Joshua 16–17). Jacob also gave Ephraim, Joseph's younger son, the birthright (see 1 Chronicles 5:1–2). Because of this blessing, Ephraim and Manasseh became large and powerful tribes (see Joshua 17:14–18).

Genesis 48:10

Like his father Isaac, Jacob now gave the blessing when his eyesight was failing (compare 27:1).

Genesis 48:14

The right hand was for the head of the firstborn, and Jacob was deliberately giving that position to the younger son. That pattern was followed for four consecutive generations:

- Isaac over Ishmael,
- Jacob over Esau,
- Joseph over Reuben, and
- Ephraim over Manasseh.

Many years later, Ephraim became the leading tribe in the northern kingdom, superior to the tribe of Manasseh. The entire northern kingdom of Israel was occasionally called Ephraim (see study notes on 2 Chronicles 28:12; Isaiah 11:13; Ezekiel 37:15–28; Hosea 6:4; Zechariah 9:10).

Genesis 48:15–16

When Jacob blessed Joseph, he used three titles to describe the God he trusted:

1. the God who was in covenant with his fathers Abraham and Isaac (28:13; 31:5, 42; 32:9; 46:3);
2. the God who had been his shepherd (one who guides and cares for his people; see 49:24; Exodus 6:6; Psalm 23:1; Isaiah 59:20); and
3. the angel (a messenger from God) who had rescued him from all harm.

Jacob prayed the same blessings for Joseph's sons.

Genesis 48:17–19

Not so, my father!: Joseph was upset because he expected God to act in a predictable way. But faith understands that God's ways and thoughts are different from human ones. Jacob spent his life learning this lesson, but he eventually understood and acted on it.

Genesis 48:22

Joseph was later buried at Shechem as a sign that this extra portion of land belonged to him (Joshua 24:32). It seems that Jacob had conquered this area, though the event is not mentioned elsewhere.

Genesis 49:1–2

Jacob's words were carefully chosen prophecies. The days to come refer to the conquest and settlement of the promised land and the future messianic age. All tribes would share in the blessing and enter the land with Joshua. But they would not all participate in the same way.

Genesis 49:1–28

By faith, and as one who speaks for God, Jacob looked ahead to Israel's future in the land and beyond to a greater future still.

At the end of the time of the patriarchs (the early fathers of Israel), he spoke about what would happen to each tribe. He did this as he considered each of his sons, one by one, just as Noah had done earlier (compare 9:25–27).

The character and actions of each ancestor affected the lives of their descendants (Exodus 20:5–6; 34:6–7; Numbers 14:18; Jeremiah 32:18).

Genesis 49:3–4

Uncontrolled as the waters: As the firstborn, Reuben should have led the family. But he acted without control, like water that boils or flows wildly (for example, 35:22). Because of this, Jacob said that Reuben would not succeed as a leader (see 37:21–22, 29; 42:22, 37–38; compare Judges 5:15–16; 1 Chronicles 5:1–2).

Genesis 49:5–7

- Simeon and Levi were violent and lawless. Instead of seeking justice, they allowed their uncontrolled anger to control them and ignored the value of life (34:24–29).
- I will disperse them: Simeon's land mostly became part of Judah's (Joshua 19:1, 9). Levi was given a more honorable future because the Levites became the priestly tribe (see Exodus 32:25–29). But they did not have their own region (Joshua 21).

Genesis 49:8–12

The blessing for Judah is the most notable. In this message, Jacob said that Judah would be strong like a lion and would defeat his enemies. His brothers would also honor and praise him (compare 29:35; see, for example, Ruth 4:11–12; 1 Samuel 18:6–7; Psalms 2, 45, 72; Isaiah 11:1–13).

Genesis 49:10

- This verse anticipates the kingship in Judah (compare 17:6, 16; 35:11). Although Joseph received the birthright blessing, Judah would provide Israel's rulers (see 1 Chronicles 5:1–2). Many kings from Judah would hold the scepter, the symbol of rule. The final king would be the one to whom the scepter belongs, the promised Messiah (see 2 Samuel 7:4–16; Psalms 2, 45, 60; Isaiah 11; Ezekiel 21:26–27; Zechariah 9:9; Revelation 5:5).
- from between his feet: This is a poetic way to refer to reproductive organs.
- until Shiloh comes and the allegiance of the nations is his: This wording reflects a long-standing way of understanding a difficult Hebrew phrase. Other translations include until the coming of the one to whom it belongs or until tribute is brought to him and the peoples obey.

The right to rule Israel belongs to Judah's descendant through David's line (2 Samuel 7:8–16). He will eventually rule all nations, as shown by the bringing of tribute (see Psalms 68:29; 72:8–11; Isaiah 2:2–4; Ephesians 4:8–10).

Genesis 49:11–12

- These descriptions describe the abundance of the Messiah's kingdom (see Isaiah 61:6–7; 65:21–25; Zechariah 3:10). When the Messiah arrives, the earth will be like paradise, full of beauty and abundance.
- He ties his donkey to the vine: Grapevines will be so plentiful that people will use them as hitching posts, and wine will be as plentiful as fresh water (see Amos 9:13–14; Zechariah 3:10).
- His eyes are darker than wine, and his teeth are whiter than milk: He will be strong and healthy, as will be the time of his rule. The miracle of turning water into wine was the first sign from Jesus that the Messiah had arrived (John 2:1–12). It was a preview of even better things to come.

Genesis 49:13

The message said Zebulun would live by the sea and be a safe harbor. But when the land was divided, the tribe settled inland instead (see Joshua 19:10–16). The message did not give specific borders for the tribes.

Genesis 49:14–15

Issachar would become a tribe that had to do hard work for others. Invading armies often controlled Issachar.

Genesis 49:16–17

Dan (meaning "judge") was meant to bring justice. But the tribe chose betrayal, like a snake by the road, striking in a dangerous and unexpected way (see Judges 18).

Genesis 49:18

At this point, Jacob paused to speak words of hope. He may have been reminding his sons of their need to depend on the Lord. Or he may have been expressing hope in the Messiah's reign, when he and his descendants would be rescued from all trouble, grief, and human betrayal.

Genesis 49:19

Three of the six Hebrew words in this verse are wordplays on the name Gad, which means "attack." Gad will be attacked by raiding groups, but he will also attack them back. The tribes living east of the Jordan River often experienced raids on their borders (see Joshua 13; 2 Kings 10:32–33; 1 Chronicles 5:18–19).

Genesis 49:20

Asher would be fertile and productive, providing rich foods. The tribe settled along the rich northern coast of Canaan.

Genesis 49:21

Naphtali was like a doe. This may mean the tribe would live as a free people in the mountains (compare Judges 5:18). The tribe of Naphtali settled in the hill country northwest of the Sea of Galilee.

Genesis 49:22–26

This message about Joseph is longer and more detailed than the others, because it contains the main blessing(see 1 Chronicles 5:1–2). Jacob gave Joseph many promises of victory and success.

Some from the tribe of Ephraim who later won victories in battle include Joshua (Joshua 6, 8, 10, 12) and Deborah (Judges 4). From the tribe of Manasseh, Gideon (Judges 6–8) and Jephthah (Judges 11:1–12:7) were also victorious leaders.

Genesis 49:24–26

the Mighty One of Jacob ... the Shepherd ...the Rock of Israel ... the God of your father ... the Almighty: Five names for God introduce five blessings. God is the giver of all good things.

Genesis 49:25

- The blessings from the heavens brought rain for crops.
- The blessings of the depths below provided streams and wells.
- The blessings of the breasts and womb led to many children.

Genesis 49:26

Joseph ... the prince of his brothers: He is a leader among his brothers, showing his strong character and high status.

Genesis 49:27

The oracle about Benjamin describes a violent tribe (see Judges 20; 1 Samuel 9:1–2; 19:10; 22:17).

Genesis 49:28

These prophecies cover a wide range, predicting the future of various tribes in general terms. Individuals could receive great blessings from God through faith and obedience, no matter what happened to their clan.

Genesis 49:29–33

Bury me with my fathers: This grave in the land of Canaan represented hope for the future (compare 47:29–30). Others buried at the cave of Machpelah near Hebron were:

- Sarah (23:19),
- Abraham (25:7–9),
- Isaac (35:27–29),
- Rebekah, and
- Leah.

Genesis 49:33

Jacob died at the age of 147 (47:28), bringing his life of struggle and sorrow to an end. Jacob had always had a strong desire for God's blessing. He had a deep devotion and consistently relied on God no matter what happened.

In the end, he died with genuine faith. He learned where true blessings come from. Through his faith, he would be able to pass these blessings on to his sons (Hebrews 11:21).

Genesis 50:1–6

Like his father and his grandfather, Jacob's death marked the end of an important time in Israel's history.

Genesis 50:2

Jacob's body was embalmed for burial in typical Egyptian fashion. Embalming is the process of preserving a body after death.

Genesis 50:3

The Egyptians mourned Jacob for 70 days, just two days less than they would for a pharaoh. This showed their great respect for Joseph.

Genesis 50:4–6

Joseph needed Pharaoh's permission to leave his official duties for a short time. He wanted to bury his father in Canaan.

Pharaoh quickly gave permission to Joseph, who had once been a slave.

Genesis 50:7–9

This was Joseph's first return to his homeland in 39 years. The trip was temporary. Hundreds of years later, the family of Israel would permanently leave Egypt, taking Joseph's bones with them for burial in the promised land (see 50:25).

Genesis 50:10–13

This journey to Canaan was a sorrowful one, because they went there to bury a man. The next journey into the land would be to live there.

Genesis 50:15–18

The brothers begged Joseph to forgive them, referring to themselves as his slaves (compare 37:7; 44:16, 33). They worried that Joseph had only made peace with them earlier because he wanted to see his father again. Now that Jacob and Pharaoh were not there to restrain him, they feared he might seek revenge. But Joseph wept because they still feared he would punish them.

Genesis 50:19–21

Joseph comforted his brothers, explaining that God intended to fulfill the promised blessing (compare 45:5, 7–9). He also promised them kindness and support (see 45:11).

Genesis 50:22–23

Joseph lived to see his great-great-grandchildren by Ephraim, and his great-grandchildren by Manasseh. This was a sign of God's blessing (see Psalm 128:6; Proverbs 17:6; Isaiah 53:10).

Genesis 50:23

were brought up on Joseph's knees: Placing them on his knees at their birth was a symbolic act signifying that they came from him and belonged to him (compare Job 3:12).

Genesis 50:24–25

- God will surely visit you: These words from Joseph are repeated twice. They summarize the hope found in both the Old Testament and the New Testament. God would come to his people and act to save them.

God's coming in the Messiah (the promised descendant of Abraham and God's chosen king) would bring an end to the curse (the result of sin) and bring God's promised blessing in a new creation (a renewed world). God's faithful people would wait with hope for this to happen.

- Like his father, Joseph made his brothers promise to take his bones out of Egypt when God came to lead them back to Canaan ("attend to you"; see Exodus 13:19; Joshua 24:32; Hebrews 11:22).

Genesis 50:26

- Joseph's death signified the end of his generation (see study notes on 25:7–8; 35:1–29) and of the patriarchal age. From this point forward, God dealt with Israel as a nation. •
- Joseph's body stayed in Egypt as a symbol of hope for slaves awaiting the promised land (see Exodus 13:19; Hebrews 11:39–40). They eventually buried him in Shechem (see Joshua 24:32), where Jacob had originally sent him (Genesis 37:13).